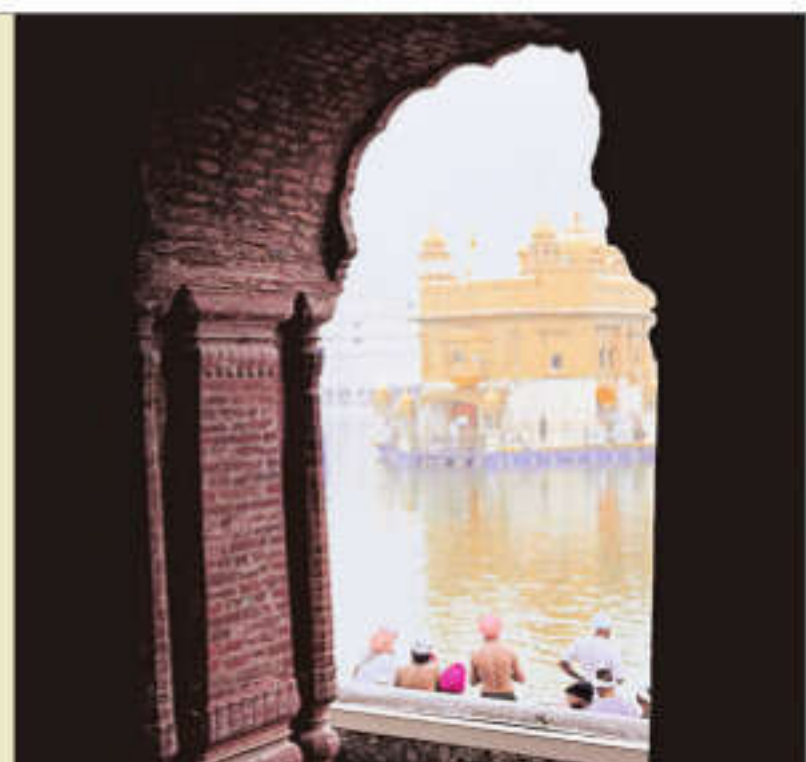


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The Sunday EXPRESS

**EYE**

FINDING AMRITSAR

Tracing the city that's home to one of the most notable places of pilgrimage, Amritsar unravels as a place that was built to be a refuge for all — before it became an epicentre for all of Punjab

SCREEN

Gurvinder Singh on reimagining Ajeet Cour's short stories for his latest directorial *Rehmat*



DAILY FROM: AHMEDABAD, CHANDIGARH, DELHI, JAIPUR, KOLKATA, LUCKNOW, MUMBAI, NAGPUR, PATNA, PUNE, VADODARA

Happening today

● **KARNATAKA CHIEF** Minister D K Shivakumar has called an all-party meeting over the Cauvery water-sharing issue. The state has been ordered to release 3,500 cusecs of water daily to Tamil Nadu.

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NATION

PAGES 6, 9



ANDHRA POISED TO EMERGE AS MAJOR MANUFACTURING HUB, SAYS PM

'Rs 1,800-CR LOSS TO EPFO': CBI BOOKS RELIANCE CAPITAL, ANIL AMBANI

KIN OF ONE OF THE TWO DEAD CLAIMS TERRORISTS ENQUIRED ABOUT NAMES, RELIGION

Manhunt in Valley as terror attack claims 2; TRF link being probed

Kulgam village cordoned off as search ops on; LG calls meeting with top security brass

Bashaarat Masood
Srinagar, August 1

AT HABLISHI, a village two kilometres ahead of South Kashmir's Kilam area, where two migrant workers were shot dead by terrorists on Friday, the road is blocked by armoured vehicles of J&K Police and the Army. No one is allowed to enter or exit.

Almost immediately after the attack on Friday evening, a joint team of police, Army and paramilitary forces had cordoned off the village and launched massive search operations.

The targeted killing, the first



Security personnel conduct a cordon-and-search operation a day after the terror attack in Kulgam, Saturday. SHUAIB MASOODI

attack on seasonal migrant workers since October 2024, has sent the security apparatus into overdrive. Across the Valley, security forces have intensified surveillance, expanding their footprint and stepping up vigilance around the areas where migrants live and work.

The attack has prompted an urgent security rethink, with Lt Governor Manoj Sinha conven-

ing a high-level meeting of the security establishment to re-view the situation and chart the response.

Hablishi and Kilam, twin villages in south Kashmir's Kulgam, are dotted with nearly a dozen brick kilns tucked away in secluded pockets away from residential areas. Hundreds of labourers from North India,

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

In Valley for better pay, the two migrants who never made it back

Jayprakash S Naidu & Saurabh Parashar
Sakti, Shimla, August 1

DRIVEN BY the search for better-paying work outside Chhattisgarh, two young labourers travelled over 1,500 km to a brick kiln in Jammu and Kashmir's Kulgam district. On Friday evening, that journey ended in tragedy when terrorists shot them dead after allegedly verifying their identities.

For the family of Deepak Ratre, 24, the pain is compounded by the fact that he was cremated in Kashmir and his body was not brought home.

According to his uncle, Diharhar Sande, Deepak's father died by suicide when he was



Deepak Ratre and Bhupinder Bhaina were from Chhattisgarh

four years old, following which Deepak, his mother and younger brother moved in with his uncles' families in Hardidh village in Chhattisgarh's Sakti district.

"His younger brother is disabled since birth. We looked after their education, work and

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

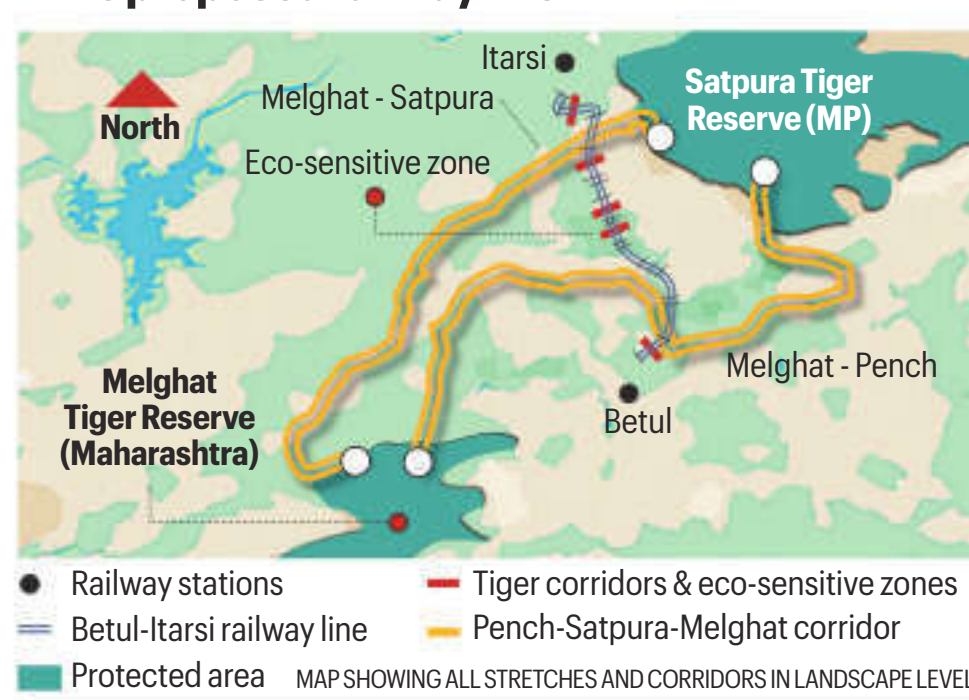
Railway line through key tiger corridor gets in-principle approval, with a rider

Nikhil Ghanekar
New Delhi, August 1

CENTRAL INDIA'S key tiger corridor between the Satpura and Melghat tiger reserves stands to be fragmented because in-principle wildlife clearance for a third railway line between Jujharpur and Chichonda in Madhya Pradesh has been recommended by the Standing Committee of the National Board for Wildlife (SC-NBWL).

The clearance is subject to the condition that mitigation structures — such as overpasses for safe passage of wildlife across the rail alignment — suggested by the Central Rail-

● The proposed railway line



way are reviewed and finalised based on proper scientific study and engineering designs, according to the minutes of the SC-NBWL's July 9 meeting.

The proposed railway line will pass through two notified tiger corridors, and an eco-sensitive zone in the Satpura-Melghat landscape, according to official documents. The Satpura tiger reserve is in Madhya Pradesh while the Melghat tiger reserve is in Maharashtra.

Tiger corridors provide safe pathways for many wildlife species including tigers, leopards, herbivores, sloth bears, helping the animals disperse to

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

THE WORLD



SPAIN INSTALLS BARRIER AFTER BORDER RUSH FROM MOROCCO

RUSSIAN ATTACK KILLS AT LEAST 10 AS KYIV SEEKS INTERCEPTORS

PAGE 8

Cong's Punjab headache: Channi, Warring supporters in free-for-all

Clash in Sangrur, nearly come to blows in Patiala in presence of Baghel

Man Aman Singh Chhina
Chandigarh, August 1

IN AN ugly turn to the rivalry between senior Congress leaders in Punjab, supporters of PCC president Amrinder Singh Raja Warring and former Chief Minister Charanjit Singh



PCC president Amrinder Singh Raja Warring addresses party workers at an event in Patiala on Saturday. X/@INCPUNJAB

Channi clashed Saturday at a party meeting in Sangrur and nearly came to blows in Patiala

in the presence of Bhupesh Baghel, AICC general secretary

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

● ALSO FIRST TO WIN MEDALS IN TWO DIFFERENT TRACK AND FIELD EVENTS AT COMMONWEALTH GAMES

With a strapped knee, Tejaswin becomes first Indian to win CWG decathlon medal

PAGE 1 anchor

Prithish Raj
New Delhi, August 1

"I WON'T cry today," Tejaswin Shankar said after becoming the first Indian decathlete to win a medal at the Commonwealth Games on Friday night.

Just four days ago, his CWG journey in Glasgow, Scotland, had almost ended in heartbreak before it even began when he pulled out of the individual high jump event due to patellar tendinitis, a painful injury commonly known as Jumper's knee.



Tejaswin Shankar competes in the decathlon long jump event at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow, Scotland. PTI

Yet, despite performing at '80 per cent' fitness, Tejaswin persevered over two days, winning a

bronze in decathlon, a grueling 10-event competition to determine the best all-round athlete

SPORT

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INDIAN BOXERS SCRIPT GLORY IN SCOTLAND

in track and field, and even registering two personal bests in discus throw and long jump.

He is also the first Indian athlete to win medals in two different track and field events at the CWG. Four years ago in Birmingham, he won a bronze in high jump — it was also a first for India at the CWG — before becoming a multi-event athlete. He later won a silver in

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



NATION

SIX DEAD, ANOTHER SIX MISSING AS HEAVY RAINFALL BATTERS KERALA
PAGE 7

KRACKJACK JOKE #2

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Union Home Minister Amit Shah felicitates NSA Ajit Doval with the Lokmanya Tilak National Award 2026 in Pune on Saturday. Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis and Deputy CMs Sunetra Pawar and Eknath Shinde are also present. ANI

‘Big contribution in foreign policy’: Shah confers Lokmanya Tilak Award on Doval

Soham Shah
Pune, August 1

UNION HOME Minister Amit Shah said on Friday that National Security Advisor Ajit Doval had played a big role in India's foreign policy. Shah said this at the Lokmanya Tilak National Award 2026 in Pune, where he presented the award to Doval. "Today, India's foreign policy is one that has a spine. No one can deny this. With respect, we have strengthened our position in the world. And in this achievement of the Modi government, Ajit Doval has made a big contribution," Shah said. Speaking about Lokmanya Tilak, Shah said that he gave a new direction to the Indian freedom struggle and laid a strong foundation for national-

ism, education, journalism, and social awakening. "His conviction continues to inspire every Indian today and serves as a guiding principle for building a developed and capable India," he added. He said that Tilak's message of "Swaraj is my birthright" should be transformed into a national resolve for a developed India in the present times. "Today those who talk of rights don't know that if we misuse them, then the souls of those who sacrificed a lot for us to get these rights will likely be troubled," he said. Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, Deputy Chief Ministers Eknath Shinde and Sunetra Pawar, and Pune MP and Union Minister Muralidhar Mohol were present at the event.

Mediation is key to accessible, dignified justice: CJI in Jaipur



Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Rajasthan Chief Minister Bhajan Lal Sharma in Jaipur. ROHIT JAIN PARAS

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, August 1

CHIEF JUSTICE of India (CJI) Surya Kant on Saturday made a strong case for mediation as an integral part of the justice delivery system, saying the rule of law seeks to ensure timely, accessible and dignified justice rather than adjudication of every dispute. Addressing the Commonwealth Peace Mediation Conference in Jaipur, the CJI said the justice system must prioritise outcomes that are efficient, humane and accessible to all. "The Rule of Law does not demand that every grievance be adjudicated, it demands only that every citizen enjoy timely, accessible, and dignified recourse to justice," he said. Highlighting the advantages of mediation over adversarial processes, he emphasised the autonomy it gives to disputing parties in crafting their own solutions. "Mediation alone permits the parties themselves to

author their own resolution, addressing the true sources of conflict at a pace and cost proportionate to the dispute. He noted that mediation enables a shift away from rigid legal positions towards a more meaningful resolution of disputes, especially in situations where preserving relationships is important. The also underscored the broader philosophical and practical relevance of mediation, suggesting that such approaches align with both modern needs and longstanding traditions of dispute resolution. He expressed confidence that mediation would continue to grow in importance as legal systems evolve to handle increasing caseloads and complex disputes. Referring to the enduring relevance of such mechanisms, he said they represent "a tradition as old as our ancient heritage and as urgent as Monday morning's docket". The CJI concluded his address on a note of optimism, extending his best wishes for the success of the conference.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Manhunt in Valley

mainly Bihar and Uttar Pradesh, arrive every year to work at these kilns, living in modest accommodations or on-site. Friday's attack took place at one such brick kiln. Police officers say they are yet to establish who carried out the attack, but maintain that only the Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT) retains a limited presence in the Valley. Officers say they are also investigating the anonymous social media posts in which The Resistance Front (TRF), which police say is a shadow group of the Lashkar, has claimed responsibility for the killings. "Most attacks of this nature in recent years have been carried out by the TRF, and in many cases they claimed responsibility publicly," said a police officer. "There are inputs that (Lashkar commander) Latif (Bhat) was involved in the attack, but we are investigating all possible angles." Police sources also said this

is a typical TRF strategy. "When the government or political leadership indicates things are getting better, they strike. Two aspects are unique to their attacks: one, they are targeted at people from outside Jammu and Kashmir; two, these attacks are generally below a certain critical level, but keep the fire simmering," said a source, who did not wish to be identified. The Amarnath Yatra is half-way through, and the government has been keen to make it a benchmark for spiritual tourism. "We will respond to such terror attacks with full force," the source said, adding that they have further tightened security and increased vigilance. According to police sources, Deepak Rathe, 24, and Bhupinder Bhaina, 25, were sitting near the brick kiln, outside the sheds where they stayed, when a man approached them. The wife of one of the victims is learnt to have told police that the man, who had a bag with

him, engaged them in conversation. After some time, the women went inside, and soon after, gunshots rang out. The man, they said, had escaped. On Saturday, Lt Governor Sinha chaired a security review meeting attended by top officials, including Chief Secretary Atal Dulloo and the Director General of Police Nalin Prabhat. "He directed the top security brass to conduct a comprehensive review of Standard Operating Procedures established to protect the labourers from outside Jammu and Kashmir," an official release issued by the Lok Bhawan said. "He also directed that the employers must ensure all workers from other states and UTs are provided insurance and that their details are registered with local police and district authorities." He also directed police to "intensify precise, high-impact, anti-terror operations to neutralise terrorists". Across the Valley, searches, frisking and checking of vehicles have been intensified. While there are no official figures for the number of mi-

grant seasonal labourers working in Kashmir, estimates put the figure at anything between three and five lakh during the peak season, which lasts from April to October. These workers are largely employed in the construction or agriculture sectors, brick kilns, and small trade. In the last six years, over 20 non-local workers were killed and another 20 injured in terror attacks across Kashmir. While Friday's attack in Kulgam has caused anxiety among migrant workers, they say it is too early to decide whether to leave the Valley. "Yesterday's attack has brought back some fears," says Vikramjit Singh, a carpenter from Amritsar in Punjab. "We will stay for now. We will keep a close watch, and if something happens again, we may think about leaving Kashmir." For Mithilesh Kumar, a construction worker from Bihar, leaving the Valley is not an option. "I have been coming to Kashmir for 15 years now. I have lived here in the most difficult times," he says. "If we leave, our families will die of hunger."

The two workers who never made it back home

marriage. Our biggest pain is that we never got a chance to bid him goodbye," Sande said. The two labourers were shot from point-blank range at a brick kiln in Kulgam on Friday evening. According to Ganpat Bhaina, the maternal uncle of the second victim, Bhupinder Bhaina, 25, the attackers first verified the identities of the workers before opening fire. "Before killing them, the terrorists asked them their names and religion, and checked their Aadhaar cards," he claimed. "They called them out of their jhuggis while their wives were probably preparing food." Ganpat, who also works in Kashmir and spoke to *The Indian Express* over the phone, said he learnt about the sequence of events from a relative working near the brick kiln where the attack took place. "The son of my close relative works there. I work at another brick kiln around 50 kilometres away," he said. He added that the bodies of both victims were handed over

after legal formalities and cremated in Kulgam. Deepak had travelled to Kashmir for work five times. Before leaving for Kashmir in June, he had also worked in Punjab and Himachal Pradesh. He and his wife earned around Rs 1,000 a day in Kashmir depending on available work, compared with around Rs 600 a day in Chhattisgarh, where work was also less certain. His mother worked alongside the couple while his disabled younger brother looked after their two-year-old child. His uncles were employed at another site around 50-70 km from where Deepak was killed. Deepak had hoped to build a house of his own and was also repaying a marriage loan of Rs 50,000. For Bhupinder Bhaina, this was his first visit to Kashmir. He had been working there for the last four to five months after previously working as a construction labourer in Himachal Pradesh's industrial town of Baddi. He had travelled to Kul-

gam with his wife to make bricks, leaving behind their young son with his minor sister in Chhattisgarh. Bhupinder was critically injured in Friday's attack. He was initially admitted to Government Medical College, Anantnag, and later referred to SKIMS Srinagar after surgery, where he succumbed to his injuries on Saturday morning. Originally from Chhuiha village in Chhattisgarh's Saranagar-Bilaigarh district, Bhupinder was the eldest of three siblings. He had dropped out of school in Class VIII, while his younger brother, Anurag, left school in Class IX. "My brother had been working in Jammu and Kashmir for the last four to five months. On Friday night, I received a call from my maternal uncle, Ganpat, informing me that Bhupinder had been shot by terrorists. He has left behind his wife and their young son," Anurag, who works as a welder in Baddi, told *The Indian Express*. Describing the family's fi-

nancial difficulties, Anurag said their parents, Dashrath Bhaina and Nageshwari Bhaina, are living with him in Baddi and are in poor health. "Our parents are not well, and we are not in a position to travel to Kashmir. The authorities informed us that my brother's last rites would be performed there," he said. "This was only the second time my brother had gone outside Chhattisgarh for work. He had earlier worked in Himachal Pradesh three years ago," Anurag said. Asked about the wage difference, he said labourers earn around Rs 150-250 more per day outside Chhattisgarh. Chhattisgarh CM Vishnu Deo Sai announced an ex gratia of Rs 20 lakh each for the families of the two victims, describing the attack as an assault on humanity and the unity of the nation. He said necessary directions had been issued to officials and assured the families that the state government would extend all possible assistance.

Punjab Cong fight

in-charge for Punjab where Assembly elections are due next year. Supporters of Channi shouted slogans in favour of the former CM and sitting Jalandhar MP as soon as Warring and Baghel arrived at the Sangrur meeting venue. Soon, a free-for-all broke out with people pushing and shoving, flinging chairs at each other. As the two sides confronted each other, Warring appealed for peace. "If you think you can bring down Raja Warring by shouting slogans, then you are mistaken," he said. Speaking to reporters in Sangrur, Dr Sukhwinder Singh, a Channi supporter, said the Congress high command and Baghel were not paying heed to the sentiments of the people on the ground. "People want Channi to be the CM face of the party. Today when we raised slogans in his favour, Warring called us sold-out agents of (CM) Bhagwant Mann. We are fourth generation Congressmen. At this rate, if Warring remains party president, we will have to move out," he said. Earlier in the day, at a meeting in Patiala, similar scenes were witnessed when supporters of Channi raised slogans in his favour in the presence of Warring and Baghel. Channi supporters repeatedly chanted slogans of "Charanjit Singh Channi *Zindabad*" and "Channi *liaao*, Punjab *bachao*" (bring Channi, save Punjab) slogans. The sloganeering and hooting began as Warring started speaking. This disrupted the scheduled programme. Visibly upset, Warring

asked why slogans were being raised. He warned that disciplinary action would be taken against those disrupting party programmes. He was heard asking "*koi* problem *hai*, *koi* problem *hai*" (is there any problem) while pointing towards a person in the crowd raising slogans in favour of Channi. There was some jostling between the supporters of Channi and Warring even as speakers from the dais kept asking everyone "not to spoil the atmosphere". The fight within the party came out in the open during the 'Har booth Congress mazboot', one in a series of weekend events to launch the Congress's 2027 election mission. A July 9 PCC letter, suspending former MLA Madan Lal Jalalpur, a Channi supporter, also surfaced Saturday. Jalalpur had been demanding the removal of Warring and was suspended for anti-party activities.

Baghel is on a 10-day visit to the state and is holding meetings in various cities to launch the poll campaign. In his speech, Warring said, "I will make efforts in the coming days to ensure that everyone is on the same stage... It is also important to not lose cool in the enthusiasm," he said. Baghel said the future Chief Minister and other ministers will be chosen by the Congress high command including party president Mallikarjun Kharge and Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi. The duty of the Congress leaders and workers, he said, is to ensure the victory of the party because "Punjab needs to be saved from the misrule of the Aam Aadmi Party government". Calling for unity in the party, he said there can be differences within a party like within a family, but the actual fight of the party is against the BJP, the AAP and the Akalis.

First Indian to win CWG decathlon medal

decathlon at the Asian Games and a silver and a bronze at the Asian Championships, leaving only a CWG medal in this intense event missing from his collection. "Today, I am standing with a medal around my neck, I have no words. This is just unreal," Tejaswin said after winning the bronze Friday. "When I was standing there crying (after pulling out of high jump), those were tears of giving up. I was thinking one year is gone, the Commonwealth Games are gone, maybe the Asian Games are gone too. I went down a very negative spiral." Given the circumstances—a knee injury and a strong field, including the Tokyo Olympic champion Damien Warner of Canada and Paris Olympics bronze medallist and reigning CWG champion Lindon Victor of Grenada—Tejaswin's 7,976 points for third place was a gritty performance. Victor got the gold with 8,096 points and Warner the silver with 8,036 points. A fully fit Tejaswin could have changed the colour of his medal given that his national record is 8,057 points. Despite the injury setback, however, Tejaswin's comeback was a tale of remarkable resilience, with his support staff doing all to get him up and running. His strength and conditioning coach Wayne Lombard was in Glasgow and played a key role in Tejaswin's recovery, ensuring he didn't lose heart when the going got tough. Indian team doctor Dr Dinshaw Pardiwala, an orthopedic surgeon, kept a close watch on Tejaswin's knee and prescribed anti-inflammatory medicines. "I would say it's the performance of the Commonwealth Games. To win a decathlon medal with 80% fitness tells you what it takes to be an elite-level athlete," Lombard told *The Indian Express* Saturday. "Tejaswin had thought that he had let every one down. I haven't seen him this disappointed ever. We threw everything we had to make sure that he is ready by the time the decathlon starts," said Wayne. For Tejaswin's decathlon, Wayne said the team "wanted to keep the strain on the knee as

low as possible." "We wanted to make sure that the discomfort and the pain he was feeling was not too significant. So, between the anti-inflammatories, a lot of icing, and then a lot of rehab, we did a few micro-dosed rehab sessions," he said. Moral support came from long jumper Sreesankar Murali. "When I went back completely broken, the one person who came up to me was Sreesankar. He had the same injury but a lot worse than mine. He told me to just take one event at a time," Tejaswin said. The competition was a mix of ups and downs for the decathlete. After barely making it to the 100m race with a heavily strapped knee, he clocked 10.96s and earned 870 points, placing him at the seventh spot. He fought back with a personal best in the second event, the long jump. He jumped 7.82 metres to improve on his previous best of 7.67m and moved to second spot with 1,015 points. After shot put, high jump and the 400-metre race at the end of Day 1, he was second with 4,339 points behind

Warner, who had 4,353 points. "When he ended Day 1, all we wanted was proper recovery for him. Thankfully, his knee was not much flared up. I told him that you have a medal shot, just let your body rest," said Wayne. Day 2 has always been more challenging for Tejaswin as it involves some of his weaker events, discus throw and pole vault. He threw a lifetime best of 40.44 metres in discus to stay second. However, despite a decent 4.30 metres, he was eighth in pole vault. But when it mattered the most, he fought back with 53.21 metres in javelin and clocked 4:36.19 to finish fifth in the 1,500-metre run. The last two events earned him 1,339 points, enough to better Ball by 83 points to win bronze. When asked why he decided to compete in both high jump and the decathlon, Tejaswin said, "*Yeh dil maange* more. High jump is good, but when you can do more, why not."

Small firms that make PVC pipes

are largely insulated from crude oil price swings. Queries emailed to the Commerce and Industry Ministry, Adani Group and Reliance Industries (RIL) remained unanswered. The DGFT notification sets a Minimum Import Price (MIP):S-PVC priced above \$0.76/kg remains freely importable for six months, while anything below that is restricted (barring Export Oriented Units, SEZs and the Advance Authorisation Scheme). This shuts out the cheapest suppliers—major exporters' prices are in the \$0.65-0.75/kg range, with China's the lowest, according to a Global Trade Research Initiative (GTRI) report. Chemical sector advisor Ajay Joshi linked the dumping to two factors: nearly 70% of China's PVC production uses the coal-based route, insulating it from oil and gas prices, and a domestic real estate slump has weakened Chinese demand. "With housing projects slowing, demand for pipes, plastic products, and consequently, PVC has weakened significantly. As a result, Chinese producers have been dumping excess material into India, driving PVC prices down to around \$700 per tonne," Joshi said. ICRA had flagged similar dumping from China, Indonesia, Japan, South Korea, Taiwan, Thailand and the US, last year. DCM Shriram defended the MIP as a floor, not a price-setter: "It only blocks distress-priced cargo from treating India as a dumping ground for their excess capacities... PVC resin is a small fraction of total project costs, and a six-month floor price cannot materially move project economics. The distress from dumping of PVC that the MIP addresses is real and well documented," the company said. The DGTR's MIP follows an earlier investigation last year after which anti-dumping duties ranging from \$22 to \$284 per tonne were recommended on August 14, 2025, on imports from China, Japan, Taiwan, South Korea, Thailand, Indonesia and the United States. Under Rule 18 of the Customs Tariff (Identification, Assessment and Collection of Anti-Dumping Duty on Dumped Articles and for Determination of Injury) Rules, 1995, the Ministry of Finance had three months to impose the duty through a customs notification. As no notification was issued by mid-November 2025, the DGTR recommendation lapsed. selling it at around Rs 82 per kg. As soon as the notification came, the domestic manufacturer hiked the prices to Rs 93 per kg," said Sharwan Kumar Kaler, Director at Rex Pipe and Cable Industries Ltd, and Vice President, Plastic Manufacturing Association, Rajasthan. The impact is widespread. India's PVC capacity is just 1.7 million metric tonnes (MMT) against demand of 4.7 MMT, a gap filled by imports from China, Japan, Taiwan, South Korea, Mexico and Indonesia. Reliance Industries is the largest domestic producer, accounting for 51% of capacity. Other players—Chemplast Sanmar, Finolex Industries, DCW Ltd and DCM Shriram—together hold 5-20%, according to rating agency ICRA. "The material is already in short supply. Now, with the government taking such steps, domestic industries will feel the pain, and prices will rise in the consumer market. If raw material prices go up, finished goods prices will follow," said Ajay Saboo, Executive Committee Member of the Federation of Indian Micro and Small & Medium Enterprises (FISME). Demand for PVC resin grew at a CAGR of 6.2% between FY20 and FY25. In 2024-25, demand rose 11%, driven by government housing and water-supply schemes such as the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana and Jal Jeevan Mission. Meanwhile, the Adani Group has announced plans to enter the sector, setting up a PVC plant in Mundra, Gujarat, through its subsidiary Mundra Petrochem Limited. The project began in 2021, but major equipment procurement and site construction were put on hold in 2023. Work on the Mundra project resumed in 2024, with an initial planned capacity of 1 million tonnes per annum, and commissioning expected by fiscal 2028. Reliance Industries currently makes PVC via the oil-derived ethylene route and plans to expand capacity to 1.5 MMT per annum by 2026-27. Adani Group, by contrast, is building a 2 MMT integrated PVC complex at Mundra using the coal-to-chemical (calcium carbide) route, with the first 1 MMT phase expected to start production in FY 2027-28. If Adani enters the PVC resin business, it would mark the first major petrochemical product in which Reliance and Adani compete directly in the Indian market. Industry experts say coal-based PVC production is cheaper because its economics

Rail line through key tiger corridor gets nod

newer landscape and aiding genetic flow of wildlife. A committee that inspected the alignment sites noted in its report to the SC-NBWL that the forest stretch and corridors are a lifeline for the Satpura-Pench-Melghat landscape, and hence the project should be seen in the context of current and future perspectives. The 160.6-km stretch between Juiharpur (Betul district) and Chichonda (Narmadapuram district), forms part of a longer 290-km third and fourth railway line on the busy Itarsi-Nagpur route, proposed by the Central Railway, Mumbai headquarters. The alignment passes through forest areas, two notified tiger corridors and an eco-sensitive zone. The project requires use of 206.09 hectares of land – 74.69 hectares of forest land and 131.4 hectares of non-forest land – falling in the notified tiger corridor. The proposal was earlier considered by the SC-NBWL at its 88th meeting on January 19. A final decision, though, was deferred as a site inspection was deemed necessary. The site inspection was carried out by officials from the Railways, Union Environment Ministry, a scientist from the Wildlife Institute of India, and an official from the National Tiger Conservation Authority. The site inspection committee's report stated that the Central Railway had proposed 34 wildlife overpasses along the rail line alignment. However, they were largely based on inputs from frontline forest staff, wildlife mortality records, rather than a detailed scientific study. The SC-NBWL's July 9 meeting minutes also noted that detailed engineering designs of these structures were yet to be finalised. "It was further observed that a comprehensive scientific assessment of the likely impacts of the project and the appropriate landscape-level mitigation measures had not been completed at the time of inspection. The State Forest Research Institute, Jabalpur, had been entrusted with the study, and its report was awaited," the minutes noted. Given the lack of a comprehensive study, the site inspection committee said that optimal, landscape-level mitigation measures were required, particularly considering that the Itarsi-Nagpur line expansion includes construction of a third as well as possibly a fourth line. The Chief Wildlife Warden of Madhya Pradesh informed the wildlife board panel that the state forest research institute had submitted a detailed report on mitigation measures and it was under consideration, and assured it would form the basis for overpass designs. The SC-NBWL also directed that upon receipt and examination of the scientific study and other relevant data, the site inspection committee shall revisit the project area and submit definitive recommendations regarding the location, dimensions, design and connectivity of the wildlife mitigation structures.

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AAP begins campaign against E20 policy, Kejriwal to march to PM house on Aug 4

Tabshir Shams
New Delhi, August 1

A STICK of raw sugarcane — this was what visitors received outside the Mavalankar Auditorium at Constitution Club in Delhi when they arrived for AAP's town hall against the Centre's E20 ethanol-blending policy on Saturday.

The message was clear, said Karol Bagh businessman Priyansh. "Sugarcane should be eaten, not put in your car," he added.

While people spoke to mediapersons with sugarcane in hand, a booth titled 'Rant Booth — #GanneKiBaat: Take out all your frustration against E20' invited them to record their views on the policy.

Around 11.30 am, inside the auditorium, every seat was occupied. AAP claimed more than seven lakh people watched the proceedings online.

On stage, politicians — including AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal and Delhi party chief Saurabh Bhardwaj — scientists, mechanics, automobile mechanics, farmers and vehicle owners took turns questioning the Centre's ethanol-blending programme. Kejriwal cited a survey by LocalCircles, a community platform. "Around 45,000 people participated in the survey.



Arvind Kejriwal addresses the town hall on Saturday. GAJENDRA YADAV

While 67% reported reduced mileage, 45% said the engines of their vehicles had been damaged because of E20," he said, calling for a discussion.

"The government should release its own data or studies on ethanol blending. It has not provided any evidence that it is beneficial," he added.

Kejriwal went on to link the push for ethanol blending to increased ethanol imports from the US under the India-US trade agreement.

Stepping up his campaign, he also announced that he would march to the Prime Minister's residence on August 4 to submit a petition containing two lakh signatures collected through an online campaign.

Environmental scientist Dr Anupam Sunny warned of the impact of expanding sugarcane cultivation for ethanol

production. Citing estimates by the Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change he said nitrous oxide released from nitrogen fertilisers used in sugarcane farming has a much higher global warming potential than carbon dioxide.

Amir, a mechanic, displayed a corroded carburettor that he claimed had been damaged by E20 fuel. He advised owners to avoid leaving vehicles unused for long periods and to keep fuel tanks relatively full. Jyotsna, who was introduced as an automobile industry expert, claimed that insurance policies do not cover engine damage linked to ethanol-blended petrol.

Sumit, who said he owns an E20-compatible Honda Shine motorcycle, claimed his vehicle had nevertheless suffered engine damage after the transi-

tion to E20 fuel.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, former Delhi minister Saurabh Bhardwaj said AAP was only demanding that consumers be allowed to choose between pure petrol and E20, and that ethanol-blended fuel be sold at a lower price. "We had raised these demands even before the Jantar Mantar protests (of the CJP against NEET-UG paper leak)," he said. Dismissing suggestions that the event marked AAP's political revival, he said, "AAP ka demise kabhi hua nahi tha (AAP never died). We were only one or two percentage points behind the BJP. We will bounce back fast."

Kejriwal reiterated AAP's three demands on X: Every petrol pump should offer both pure petrol and E20, E20 should cost less than pure petrol, and the price of pure petrol should remain below Rs 84 a litre.

Slamming Kejriwal for his remarks, Union Minister of State for Road Transport and Highways Harsh Malhotra, who heads Delhi BJP, said in a statement, "He claims to be an IIT graduate. But his statements make it seem as if he has not even studied at an industrial training institute (ITI). Had he been educated at IIT, he would not have opposed ethanol-blended petrol that helps the nation in so many ways."

MAJOR REJIG: 138 JUDGES SHIFTED

Special judge in fast-track court hearing NEET paper leak case transferred

Nirbhay Thakur
New Delhi, August 1

DAYS AFTER she was designated as a special judge in a fast-track court for paper leak cases, the Delhi High Court has transferred Judge Anu Grover Baliga. Special Judge Ajay Gupta will now hear the cases in the fast-track court, including NEET-UG 2026 paper leak cases. The rejig comes as a part of a major reshuffle in the Delhi Higher Judicial Service (DHJS).

Prime Minister Narendra Modi had announced the setting up of fast-track courts last week to tackle the cases of paper leaks following widespread protests against the issue.

The first hearing in Judge Baliga's fast-track court against 2026 NEET paper leak case was set to be held on July 27 but was adjourned following a request from the defence counsel. While the court has taken the chargesheet on record, a hearing on the chargesheet and on



Judge Anu Grover Baliga and Special Judge Ajay Gupta



the bail pleas of two accused was scheduled for August 3.

Judge Ajay Gupta was initially hearing the NEET paper leak case before the formation of fast-track courts.

Before her appointment at fast-track court, Judge Baliga was serving as Judge-in-Charge of the Mediation Centre, Central District, at Tis Hazari Courts. She

will now hear terror-related cases.

A total of 138 judges have been transferred via the High Court's notification on Saturday. As part of the reshuffle, 13 judges have been posted to Rouse Avenue Court to deal with matters under the Unlaw-

ful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA), National Investigation Agency (NIA) Act, Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act and Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act (MCOCA).

Of these, six judges are special NIA judges, who will exclusively hear terror cases. Across the Capital, more than 50 NIA cases are being heard, a vast majority of which were being heard before Additional Sessions Judge Prashant Sharma of Patiala House Court.

The six NIA judges are Anu Grover Baliga, Vikas Dhull, Prashant Sharma, Amit Bansal, Kiran Bansal and Pulastya Pramachala. These judges will take charge with effect from August 4. New NIA courts have been set up at Rouse Avenue Court and will be inaugurated on Monday.

• Skywatch



Forecast: August 2, 2026

Generally cloudy sky, spell

of very light to light rain

MAX: 32-34

0.4°C above normal

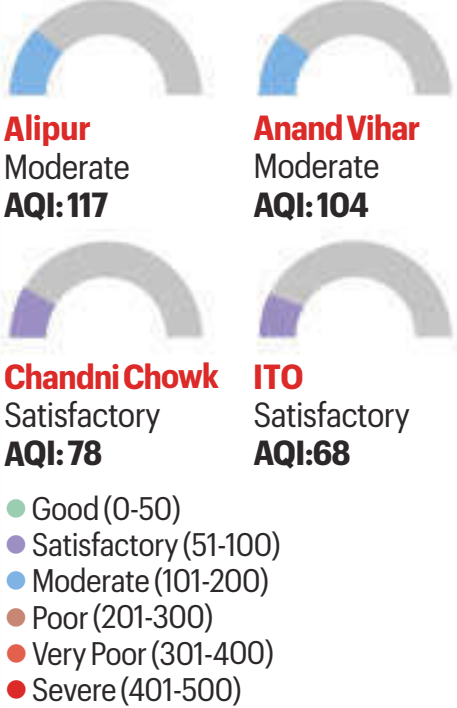
MIN: 25-27

2.1°C above normal

• Sunrise: 5:44 AM (August 3)

• Sunset: 7:12 PM (August 2)

• AQI Tracker



Above-normal rainfall, milder temperatures during daytime likely in Capital this month



India Gate after parts of Delhi-NCR received rain on Saturday. ANI

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 1

DELHI IS expected to witness a relatively milder August in terms of daytime temperatures even as nights are expected to remain warmer than usual, according to the India Meteorological Department's (IMD) monthly outlook. The Capital is also likely to record above-normal rainfall.

Monthly average maximum temperatures are likely to remain normal to below normal during August in parts of Northwest India, including Delhi-NCR.

This, however, stands in contrast to most parts of the country where daytime temperatures are expected to be above normal.

Across most of India, IMD expects August to be characterised by above-normal daytime temperatures, with only some areas of Northwest and Central India, along with isolated pockets of the southern peninsula, likely to record normal to below-normal maximum temperatures. Similarly, minimum temperatures are expected to stay normal to above normal across almost the entire country. But the overnight temperatures in the Capital are unlikely to see similar moderation.

While rainfall over the country as a whole is expected

to remain below normal in August, the IMD has forecast normal to above-normal rainfall over some parts of Northwest India, including Delhi-NCR.

The expected moderation in daytime temperatures is linked to enhanced cloud cover and intermittent rainfall associated with the Southwest Monsoon. However, higher humidity accompanying these conditions could keep nights warmer than average, limiting relief from sultry weather.

The monthly outlook comes after Northwest India experienced warmer-than-normal overall conditions in July.

According to the IMD data, the region recorded an average maximum temperature of 33.22°C, marginally above the normal of 33.08°C, while the average minimum temperature stood at 24.80°C, 0.72°C above normal. The mean temperature for the region was 29.01°C, about 0.43°C above normal.

On the rainfall front, the IMD expects the country to receive below-normal rainfall during August, defined as less than 94% of the long period average (LPA) of 254.9 mm. Despite this overall deficit, the forecast indicates that parts of Northwest India, East-Central India, the Northeast and the eastern peninsula region are likely to receive normal to above-normal rainfall.

Maharashtra Airport Development Company Ltd.
CIN: U45203MH2002SGC136979

TENDER NOTICE

MADC invites Tenders for Establishing Flying Training Organizations (FTO) at – Baramati, Dhule, Karad, Latur, Dharashiv and Yavatmal Airport.

The detailed tender document can be downloaded from the website www.mahatenders.gov.in from **03/08/2026, 05:00 PM.**

Sd/-
Vice Chairman and Managing Director

रेल विकास निगम लिमिटेड
Rail Vikas Nigam Limited
मुग्नवत्ता, गरि एवं पारवर्तिका
(A Government of India Enterprise)

RAIL VIKAS NIGAM LIMITED
(A Government of India Enterprise)

Registered office: World Trade Center, Tower A, 6th to 9th Floor, Nauroji Nagar, New Delhi- 110029 CIN: L74999DL2003GOI118633
Email: investors@rvnl.org Website: www.rvnl.org
Phone No.: 011-26738299, Fax: 011-26182957

NOTICE OF 23RD ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING, BOOK CLOSURE, RECORD DATE AND INFORMATION ON E-VOTING

Notice is hereby given that the 23rd Annual General Meeting (AGM) of the members of the Company will be held on **Tuesday, 25th August, 2026 at 11:00 A.M. (IST) through Video Conferencing ("VC")/ Other Audio Visual Means ("OAVM")** to transact the businesses as set forth in the Notice of the AGM. The Notice of AGM along with the Annual Report for the year ended on 31st March, 2026 has been sent by email only to the members whose email addresses are registered with the Company/Depository Participant(s) in compliance with the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 and SEBI (LODR) Regulations, 2015 read with General Circular No. 03/2025 dated 22nd September, 2025 and other circulars issued earlier in this regard.

Notice of the AGM and Annual Report are also available on the Company's Website: https://rvnl.org/RVNL_cms/uploads/Annualreport/23rd_annual_report_of_fy_202526.pdf and website of the stock exchanges i.e. BSE Limited & National Stock Exchange of India Limited on www.bseindia.com and www.nseindia.com. The Notice is also available on the website of Central Depository Services (India) Limited ("CDSL") on www.evotingindia.com.

Notice is also hereby given that Pursuant to Section 91 of the Companies Act, 2013 and Regulation 42 of the SEBI (LODR) Regulations, 2015, the Register of Members and Share Transfer Books of the Company will remain closed from **Wednesday, 19th August, 2026 to Tuesday, 25th August, 2026 (both days are inclusive)**. The Final Dividend as recommended by the Board of Directors, if declared at the AGM will be paid within 30 days from the conclusion of the AGM to those Members whose names appear in the Register of Members of the Company in respect of physical shares and in respect of dematerialized shares to the "beneficial owners" of the shares whose names appear in the Statement of Beneficial Ownership furnished by National Securities Depository Limited and Central Depository Services (India) Limited as at the ending of business hours on **Tuesday, 18th August, 2026. Payment of Dividend will be subject to deduction of Tax at Source (TDS) at applicable rates.** The details and documents for exemption from TDS are available on the company's website at www.rvnl.org the last date for submission of documents is **19th August, 2026.** For more details, please refer to the Notice of AGM. In accordance with the Section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013 read with Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014 and Regulation 44 of the SEBI (LODR) Regulations, 2015 and as per MCA Circular, the members are provided with the facility to cast their vote on all resolution set forth in the Notice of AGM using electronic voting system (remote e-voting and e-voting) provided by CDSL. Individual members holding securities in Demat mode are allowed to vote through their Demat Account maintained with their Depositories and Depository Participant(s).

- The remote E-voting period will commence on **Saturday, 22nd August, 2026 9:00 A.M. (IST) and ends on Monday, 24th August, 2026, 05:00 P.M. (IST).** The remote e-voting shall be disabled by CDSL thereafter and the facility will be blocked forthwith.
- The cut-off date for determining the eligibility to vote through remote E-voting or at the AGM will be **Tuesday, 18th August, 2026.** During remote e-voting period, shareholders of the company holding shares either in physical form or in dematerialized form, as on the cut-off date i.e. **Tuesday, 18th August, 2026** may cast their vote electronically. Once the vote on a resolution is casted by a Member, the Member shall not be allowed to modify it subsequently.
- Any person who has acquired shares and becomes Member of the Company after the Notice of AGM has been sent electronically but before the cut-off date of **Tuesday, 18th August, 2026**, may obtain their user ID and password by sending a request to www.evotingindia.com for procuring user ID and password for e-voting by providing the documents mentioned in the Notice of AGM.
- Those Members, who are present in the AGM through VC/OAVM facility and have not cast their votes on the resolutions through remote E-voting and are otherwise not barred from doing so, shall be eligible to vote through e-voting system during the AGM. The members who have not cast their vote by remote E-voting prior to the AGM may also attend/participate in the AGM through VC/OAVM but shall not be entitled to cast their vote again.
- The Company has engaged the services of Central Depository Services (India) Limited ("CDSL") as the agency to provide e-voting facility. M/s Kumar Naresh Sinha & Associates, Company Secretaries have been appointed as Scrutinizer for conducting the E-voting Process in a fair and transparent manner.
- The results of voting on resolutions shall be declared within two working days of the conclusion of the AGM of the Company.
- For Registration of Speaker, please refer Notice of AGM.

Members are requested to read the instructions pertaining to E-voting as printed in the AGM Notice carefully. In case of any query, you may refer to the Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs) for Shareholders and e-voting for Shareholders available at the download section of www.evotingindia.com or call on toll free no. 1800 21 099 11 or send a request to Mr. Rakesh Dalvi, AVP, Central Depository Services (India) Limited, at helpdesk.evoting@cdslindia.com

For Rail Vikas Nigam Limited
Sd/-
(Kalpana Dubey)
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

Place: New Delhi
Date: 01.08.2026

MUMBAI RAILWAY VIKAS CORPORATION LIMITED
2nd Floor, Churchgate Station Building, Mumbai - 400 020

VACANCY NOTIFICATION
NO. MRVC/E/AM (DESIGN)/ 22/2026 DATED 31.07.2026

Mumbai Railway Vikas Corporation Ltd. invited applications for filling up of 01 post of "Assistant Manager (Design)" in IDA E2 Scale on contractual basis. Last date for submission of application by mail is **30.08.2026.** For further details, please visit website <https://mrvc.indianrailways.gov.in>. Corrigendum, if any, will be posted on the website only.

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Rajan Anandan Managing Director at Peak XV Partners

Pratyush Kumar Co-founder and CEO of Sarvam AI

in conversation with **Anant Goenka** Executive Director, The Indian Express Group

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Woman run over by DTC bus, driver arrested

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 1

A 60-YEAR-OLD woman died after she was allegedly run over by a DTC bus near the Pooth Kalan bus stand in Outer Delhi on Saturday morning, said police. The incident triggered protests by her family members and locals who briefly blocked a key stretch, demanding the driver's arrest, and allegedly damaged the bus before police intervened and brought the situation under control, according to officers.

The deceased, Indira, was a resident of Sultanpuri. The bus driver, Rajesh, has been arrested.

According to officers, information about the accident was received through a PCR call at Sultanpuri police station around 11.05 am. A police team rushed to Kanjhawala Road near the Pooth Kalan bus stand where Indira was found unconscious beside the rear wheel of a DTC cluster bus operating on Route 114A between Azadpur and Auchandi Border. She was shifted to Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital in Mangolpuri, where doctors pronounced her dead on arrival.

Following the woman's death, her family members and several locals staged a protest at the accident site, leading to a temporary traffic disruption. During the agitation, some unidentified persons allegedly hurled stones at the bus and shattered its window panes.

Police personnel reached the spot and assured the protesters that appropriate legal action would be taken against the driver, after which the demonstration ended and vehicular movement resumed. Officers concerned have also initiated separate legal proceedings against those involved in vandalising the bus.

REGISTRATION PORTAL LAUNCHED

Women need endorsement letter from MP or MLA to avail Rs 2,500 monthly aid

Sophiya Mathew
New Delhi, August 1

WOMEN APPLYING for the Rekha Gupta government's flagship Delhi Lakshmi Yojana will have to submit an endorsement letter from the MP or MLA of their constituency, according to fresh eligibility conditions unveiled in the scheme's registration portal that was launched on Saturday.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta launched the portal at the East Delhi District Magistrate's office. Under the scheme, eligible women will receive Rs 2,500 every month.

Speaking at the launch, Gupta said every application would undergo a four-stage verification process to ensure that "only genuine beneficiaries" receive assistance.

Applications will first be scrutinised by the District Programme Management Unit, followed by verification by the District Women and Child Development Officer, before being placed before the District-Level Approval, Monitoring and Grievance Redressal Committee for a final nod.

The CM said the verification process would include Aadhaar authentication, Delhi voter registration, annual family income, family details, electricity consumption, vehicle ownership, pension status and government service records. She said false declarations or fraudulent claims would invite recovery of the financial assistance along with legal and administrative action.

Within hours of the portal going live, officials said more than 33,700 women had regis-



Chief Minister Rekha Gupta during the launch of the portal on Saturday. X/@GUPTA_REKHA

tered. Among them, 1,940 had completed the application process, while another 9,170 applications were awaiting MLA recommendations, they added.

The scheme, approved for an initial period of three years, is expected to cover nearly 17 lakh women. Beneficiaries can either receive Rs 1,000 in a Central Bank Digital Currency (CBDC) wallet and Rs 1,500 in a recurring deposit (RD) or fixed deposit (FD) account every month, or choose to have the entire Rs 2,500 deposited into an RD or FD for long-term savings.

The government has also placed spending restrictions on the CBDC wallet. Money credited to the wallet cannot be used to purchase alcohol, to-

bacco, narcotic substances, lottery tickets, gambling or betting services, or other prohibited goods and services.

Among one of the major eligibility conditions imposed is a three-child cap – an exclusion criterion that is uncommon among major social welfare schemes in Delhi.

It has drawn criticism from Opposition parties and civil society groups.

The other conditions are applicants must be the eldest eligible woman in the family, aged between 21 and 60 years, belong to a household with an annual income of not more than Rs 2.5 lakh, have at least 10 years' residence in Delhi, their parents or husband, be regis-

tered voters in the Capital. Also, a recent electricity meter reading has to be submitted to establish that their household's annual power consumption does not exceed 2,400 units.

Further, the scheme excludes families in which any member is a regular or contractual employee of the Union or Delhi government, public sector undertakings or local bodies. Households in which any member pays income tax or is a registered GST filer are also ineligible. Those already receiving financial assistance, including widow, retirement or disability pensions, cannot avail the benefits to prevent overlap with existing welfare schemes.

EXPRESS special

'Buried alive for 3 days': A circus artist's death and the price of drawing a crowd

Circus artist from Nat community was buried to 'draw spectators' in Haryana's Nuh

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, August 1

DEEPAK'S FAMILY had spent years urging him to abandon the profession.

A circus artist, the 27-year-old belonged to the semi-nomadic Nat community of traditional acrobats, rope-walkers and travelling performers, whose livelihood has for generations depended on drawing crowds with feats of physical daring.

But as audiences dwindled and earnings shrank, fellow performers said many troupes were forced to attempt increasingly dangerous acts to survive.

On July 23, one such performance in Haryana's Nuh district ended in tragedy.

Deepak died after remaining buried underground for three days during a "live samadhi" stunt in Khorri village in Tauru block.

At his home in Gaunchi, a village on the periphery of Faridabad, his elder brother, 29-year-old Sunet, said everyone in the family opposed the work.

Sunet himself had performed similar burial acts for nearly 15 years before quitting two years ago. "I walked away after realising how dangerous the stunts were becoming."

He said he could not understand why his brother remained inside the pit for so long. "The act should last no more than a day," he said.

A member of the troupe, who requested anonymity fearing police action, said Deepak had successfully performed the "live samadhi" act several times before, with the burial usually lasting between 18 and 24 hours.

But things did not go according to plan.

"This time, we were getting lower collections than usual. So we waited three days before bringing him back up," he claimed. "It cost his life."

A risky act

According to police, the performance had begun like numerous others.

Deepak first performed feats of precarious balance: riding a bicycle without touching the handlebars, standing upright on its frame, and circling the improvised ring to gather onlookers.

The finale was meant to be his underground burial – wrapped in a jute sack and covered under mounds of earth – with the audience promised the spectacle of watching him emerge alive.

When fellow performers dug him out on July 26, three days later, police said Deepak was unresponsive. He was de-



The pit in which Deepak was buried for three days in Haryana's Nuh district. EXPRESS



Deepak died after remaining buried underground during a 'live samadhi' stunt in Khorri village in Tauru block

more than Rs 1,500 to Rs 2,000 in small bills, a modest pool that gets split across multiple households," he added.

Azim, a former travelling performer of a different group, currently staying in Ballabgarh, said travelling groups are no longer the novelty they once were. "Only very young kids or elders show up to see it these days."

According to Shehzad, performers attempting the burial act rely on years of breath-control practice to conserve oxygen in tight spaces, puncturing tiny holes in burlap sacks and poking thin wooden rods through loose topsoil to create crude air channels.

Even then, he said, the act's success hinges on strict time limits, keeping burials brief and under constant watch.

Admin response

According to Inspector Rakesh Kumar, the Station House Officer of Sadar Tauru, no complaint has been filed yet. He added that inquest and post-mortem proceedings have been completed, which ruled out foul play as the death was caused by suffocation.

District administration officials said such life-threatening public performances are not permitted without authorisation and that a probe will be conducted.

Police officers said they were occupied with security arrangements for the Jal Abhishek Yatra scheduled for Monday and had not received any instructions for a separate probe into the alleged lack of permission for the event.

"It was an unfortunate incident. The troupe had been performing for around 10 years," Nuh police spokesperson Krishan Kumar said.

'No evidence of organised crime yet': Gurgaon court bail for cyber expert in Punjab CM video row case

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, August 1

A GURGAON court on Thursday granted bail to a 24-year-old man, who worked as a contractual cyber expert with the National Investigation Agency (NIA) and was arrested amid a video row linked to Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann, as it questioned the police over invoking organised crime charges without evidence.

Ankit Bhardwaj was accused of fabricating forensic reports related to the purported video at the centre of the controversy. Bhardwaj had been in custody since June 23 over an alleged attempt at taking bribe and manipulating the purported video of Mann that had allegedly hurt religious sentiments.

The order passed by Additional Sessions Judge Sudeep Goel observed that the police failed to produce supporting documents collected during the investigation. Setting out the reasons for granting bail to Bhardwaj, the court noted that the trial would take time and no

purpose would be served by keeping him in custody.

The Judge noted that the primary accusation against Bhardwaj was that "he prepared a false report to favour a political party" and that "the said act was done at the instance of some of the senior officers of the Punjab Government". However, highlighting the alleged missing evidentiary link in the police probe, the court pointed out that the investigating agency "themselves admitted that the documents and electronic instruments have been sent to the Forensic Lab," but the "report has yet not been received".

Organised crime charges cannot be invoked without a Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL) report, underlined the court. "At this stage, the investigating agency has failed to produce any documents collected during the investigation. Section 111 BNS (organised crime) cannot be invoked at this stage as there is no FSL report received on file."

"Accordingly, keeping in view the totality of circum-



Punjab CM Bhagwant Mann

stances and period of incarceration already spent by the accused, the applicant/accused is admitted to bail on his furnishing bail bonds in the sum of 1,00,000/- with one surety in the like amount," the court ordered. The Judge added that if the investigating agency receives a forensic report in its favour at a later stage, "it may approach this court for cancellation of bail".

The registration of the case in Gurgaon had triggered political friction across Haryana and Punjab over the alleged attempt to manipulate digital evidence.

The matter stems from a case registered on June 23 following a complaint from Jaspreet Singh, a digital forensics worker from Sirsa, Haryana. Singh alleged that he was called to Hotel Crowne Plaza in Gurgaon on June 15, where senior Punjab government officials pressured him and forcibly handed him Rs 10 lakh to issue a favorable forensic report regarding the video controversy surrounding Mann.

Singh alleged that he was instructed to obtain two separate reports from two labs, leading to reports under the names of Cipher Sentinel Lab and Cyber-ryan Lab.

The city police arrested Bhardwaj and co-accused Arun Mahendru on June 23. A Special Investigation Team subsequently recovered laptops and mobile phones from Dehradun and Delhi, before arresting a third accused, Pankaj Yadav, on June 29. The other two accused are still in custody.

Appearing for the accused, Advocate Dr Rajesh Sabhrawal this week contended that

Bhardwaj was falsely implicated and kept in illegal custody prior to his formal arrest on June 23.

Defense counsel argued that the police invoked organised crime provisions without any baseline evidence, call details, or financial records showing connivance or involvement with an organised crime syndicate.

He further submitted that charges for cheating, cheating by personation, forgery, and using as genuine a forged document or electronic record of the BNS, along with the charge of tampering with computer source documents and cheating by personation using computer resource of the Information Technology Act, 2000, could not be sustained without a formal forensic laboratory evaluation.

Opposing the bail application, Public Prosecutor Jagbir Sehrawat argued that the allegations against the accused were serious and involved creating manipulated technical reports at the behest of officials to benefit a political party, making him ineligible for bail.

SEVEN ARRESTED, HUNT ON FOR REMAINING ACCUSED

'Duped' men turn kidnappers: Delhi Police rescues job scam accused from Mathura

Pragnesh
New Delhi, August 1

IT WAS ABOUT 10 pm on July 24. A terrified Rajan Mishra (30), a wholesale trader in Delhi, dialled his wife Archana in panic.

"I have been kidnapped," he said.

Rajan had gone to Allahabad High Court to appear in a job fraud case, in which he was the prime accused. On his way back home to North Delhi's Buri-rari, he was abducted.

His captors wanted Rs 1.2 crore, Rajan told Archana (28), who lived in Kaushiki Enclave, a middle class locality.

Soon, one of the kidnappers came on the line. Archana, an HR professional, was told to place cash inside the couple's car, book a driver through the DriveU app and send it to

Yashobhoomi in Dwarka the next day.

She complied and a driver, Sarthak — hired from the app — parked the car with Rs 80,000 in cash at the spot chosen by the kidnappers before leaving.

But Rajan was not released. Instead, more ransom calls followed.

After three days, when Archana and father reached the Burari police station to file a kidnapping complaint, the police were in for a surprise.

They found that Rajan's alleged kidnappers were among the very people who had accused him of cheating them of crores of rupees by promising government jobs that never existed.

Start of a scam

According to Mathura Po-

lice, Rajan, an MBA graduate, promised government jobs — mostly clerical posts in the Agriculture department — to people from Uttar Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu.

Last year, the Mathura Police started looking for him.

Rajan's victims allegedly paid between Rs 22 lakh and Rs 60 lakh for a job. One of them was Gajraj (30), from a small-time farmer from a village in Mathura. "His father had died early. He used to farm on a small patch of land his father had left and earned enough to feed himself and his mother," said an officer.

In 2023, Gajraj's neighbour, Shashikant — who worked as clerk in the Uttar Pradesh Education department — introduced him to his friend Rajan who was "was highly connected". Gajraj was promised a



Job scam accused Rajan Mishra. EXPRESS

government job in return of Rs 22 lakh.

Gajraj sold his land and paid the money to Rajan.

Police said he travelled to Delhi for appear in front of an "interview board", which allegedly also comprised Archana, and underwent three months of training in Mathura after he was "selected" for the job.

"He was also paid Rs 22,000 as salary for the training period. He told everyone in his village about the job and even threw a party. Many others showed interest," the officer said.

While a villager, Vinod, paid Rs 40 lakh to Rajan for jobs for his relatives, retired Armyman Rohan allegedly paid Rs 60 lakh for his sons-in-law. "Gajraj's brothers-in-law also paid money to Rajan," the officer added.

"But after that, Rajan stopped taking their calls. Soon, Gajraj and others realised that they had been duped. In 2025, they got a case lodged against

Rajan and Archana in Mathura," said the officer.

From complainants to kidnappers

In February this year, during one of Rajan's court appearances, Gajraj, Vinod and Rohan met Balaji.

A former serviceman from Bengaluru, Balaji had allegedly paid money to Rajan on behalf of his three relatives from Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh. "They were promised jobs in the Railways," said the officer.

Police said Balaji introduced them to Sunny Malik, who claimed he could recover their money, as the court procedure would be lengthy.

The group then allegedly planned Rajan's abduction.

"When Rajan was leaving Allahabad High Court on July 24, he was abducted. They then

drove to Gurgaon before shifting Rajan to Mathura," said the officer.

The catch

The investigation turned on a single clue — the DriveU driver, Sarthak, whom Archana had hired to deliver the ransom. "We booked a driver from the app ourselves... He helped us navigate the app and reach out to customer care to get Sarthak's number," said the officer.

Soon, Sarthak was picked up. He told the police that he left the car in Dwarka at the place chosen by the kidnappers and left. A man named Shivam then allegedly arrived and took the car and the cash to Gurgaon.

A team led by Inspector Jaspal, Sub-Inspector Sudheer and Head Constable Pradeep tracked CCTV camera footage and saw the car entering a hotel

in Gurgaon. By the time the team reached the hotel, the suspects had fled.

"The team continued to track Rajan's phone and reached Mathura," said DCP (North) Raja Banthia.

In Mathura, the location of Rajan's phone showed that he was near Radha Rani society.

During a raid on a paying guest accommodation in a building, police rescued Rajan. Seven men were arrested — Malik, Gajraj, Vinod, Rohan as well as Keshavan, P Arun and Gunasekhar, the three for whom Balaji had paid money to Rajan.

"Malik fled with the car, Rs 80,000 and another Rs 65,000 allegedly withdrawn using Rajan's ATM card," said the officer. Balaji also accompanied Malik. "We are looking for them," the officer added.



ODOP: Powering UP's Inclusive Growth Story

As Uttar Pradesh advances towards Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath's vision of a trillion-dollar economy and a Viksit Uttar Pradesh by 2047, the One District One Product (ODOP) initiative has emerged as one of the state's most successful models of grassroots economic transformation. Complementing the state's broader development pillars of Arth Shakti, Srijan Shakti and Jeevan Shakti, ODOP has strengthened traditional industries, empowered artisans, accelerated MSME growth, expanded exports, and generated large scale employment opportunities. By transforming district-specific products into globally recognized brands, the initiative has positioned Uttar Pradesh as a leading example of inclusive and locally driven economic development. Today, ODOP is not merely a branding programme, it is a catalyst for entrepreneurship, exports, investment and self-reliance.



Transforming Local Strength into Global Opportunity



A Unique Economic Identity for Every District

- Uttar Pradesh has identified and promoted a signature product for each district, creating a strong economic and cultural identity.
- Products such as Varanasi Silk Sarees, Lucknow Chikankari, Moradabad Brassware, Bhadohi Carpets and Kannauj Perfume have gained wider market visibility.



Driving Export Growth

- UP's exports have increased by nearly 76% since the launch of the ODOP programme.
- State exports rose from approximately ₹88,967 crore in 2017-18 to over ₹2.01 lakh crore in 2025-26. ODOP products have been among the major contributors to this growth.



Employment Generation at Rise

- The initiative has generated more than 3.26 lakh employment opportunities since its launch in 2018, benefiting artisans, craftsmen, entrepreneurs and youth across the state.
- ODOP has strengthened self employment opportunities in both rural and urban areas.



Strengthening Uttar Pradesh's MSME Ecosystem

- Uttar Pradesh is home to nearly 96 lakh MSMEs, making it one of India's largest MSME ecosystems.
- ODOP has become a key pillar in connecting traditional industries with finance, technology, branding and market access.



Skill Development and Artisan Empowerment

- More than one lakh artisans have been trained and equipped with modern toolkits under ODOP Skill Development and Toolkit Distribution programmes.
- Government data for 2024-25 shows over 25,000 beneficiaries under ODOP training initiatives.



Financial Support for Entrepreneurs

- Projects worth more than ₹6,000 crore have been sanctioned under the ODOP Margin Money Scheme, providing critical financial support to entrepreneurs and MSMEs.
- The initiative has helped thousands of small enterprises scale operations and improve competitiveness.



Digital and E-Commerce Expansion

- More than 20,000 ODOP products are being sold through major e-commerce platforms.
- The programme aligns with the state's Digital Pradesh vision by connecting local producers directly with national and international consumers.



Building Global Market Access

- ODOP products have been showcased at international platforms including global expos, trade fairs and buyer-seller meets.
- The state is now preparing the next phase of ODOP with enhanced export facilitation, global market outreach and international branding.



Preserving Heritage Through Enterprise

- ODOP has transformed traditional crafts from cultural assets into sustainable economic opportunities.
- The initiative supports the preservation of centuries old skills while creating modern livelihood opportunities for future generations.



National Recognition for Excellence

- Uttar Pradesh was ranked Joint No. 1 in India for implementation of the National ODOP Programme, reflecting the state's leadership in promoting local products, employment generation and traditional industries.

A Key Pillar of Viksit Uttar Pradesh

Aligned with the Yogi government's vision of inclusive development, ODOP embodies the spirit of Arth Shakti by strengthening MSMEs and exports, Srijan Shakti by fostering innovation and entrepreneurship, and Jeevan Shakti by creating livelihoods and improving economic well-being. As Uttar Pradesh moves towards becoming a 1 trillion-dollar economy and one of India's most powerful growth engines, ODOP continues to demonstrate how local excellence can create global impact.



Taslima: Kolkata homecoming is return to my life’s lost chapter; CM Suvendu pledges security

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, August 1

MAKING HER first public appearance in Kolkata after 19 years, exiled Bangladeshi author Taslima Nasrin told a gathering on Saturday evening that she has not just made a homecoming to the city but to a lost chapter in her life.

Nasrin was felicitated at a cultural function at Rabindra Sadan, where Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari welcomed her, asserting that he will guarantee her security whenever she visits Kolkata which she has often described as her second home. State finance minister Swapan Dasgupta and urban development minister Agnimitra Paul were also in attendance.

Addressing the gathering, Nasrin said, “I have not just returned to a city, but to a lost chapter in my life... For 19 years I wanted to say this to Kolkata. I never did anything wrong but was punished and driven away from the city. I just want to say: Kolkata, I am back. History will remember who closed the door and will also remember who opened it... The Chief Minister took time out of his busy schedule to come here. I am grateful.”

Speaking about her exile from Bangladesh, she said, “The Bangladesh government drove me out on August 8, 1994. Many governments have changed since then, but I remained in exile for 32 years. I carried my



West Bengal CM Suvendu Adhikari felicitates exiled Bangladeshi author Taslima Nasrin in Kolkata on Saturday. PARTHA PAUL

country in my heart. Europe gave me citizenship and security for which I am grateful.”

Referring to her return to Kolkata in 2004, from where she was forced to leave in November 2007 amid tensions and pressure from the then Left Front government over the second volume of her autobiography, *Dwikhondito (Split: A Life)*, Nasrin said, “After a decade in exile, I got a home in Kolkata. Calcutta High Court lifted the ban on my book *Dwikhondito*. Yet, I was again exiled from Kolkata. I did not do anything wrong. Bangladesh exiled me for 32 years. Did I murder someone or burnt someone’s house? I just wrote for equality. I spoke against fundamentalism.”

“My country is not just a map but people’s love... I dream

one day the situation will change. Religion and state will be separated. Law and religion will be separated,” she said.

In his speech, Adhikari said, “Nasrin’s return shows that not only the face of the government has changed in West Bengal but there has also been a transformation of the system. Everyone has a right to come to Bengal. Everyone has a right to speech in Bengal.”

“I welcome Taslima Nasrin to Bengal. Whenever she wishes she can come to the state. The government will make arrangements for her security,” he said. “She came to Kolkata yesterday and today she participated in this programme. It symbolises that democracy and free speech are restored here,” the CM claimed.

Andhra poised to emerge as a major manufacturing hub: PM

Express News Service
Hyderabad, Bengaluru, August 1

PRIME MINISTER Narendra Modi on Saturday said Andhra Pradesh is poised to emerge as a major manufacturing hub under the leadership of Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu.

Addressing a public meeting after inaugurating the Alluri Sitarama Raju International Airport at Bhogapuram on the outskirts of Visakhapatnam, Modi said the state is set to generate future-ready jobs and develop a new ecosystem that will support technology-driven industries.

He said no global economic growth centre is built around a single factory, but rather through the creation of a comprehensive industrial ecosystem. Andhra Pradesh is now on the path to building such a growth ecosystem, said the PM.

He said due to Naidu’s efforts, several leading global companies are showing interest in investing in Andhra Pradesh. “Google has announced a \$15 billion dollar AI and cloud infrastructure campus (at Visakhapatnam). Many other global companies are also looking at new possibilities. This will be of great benefit to Andhra Pradesh and the youth of the country,” He said the Union government is also backing a mega pharma park in Naka Palli, which is slated to be developed into a major pharma hub in the state.



PM Narendra Modi, Union Minister Kinjarapu Rammohan Naidu, Andhra CM N Chandrababu Naidu and others at Alluri Sitarama Raju International Airport in Bhogapuram on Saturday. ANI

The Alluri Sitarama Raju International Airport has been built at an outlay of over Rs 5,700 crore with an initial annual passenger handling capacity of 6 million, which can be scaled up to 40 million. PM Modi was welcomed at the airport with a traditional dance performance by 13,500 tribal women.

The airport has been projected by CM Naidu as a catalyst for industrial growth, employment generation, exports, skill development and research in north Andhra Pradesh. Its terminal design is inspired by the “Flying Fish”, symbolising the

Bay of Bengal and North Andhra’s maritime heritage.

Praising the landowners who parted with their land for the construction of the airport, Naidu said they did not just give their land but rather gave north Andhra “a golden future.”

“Bhogapuram International Airport is a jewel in the crown of Uttarandhra,” Naidu said. He said the airport was a milestone that would transform the future of north Andhra Pradesh. Highlighting the region’s growing investment potential, the CM said the international airport would accelerate industrial and econ-

omic development.

Naidu praised PM Modi for giving the state a new life and bringing it back on track. “The Prime Minister has played a pivotal role in reviving the state’s growth. The person who gave oxygen to Andhra Pradesh and made the state stand on its feet again is Narendra Modi,” he said.

“We will dedicate the Polavaram project to the nation through PM Modi in 2027. The first phase of Amaravati will be completed by 2028 and will be inaugurated by PM Modi,” Naidu said. He praised the PM for what he described as a dec-

ade of transformative governance across multiple sectors.

Focus on youth

Later in the day, PM Modi reached Musuru where he inaugurated the Swami Vivekananda Cultural Youth Centre, ‘Viveka Smaraka’, at Ramakrishna Ashrama. At the event, the PM praised the youth of the country for being at the forefront of progress in several sectors.

“Swami Vivekananda considered the education of youth a key aspect of nation building. He saw how the nations of the world were educating their youth. Unfortunately, India was trapped in slavery at the time. The youth of India have traveled a long way from that period,” Modi said, adding that the economic situation of the country is growing at a rapid rate because of the youth.

“Today, India is rapidly progressing in the realm of semiconductor manufacturing because of the abilities of its youth. Today India is writing new chapters in AI, deep tech, space, and technology...,” Modi said.

“A few days ago we saw the youth of India create a sensation in space. For the first time, a rocket made by youths, a rocket made by a private company, went to space. Today, in any given sector the youth of India are showing their capabilities. We are seeing all around us that youth involved in small businesses are taking India’s digital economy forward,” he said.

EXPRESS special

Owaisi’s twin-track UP strategy: Target Samajwadi Party, but keep alliance doors open

Maulshree Seth & Asad Rehman
Lucknow, New Delhi, August 1

ADDRESS RALLIES at the turf of two of the biggest Opposition parties, draw large crowds, crank up the pressure on those very parties, and keep the door open for a pre-poll alliance. This seems to be the strategy that AIMIM chief Asaduddin Owaisi has adopted as he looks to shake up Muslim votes in Uttar Pradesh ahead of the elections early next year.

Over the past one-and-a-half months, Owaisi has intensified his campaign across UP, repeatedly addressing public meetings in strongholds of the Samajwadi Party (SP) and the Congress. In rally after rally, he has launched some of his sharpest attacks on SP chief Akhilesh Yadav and the party’s Muslim legislators and the local leadership, accusing them of failing to safeguard the interests of Muslims and treating them as a vote bank. In the same breath, Owaisi has also kept the door open for an alliance with the SP, saying his party was willing to join hands with other Opposition parties to stop a hat-trick of BJP wins in the state, provided the AIMIM is given “hissedari” (political partnership) and not asked to play the role of a subordinate.

The speeches delivered in constituencies such as Matera in Bahraich, Nazibabad in Bijnor, Moradabad, and Saharanpur point to a calibrated strategy: challenge the SP’s hold over Muslim voters by questioning the performance of its Muslim MLAs in their own bastions, strengthen the AIMIM’s position, and in the process enhance its bargaining power.

Owaisi began his campaign on June 14 from Matera, which the SP has won the last three times — first by former minister Yaseer Shah and now his wife Mariyam Shah. The Hyderabad MP announced state UP president Shaukat Ali as the party’s candidate from the seat, signalling that he would challenge the SP directly in one of its minority-dominated bastions. The Shahs, he alleged, had been absent from the area for years and suddenly became active on seeing his party. Owaisi, however, reiterated that the AIMIM did not want the BJP to return to power in UP. “If anyone wants to stop the BJP, the AIMIM is ready to stand with them,” he said.

Driving home the point
The AIMIM chief on June 29 repeated the message in Nazibabad that is represented by three-time SP MLA Tasleem Ahmed. He also urged Muslims to reconsider their political choices after having “tried everyone”. Taking a dig at Ahmed, Owaisi said the MLA was “like the moon that appears only once in five years”, questioning both his accessibility and performance. He also referred to the Sambhal mosque controversy, accusing the SP of failing to effectively raise the



AIMIM chief Asaduddin Owaisi; SP president Akhilesh Yadav

concerns of Muslims. He also took a dig at the SP’s PDA strategy — an acronym for Pichhda (backward classes), Dalit, Alpa-sankhayak (minorities) — saying the SP leadership had selectively reacted to their issues. Here too, Owaisi repeated his offer of an alliance and spoke of a partnership of dignity among equals.

The next attack came on July 20 in Saharanpur, which is the constituency of Congress MP Imran Masood. But here too, his focus was on the SP and Akhilesh Yadav, questioning the Opposition party’s strategy of appealing to voters to make “*Bhaiyya*” — as the SP chief is popularly referred to in party circles — the next CM. Muslims, he claimed, had repeatedly voted strategically for the SP, but had neither received political representation nor succeeded in seeing the BJP defeated. “How long will you keep your own house in darkness while lighting someone else’s?” he asked.

In Moradabad on July 26, Owaisi trained his guns on three-time Thakurdwara MLA Nawab Jan Khan. Recalling the 2013



Muzaffarnagar riots during Akhilesh’s CM tenure, the AIMIM MP argued that the SP had failed to protect Muslims while continuing to accuse his party of dividing votes. He asked why Akhilesh had not regularised Mohammad Ali Jauhar University, which faces a demolition threat, during his tenure despite now raising the issue politically. “We are also a recognised political party. We don’t want the BJP to return because Muslims suffer the most under BJP rule. If everyone wants to defeat the BJP, why shouldn’t we fight together?” said AIMIM state chief Shaukat Ali. Recalling the Bihar polls, he said AIMIM had sought only five seats from the RJD, but was denied. Ali alleged that parties such as SP, Congress and BSP want Muslim votes but hesitate to accept independent Muslim leadership. “Our offer is for political partnership, not for spreading carpets. There has to be *hissedari*,” he said.

SP & Cong push back

However, SP and Congress leaders remain sceptical about

Owaisi’s offer of alliance, believing it to be political posturing.

“Our party has taken a stand on most Muslim issues... These things stick with the community and we are confident that we will get the community’s vote. Bihar has a very different situation because Muslims have not been oppressed as they have been in UP,” said a senior SP MP from the minority community. “The SP does not view any community merely through the prism of vote bank politics, but as equal citizens entitled to dignity, opportunity and representation under the Constitution of India,” said SP spokesperson Nasser Salim.

State Congress chief Ajay Rai said that his party had reached out to Muslims “when they suffered”, while “Owasi was nowhere to be seen”. “He has suddenly appeared before polls and is presenting himself as the lone well-wisher of the community. We do not consider his offer to be serious,” Rai said. AICC secretary and former chairman of UP Congress Minority Department Shah Nawaz Alam said that after the 2024 Lok Sabha polls, Muslims in UP were confident of the INDIA bloc forming the government. “...In states where it feels the Opposition parties are in a position to defeat the BJP, they rally behind them. But in places where it feels that the Opposition parties or alliance is not in a position to defeat BJP, it backs a party such as the AIMIM.”

Ladakh Police registers zero FIR over ‘objectionable’ video against Shah

ENS & PTI
Srinagar, August 1

THE LADAKH police have filed a zero FIR in connection with the circulation of a “derogatory” video against Union Home Minister Amit Shah.

The complainant from Leh has alleged that the said video contains “highly objectionable, hateful and offensive remarks” concerning the Home Minister and it has been “widely viewed and shared on social media”.

It is also alleged that the content is “likely to promote hostility, disturb public order and adversely affect social harmony” by inciting resentment among the public.

The FIR has been registered under Sections 197(1)(d) (acts against national integration), 352 (insult to provoke breach of peace) and 353(1) (public mischief) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS). The offences carry punishments ranging from two to three years of imprisonment, along with a fine, or both, depending on the specific provision.

The case has been registered against one Yogesh Parmar based on a written complaint received at the Leh police station.

As the alleged incident falls under the jurisdiction of the Devaraja police station in Mysuru City, Karnataka, Leh police registered a zero FIR and transferred the case to the concerned police station for further investigation, according to the officials.

Rahul among three booked in Varanasi over Parliament skit

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, August 1

A CASE was registered in Varanasi Saturday against Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi, Independent MP Rajesh Ranjan alias Pappu Yadav and Samajwadi Party’s Faizabad MP Awadhesh Prasad for allegedly “insulting Sanatan Dharma and religious sentiments of Hindus” during a protest outside House a day before.

On Friday, Yadav, clad in saffron clothes, staged a skit on the alleged theft of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya outside the House during the ongoing Monsoon session, in which Gandhi also made a brief appearance. In the act, Gandhi is seen depositing cash in a donation box which Yadav, ostensibly playing a priest, flees with before being caught. Prasad also participated in the skit, according to the FIR filed at Varanasi’s Kotwali police station on the complaint of Jagadguru Balak Devacharya, head of the Patalpuri Math in Narharipura, Varanasi, alleging the incident had hurt the religious sentiments of crores of Hindus.

Confirming filing of the FIR, Varanasi Assistant Commissioner of Police Vijay Pratap Singh said a probe would start soon. The case was registered under BNS sections 196 (promoting enmity between different groups on ground of religion, race, place of birth, residence, language, etc., and doing acts



Lok Sabha LoP Rahul Gandhi at Chennai airport on Saturday. PTI

prejudicial to maintenance of harmony), 299 (deliberate and malicious acts, intended to outrage religious feelings of any class by insulting its religion or religious beliefs), 302 (uttering words, etc., with deliberate intent to wound religious feelings of any person) and 3(5) (acts done by several persons in furtherance of common intention).

The complainant, Devacharya, said, “I lodged a police complaint because the religious sentiments of Hindus were hurt and our revered religious symbols were publicly mocked by them.” Police said that he alleged the demonstration was held on the Parliament premises with an apparent objective of ensuring wide media coverage and to attract nationwide attention. After the broadcast of the incident, saints, devotees and followers from across the country expressed “deep anger and distress” before him, he had said.

From LDF to UDF, deja vu for PM SHRI as Congress blinks after IUML pushback

Shaju Philip
Thiruvananthapuram, August 1

THE NEW Congress-led UDF government in Kerala has put on hold its decision to implement the central PM SHRI (Pradhan Mantri Schools for Rising India) scheme in the state-run schools after the move faced stiff opposition from its key ally Indian Union Muslim League (IUML).

After the first meeting of the ruling coalition Thursday, UDF convener and Congress MP Adoor Prakash announced the proposal to roll out the PM SHRI scheme in Kerala, which the UDF had vehemently opposed while in Opposition on the ground that it was aimed at “saffronisation” of school education.

“The previous LDF government had signed an MoU with the Centre (for implementation of PM SHRI). Hence, the present UDF government cannot withdraw from it. The UDF government will take forward the scheme to get the fund, which is not a magnanimity of the Centre,” Prakash had then said.

On Friday, however, senior IUML leader and minister P K Kunhalikutty took exception to the UDF convener’s announcement, pointing out that the V D Satheesan Cabinet has formed a four-member Cabinet sub-committee to examine the issue.

“The previous CPI(M)-led LDF government had signed the MoU with the Centre. The UDF’s Cabinet sub-committee will find ways to move out of the MoU. At any cost, we are not going to implement the condi-

tions of the scheme in the school curriculum. The sub-committee (headed by IUML leader and general education minister N Samsudheen) will report to the Cabinet on the road ahead. We have not taken any decision,” he said.

After Kunhalikutty made clear the IUML’s stand, Prakash made a U-turn, saying that “We have not decided on whether the state should remain as a participant of the PM SHRI. The decision will be taken after the Cabinet’s sub-committee report.” Several Muslim bodies, including those close to the IUML, had flayed the UDF government’s bid to go ahead with the PM SHRI scheme.

LDF’s retreat

Last year, when the previous Pinarayi Vijayan-led LDF



The V D Satheesan-led government’s decision to put PM SHRI rollout on hold comes months after the previous state government suspended the scheme after CPI’s education saffronisation’ charge. FILE

government signed the MoU with the BJP-led Centre for the implementation of the PM SHRI — meant to upgrade many schools into “model institutions” — the UDF leaders had alleged that it was an outcome of a “secret deal” between the CPI(M) and the BJP.

In October 2025, after days of standoff with its junior ally CPI, the CPI(M)-led government had decided to suspend the MoU, while constituting a seven-member Cabinet sub-committee to review it. Opposing the scheme, the CPI had echoed the LDF’s stand that the PM SHRI scheme was part of the Narendra Modi government’s National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, which it saw as a tool for pushing “saffronisation of education” in the country.

On Saturday, Pinarayi Vi-

jayan said: “Why is the Congress government in a hurry to implement the PM SHRI scheme. Chief Minister Satheesan should apologise to the people of Kerala for spreading canards that the UDF government cannot go back on the scheme. The LDF government had not initiated any further action on the scheme after signing the MoU. Now a Congress government has ratified the BJP agenda of saffronising the education sector.”

IUML factor

During the PM SHRI row last year, the IUML had openly stated that the scheme will be rejected if the UDF is voted to power. During the recent Assembly elections, the UDF had called the LDF’s PM SHRI move “an evidence of CPI(M)-BJP

pact in Kerala”.

Currently, in the 140-member Assembly, the Congress has a majority on its own as it has 63 seats as compared to the IUML’s 22. However, Satheesan could not upset the IUML as he had its strong backing during the Congress race for the CM’s post.

Besides, in several Congress seats, including Priyanka Gandhi Vadra’s Wayanad Lok Sabha seat, the IUML’s support is considered crucial for the grand old party. However, while in power in the state, the Congress has always faced allegations about being driven by the IUML on various issues.

In another embarrassment for the UDF, Union Minister of State for Education Jayant Chaudhary recently informed the Rajya Sabha that Kerala had

not been allotted any funds under the PM SHRI scheme. The disclosure undermined the Congress’s claim that the previous LDF government had received the central assistance after signing the MoU.

In response to another question raised by IUML MP Abdul Wahab, the Union MoS also contradicted the Congress’s contention that the state government could not withdraw from the PM SHRI because the LDF government had already signed it.

In his reply, Chaudhary also did not say that states were barred from withdrawing from the PM SHRI. Instead, after mentioning its various features, he said states that do not sign the MoU or withdraw from the scheme stand to miss out on its benefits.

6 dead as rain pummels Kerala

Tourism hubs, hill stations shut until further orders

Express News Service
Thiruvananthapuram, August 1

SIX PEOPLE died and six others went missing in Kerala on Saturday after heavy rainfall since Friday night battered the state. Landslides and flooding have destroyed houses and vast tracts of agricultural land, with Kottayam and Pathanamthitta said to be the worst affected.

Heavy spells continued, especially in the hilly regions. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) sounded a red alert in nine districts of Idukki, Kottayam, Pathanamthitta, Thrissur, Malappuram, Kozhikode, Wayanad, Kannur and Kasargod.

Chief Minister V D Sathes- san has directed ministers to camp in different districts to oversee rescue and relief operations. The state also sought the Navy’s assistance after two fishermen went missing at Mu-



Rescue work underway in Kottayam, Kerala, after floods triggered a landslide on Saturday. PTI

thalapozhi in Thiruvananthapuram. A coast guard vessel is already engaged in search operations.

Caught off-guard

A day after the IMD pre- dicted isolated heavy rain in some districts in Kerala, torren- tial rainfall caught the state off guard on Saturday.

IMD had declared an orange alert (heavy to very heavy rain)

for Saturday in nine districts, mainly in North Kerala. Kot- tayam and Pathanamthitta, two of the worst-affected dis- tricts, were on yellow alert (moderate rain).

A nowcast issued at 10 pm Friday for southern and central Kerala, including Pathanam- thitta, Idukki and Kottayam, was only an orange alert. The first red alert for the districts was given at 11.15 pm.

The torrential rain that pummeled the state through the night delayed rescue oper- ations. Most tourism hubs, es- pecially the hill stations, across the state are closed until further orders. Travelling to Wayanad, which is on high alert, is also re- stricted.

After the Pamba river swelled, the Travancore Devas- wom board on Saturday ad- vised devotees to reconsider their plan to visit the Sabari- mala temple.

As many as six people lost their lives in the ensuing floods and landslides.

Rejina Johny and her son Josefine from Poonjar in Kot- tayam district died after a land- slide buried their house in the early hours of Saturday. Jose- fine had recently sustained an injury in a road accident and could not escape, said officials. Both bodies were recovered later. At Kudayathoor village in Idukki district, 69-year-old Su- mathi died after her house was hit by a landslide. Sumathi’s husband Ravi Narayanan and son Ratheesh escaped with in- juries.

At Kolahalamedu in Idukki, Prabakaran Nair (72) died when

the rain-soaked wall of his house collapsed. Two kids, both aged below 5, died in Mal- appuram after they slipped into streams near their homes.

Ranni and Arannula in Pa- thanamthitta, and Pala and Erattupetta in Kottayam dis- trict were inundated leaving shops and establishments flooded and scores of people stranded in their houses. Small fishing vessels and yachts were deployed on Saturday to rescue them.

Several hilly regions in the state saw extremely heavy rain- fall, according to data. Waga- mon in Idukki reported 314 mm of rain and Thikkoy in Kot- tayam 277 mm in the last 24 hours till Saturday 7 am. Vythiri in Wayanad district reported 208.4 mm of rainfall, and Anak- kampoyil in Kozhikode 106 mm from 8.30 am to 4 pm on Satur- day. The region got 306 mm of rainfall in the last 33 hours.

On the other hand, Kerala has reported a 34 per cent defi- cit in rainfall in the southwest monsoon between June 1 and July 31. Against the usual rain of 1,301 mm during this period, the state witnessed only 853 mm of rain.

Over 20,000 shifted in South Gujarat, Navsari worst hit

Kamal Saiyed
Surat, August 1

OVER 20,400 people from Surat, Tapi, Navsari and Valsad districts were shifted to shelter homes by their respective ad- ministrative officials in the past 24 hours, of which nearly half were from the worst-affected district of Navsari. Till 6 am Sat- urday, Surat district’s Ambika taluka had received the highest rainfall in 24 hours at 20.43 inches, followed by Vansda in Navsari at 16.25 inches.

Surat city recorded 6 inches of rainfall in the past 24 hours and the water level in Ukai dam on the Tapi river rose to 320 feet against the danger mark of 345 ft.

Navsari District Collector Manish Gurwani said, “We have made proactive manage- ment in shifting the people by forming teams comprising po- lice personnel, district admin- istration officials, fire officials and others who visited villages located on the sea coast as well as on banks of Ambika, Purna, Kaveri. All three rivers were flowing above the danger level on Friday, and the water level gradually decreased on Sat- urday. Among the 11,000 people rescued were 34 pregnant women and over 1,000 elderly people. No casualties were re- ported as of Saturday even- ing.”

The situation in Valsad dis-



The low-lying areas in Limbayat are among the most affected. HANIF MALEK

trict, the last district bordering Maharashtra state, had re- ceived heavy rainfall during 24 hours on Friday. The highest rainfall was recorded in Dha- rampur taluka – 10.40 inches, while other talukas, Kaprada, Pardi, Nanapondha and Valsad town received around five inches of rainfall. Over 109 roads in the district has been closed due to water overtop- ping till Saturday. No casualties were reported from the district.

Tapi district also received heavy rainfall in Dolvan taluka – 16.7 inches, and Valod – 7.80 inches. Over 1,400 people have been shifted to safer places by district authorities. On Sat- urday, due to the moderate rainfall, people returned to their homes.

Tapi District Collector Dev

Choudhary said, “The situation at present is under control, as no heavy rainfall has been re- corded in the district. No casu- alties have been reported and our teams are at different loca- tions monitoring the situation.”

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Industrialist hired men to kill partner over Rs 32-crore dispute, say police

Wanted full control of firm based in Maharashtra: Cops

Manish Kumar Pathak
Mumbai, August 1

A RS 32-crore financial dispute between two business partners allegedly culminated in an murder bid when masked gunmen shot Vasai industrial- ist and GSM Foils Managing Di- rector Mohansing Parmar outside his factory, with the Waiiv police arresting seven people, including his business partner who allegedly master- minded the attack to seize com- plete control of the company.

Police claimed Parmar’s business partner, Sagar Bhanu- shali, had hired contract killers for Rs 5 lakh, paying only a few thousand rupees in advance to one Vijay Prajapati. Parmar suf- fered a bullet injury to the right side of his chest and is recuper- ating at a hospital in Nalasopara.

“The alleged mastermind, Sagar Bhanushali, had suffered massive losses in the US stock market and accumulated debts running into crores. Bhanu- shali had allegedly persuaded him to buy his shares in the company for around Rs 32 crore. Parmar paid an amount of Rs 32 crore to Bhanushali,” said Deputy Commissioner of Police Ashok Virkar (Zone II) of the MBVV police.

“During investigation it was revealed that the accused hatched a murder conspiracy to avoid returning the amount if Parmar was killed and also to gain huge financial benefits by taking complete control over the company,” said Virkar.

The arrested accused are Sagar Girish Bhanushali, the al- leged main conspirator, shooters Sujeet Pandey and Manoj Thathera, residents of

Azamgarh and Ballia in Uttar Pradesh, respectively, Vijayku- mar Prajapati, Anup Prajapati, Vijay Kumar Vishwakarma, Gokul Gautam and Mohammed Yusuf Khan of Goregaon.

According to police, the incident took place around 8 pm on July 24 outside GSM Foils Limited in Diamond In- dustrial Estate, Vasai East.

As Parmar walked towards his parked Mahindra Thar after leaving the factory, Sujeet Pan- dey and Anup Prajapati, who had allegedly been waiting near the premises on a motorcycle, put their plan into action.

Police said Pandey, wearing a mask and hiding behind a parked WagonR, called out “Mohan”. As Parmar turned around, Pandey allegedly fired at his chest from a distance of a few feet. According to the FIR, when company employee Nan- dra Rohidas Borade rushed to assist Parmar, the shooter alled- gedly attempted to fire again, but the weapon malfunctioned. The accused then allegedly struck Parmar on the head with the butt of the pistol before fleeing on a motorcycle ridden by Anup Prajapati, who had been waiting near the factory gate.

Parmar was initially taken to Gayatri Hospital before being shifted to Riddhi Vinayak Hos- pital in Nalasopara.

Police analysed CDR, IDPR and CCTV footage to identify the assailants. Technical analy- sis and local intelligence led in- vestigators to Uttar Pradesh, where the accused were traced and arrested.

According to police, Vish- wakarma arranged weapons, vehicles and shooters, while Thathera procured illegal fire- arms from Uttar Pradesh. Gaud- tam allegedly helped source the weapons, and Anup Prajapati conducted reconnaissance, drove the getaway motorcycle and attempted to destroy evi- dence after the attack.

EXPRESS special

J&K: Trials pending for over 18 years, HC sets timeline for courts to decide 15 oldest cases

HC order follows SC’s criticism over prolonged trials; 351 cases identified for speedy disposal

Arun Sharma
Jammu, August 1

ON JUNE 26, 1996, Ali Moham- mad Mir, a contractor, was ab- ducted by some gunmen from his residence in the Nishat area of Srinagar. He was later killed and his body allegedly thrown into the Jhelum river.

Over 30 years since the ab- duction and subsequent killing of Mir, his body remains un- traceable and the trial in the case is continuing even as three of the six accused named in the FIR, registered in 2007, are dead. Of the three surviving accused, two have been in jail since 2008, and the third one was arrested in De- cember 2025.

Mir’s is among the 15 of the oldest cases in which the Jammu and Kashmir and La- dakh High Court has given a timeline of four to five months to three years for the conclusion of trials. The HC order comes in the wake of the Supreme Court’s criticism of prolonged criminal trials and incarceration of ac- cused in J&K jails. The HC has identified a total of 351 pending cases and directed the trial courts concerned to ensure their speedy disposal. The Registrar General of the High Court, M K Sharma, in an order dated June 25, has directed the trial courts in J&K and Ladakh to fast-track the 336 remaining criminal cases in which the accused have been in jail for 14–15 years.

Significantly, in two of the 15 cases shortlisted by the High Court, the accused, Ghulam Nabi from Doda, has been in jail for over 15 years, a period longer

than the punishment pre- scribed for the offences he is ac- cused of.

According to official records, Ghulam Nabi is facing trial for offences under Ranbir Penal Code’s Section 307 (attempt to murder), 120-B (criminal con- spiracy), 212 (harbouring an of- fender), 216 (harbouring an of- fender who has escaped from police custody) and 7/27 of the Arms Act (illegal possession and use of prohibited weapon). The maximum punishment for these offences prescribed at the time of commission of the of- fence in 2010 was 10 years, said his counsel Pervez Ahmed.

Ghulam Nabi is undergoing trial in another case registered at Doda police station in 2010 under the provisions of Section 4/5 of the Explosive Substances Act (ESA) and Section 7/27 of the Arms Act. The maximum pun- ishment prescribed for these of- fences was 10 years in 2010.

Another one among the 15 shortlisted cases is of Moham- mad Shafeeq Awan, a truck driver from Muzaffarabad, who has been in jail for over 12 years. Booked for offences under Sections 8, 21 and 29 of the Narcotic Drugs and Psy- chotropic Substances (NDPS) Act, Awan was arrested on Jan- uary 17, 2014 after the police intercepted his truck at the Sa- lamabad Trade Facilitation Centre in Uri and seized 114 bricks of acetyl morphine (her- oin) weighing one kg each con- cealed in 148 sacks of almonds.

The seizure led to a major diplomatic and trade standoff between India and Pakistan, 25, has directed the trial courts in J&K and Ladakh to fast-track the 336 remaining criminal cases in which the accused have been in jail for 14–15 years.

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trader, Tariq Ahmad Sheikh, whom the police said had used Pohl’s name to allegedly broker the shipment for drug networks in Punjab and Delhi. However, while Pohl and Sheikh were granted bail by the court, Awan continues to be in jail.

According to officials, the maximum punishment to a per- son in the event of seizure of commercial quantity of nar- cotics at that time was imprison- ment up to 20 years.

SC’s criticism

In April this year, the Su- preme Court, while hearing a Special Leave Petition (criminal) Anoop Singh Versus Union Ter- ritory of J&K, had directed the J&K and Ladakh High Court to look into the matter and take corrective measures for expedi- tious disposal of cases wherein the trial has been pending for over five years. Earlier in Febru- ary, it had criticised the prosecu- tion and the administration for keeping a murder accused in jail for seven years without complet- ing the trial.

Noting that in seven years, the prosecution examined only seven of 17 witnesses across 82 hearings, the Apex Court said it was a “mockery” of the right to a speedy trial under Article 21 of the Constitution. It directed the Home Secretary of J&K to ex- plain delays and submit rec- ords of all criminal trials in the UT where under trials have been in custody for five years or more.

The High Court in its order has asked the trial courts to avoid unnecessary delays, ex- cept in exceptional circum- stances, list these cases apart the daily regular list and take appropriate steps to secure the attendance of witnesses. It has also asked them to make full use of videoconferencing and other electronic modes for re- cording evidence and provide legal aid wherever necessary.

UKSSSC paper leak: ED attaches property worth Rs 63.3 lakh

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 1

THE ENFORCEMENT Direc- torate (ED) has attached mov- able and immovable properties worth Rs 63.30 lakh under the Prevention of Money Launder- ing Act (PMLA) in connection with the Uttarakhand Subordi- nate Service Selection Com- mission (UKSSSC) exami- nation paper leak scam.

The action targets assets al- legedly bought with proceeds of crime generated by an orga- nised syndicate that leaked con- fidential question papers for the 2016 and 2021 VDO/VPDO exams and manipulated the re- cruitment process.

ED’s financial investigation found that employees of M/s RMS Techno Solutions Pvt. Ltd - the printing agency for UKSSSC exams - colluded with public servants, middlemen and facilitators to steal and sell question papers. “Confidential papers were distributed through a network of inter- mediaries in exchange for sub- stantial monetary consider- ation, with candidates paying large sums to secure leaks,” a ED spokesperson said in a statement.

A key figure in the probe is Hakam Singh Rawat, who ED says received about Rs 95 lakh from candidates and then tried to project the illicit earnings as legitimate income. “Bank ac- count analysis showed large cash deposits inconsistent with his declared income, while his Income Tax Returns (ITRs) claimed agricultural income that was “disproportionate to the actual agricultural activity undertaken,” the spokesperson said.

• BRIEFLY



Government officials, police and a forensic team inspect the site following the building collapse in Bhiwandi on Saturday. DEEPAK JOSHI

MAHARASHTRA

Bhiwandi building collapse: Police probe if contractor was among dead

POLICE INVESTIGATING the Bhiwandi building collapse that killed 10 people are trying to establish whether one of the victims, Ashok Paswan, was the contractor who alled- gedly undertook repair work at the site. The owner of the building, meanwhile, has been traced to Dubai and will be arrested after he returns to India, police said. Investigators said three Paswan brothers, all masons, were among those killed in the collapse. One of them, Ashok, is suspected to have been the contractor entrusted with the repair work, though police said this is yet to be confirmed. ENS

Two women die of electrocution in Uttar Pradesh

AN 80-YEAR-OLD woman and her daughter-in-law died of electrocution after coming in contact with a live high-tension wire in their house in Shamli dis- trict on Saturday, police said. The victims were identified as Baton Khatun (80) and Khushnuma (40), of Kaserva village. The inci- dent occurred when Khatun tried to switch on a light and came in contact with the live wire. Khushnuma was electrocuted while trying to rescue her. Station House Officer Gyanendra Singh said. PTI

3 dead in road accident in UP’s Sambhal

THREE PEOPLE died on Saturday evening after the autorickshaw that they were travelling in collided with a truck head-on, police said. Additional Superintendent of Police Kuldeep Singh said the accident occurred near Mohammadpur Tanda vil- lage. The bodies were sent for a post-mortem exami- nation. The officer said the truck has been seized and efforts are underway to trace and arrest its driver. Identities of the deceased were yet to be ascertained, police said, adding that further probe is on. PTI

‘Those taking over land think people can’t fight the mighty; even Army came to us for help’

Nikhila Henry
Hyderabad, August 1

CREATED BY the Congress government in Telangana in 2024, HYDRAA — short for Hyderabad Disaster Response and Asset Protection Agency — has remained in the news for its demolition drives against al- leged illegal constructions. Supporters argue it is reclaim- ing public land and reducing urban flood risk; critics accuse it of selective enforcement and overreach. In the latest in- stance, **A V Ranganath**, the IPS officer who has headed HY- DRAA as its Commissioner since its formation, has been at the receiving end of ire of the Telangana High Court, which has cited 63 contempt of court petitions against him for al- leged non-compliance, and asked the Telangana govern- ment to replace him.

In an interview with *The In-*

dian Express, Ranganath blames landgrabbers for the petitions against him, and says HYDRAA is only trying to “fol- low the law in letter and spirit”. Excerpts:

How do you define HYDRAA’s mandate?

HYDRAA’s mandate is very much in its name... disaster re- sponse and asset protection. In many cases, disasters are linked to non-protection of assets, in- cluding nallahs, lakes and rocks. We also protect parks, open spaces and land parcels.

So, HYDRAA protects not just natural resources but also prime land?

Yes, exactly. The custodian of government land is the dis- trict collector and Revenue De- partment... It is the duty of the department to verify whether it is government land or not, and establish the ownership before

they come to us. Once all that is done... we provide the men and machinery to fence and protect the land parcel.

In protecting water bodies and parks, we do not wait for the intervention of any other agency because this duty was entrusted to HYDRAA (under the rules that created the body)...

When you are protecting the environment, forests, green cover, lung spaces and water- bodies, we are ultimately pro- tecting people’s interests from landgrabbers.

The HC has observed on several occasions that the demolition of properties is being done despite a stay or status quo order.

In the most recent case where the court has issued a contempt order, we are clearly protecting Articles 21 and 51 A(g) of the Constitution. Article 21 mentions the right to life, and

the right to have a healthy en- vironment is part of the right to life as per the Supreme Court. Article 51 A(g) clearly mentions that it is the fundamental duty of every citizen to protect water- bodies. Article 48A in the Direc- tive Principles of State Policy also clearly mentions that the state has to protect forests.

In one of the cases which we are fighting in court, the com- plaint was given by Save the Rocks Society and other public- spirited environmentalists. The Ammuguda Rocks of Lothu- kunta (in north Secunderabad) are 2.5 billion years old. We have got in writing from the Mining Department that the builder was not given a mining licence. The Forest Department has given a letter that they did not give permission to con- struct. We are saying this is gov- ernment land...

The High Court has pulled



you up in particular for ‘being a law unto yourself’, for having 63 contempt of court cases against you.

You should also understand who are the petitioners in the contempt cases — most of them are landgrabbers who are trying to take over crores of ru- pees worth of government land at the cost of environment and

lung spaces. One of the com- plainants is a landlord in the Ghatkesar area (in the suburbs of Hyderabad) who has usurped plots of 2,200 Singa- reni workers and built a com- pound wall. This landlord has filed some 10 contempt peti- tions against me.

Another person, who has about 40 criminal cases against him and who was trying to take away 20 acres of prime land worth Rs 6,000 crore in Gachi- bowli junction, has filed over a dozen contempt cases against me. There is another person, who is accused of double murder, who has filed a few contempt cases against me be- cause he was trying to take 200 acres of land, worth almost Rs 20,000 crore. These are people who are taking over parks and roads and land and think that (the common person) cannot fight against the mighty.

HYDRAA is trying to protect

people who do not have the money for legal battles. That is why HYDRAA is getting public applause and appreciation... We are trying to follow the law in letter and spirit.

One observation by the court was that maybe the Army should be involved in protecting its orders.

Ironically, the very day that the court made this comment... Army officials came to us to say that HYDRAA should protect some land in the Cantonment area. The Army said that only when HYDRAA is involved, is there fear of the law.

Chief Minister Revanth Reddy seems to be firmly behind HYDRAA.

He has said that HYDRAA is the topmost reform that his government has undertaken. HYDRAA is his brainchild, and I am the officer assigned the

task of heading it.

How many acres of land would you say HYDRAA has protected so far, as well as lakes, water bodies and rocks?

We are flooded with 35,000 complaints. In our Prajavani (weekly public grievance sys- tem), there are people who wait in queues from 6 in the morn- ing. We have protected 3,350 acres of land worth Rs 1.5 lakh crore. We have protected hundreds of lakes, waterbodies, parks and rocks. We are also into lake rejuvenation. All this will mitigate disasters.

The court has also asked for your removal.

It is for the government to take a call on... We have huge respect for courts, (but) here, the petitioners are misleading courts... They are landgrabbers who forge documents.

Passerby dials 112, gang rape attempt foiled in Madhya Pradesh's Guna; five arrested

Express News Service
Bhopal, August 1

A PASSERBY'S promptness in dialling 112 police patrol helped foil a sexual assault attempt on a woman who was returning from a temple with her fiancé on Friday night in Madhya Pradesh's Guna district.

The call not only forced the accused to flee the spot, but also led to the arrest of five of them in 24 hours following a district-wide manhunt, said police. The incident unfolded on the night of July 31 when the woman and her fiancé, an engineer, were on their way home from a temple. According to the police, three men on another bike approached the couple near a petrol pump on the highway and told them that one of the tyres of their motorbike was punctured. When the engineer halted the bike to check the tyres, the

three men called four more associates to the spot, said police. "They snatched the key of their bike and both the victims were taken into the adjoining forest," said a senior police officer.

After reaching a secluded stretch, the accused persons assaulted the man and robbed the couple of their mobile phones, wallet and other belongings. They then allegedly attempted to sexually assault the woman. It was at this moment that a passerby noticed suspicious activity on the roadside and dialled 112. "The Dial-112 police team reached the spot within minutes. Seeing the police vehicle, the accused fled into the forest," the officer said. The couple was rescued and the woman underwent medical examination. "The moment information about the incident was received, separate police teams were constituted. A Special Investigation

Team (SIT) was formed immediately and the probe was monitored continuously at my level. Our priority was to identify and arrest every accused at the earliest," said Guna Superintendent of Police Hitika Vasal.

A night-long operation saw police teams comb through forests, where the accused persons were believed to have fled, while investigators went through CCTV footage collected from roads, petrol pumps and nearby establishments.

"Technical evidence, CCTV footage, intelligence gathered through the informer network and continuous field operations enabled us to establish the identities of the accused within hours; coordinated raids were launched simultaneously," the officer said. Officers searched villages, forest hideouts, houses of suspects and their relatives.

"Despite difficult terrain and challenging circumstances, police teams continued the operation relentlessly. Their coordinated effort resulted in the arrest of five accused within 24 hours," officials said.

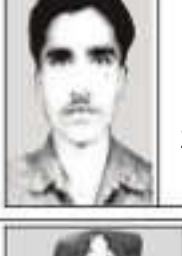
Those arrested have been identified as Bablu Banjara (23), Mahendra Banjara (20), Dinesh Banjara (28), all three from Borkheda village, Chhotu Banjara (28) from Khajra and Sardar alias Karam Singh Banjara (30) from Vinyaki. Two more are absconding.

Police said the accused confessed their involvement in the incident during questioning.

"The mobile phone, wallet and other stolen articles of the couple were recovered," said an investigator.

"Special police teams are conducting raids to apprehend the remaining accused," the officer said.

SALUTE THE SOLDIER

BORDER SECURITY FORCE		
	CONSTABLE TANURAM NARZARY 1 BN BSF 24.07.1962 – 02.08.1995	Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Tanuram Narzary on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injuries while fighting militants in Munawarabad Seed Factory, Srinagar (J&K) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.
	HEAD CONSTABLE SUDARSHAN SHARMA 32 BN BSF 14.04.1945 – 02.08.1995	Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Head Constable Sudarshan Sharma on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal injuries in an IED blast triggered by militants in area of Saligram, Anantnag (J&K) and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.
	HEAD CONSTABLE SUDARSHAN SHARMA 32 BN BSF 14.04.1945 – 02.08.1995	Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Lance Naik Ramgati Ram on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he made ultimate sacrifice while on operational duty in area of BOP Boltala, Kolkata (West Bengal).
	CONSTABLE HABIBUR RAHMAN 49 BN BSF 28.10.1968 – 02.08.1995	Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant Jawan Constable Habibur Rahman on his Balidan Diwas. On this day, he sustained fatal bullet injury while fighting militants in Srinagar area, J&K and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty.
	SHRI V P PUROHIT, COMDT, KIRTI CHAKRA, PPMG 171 BN BSF 28.12.1958 – 02.08.2002	Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant officer Shri V P Purohit, Commandant and Head Constable K K Hooda on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained bullet injuries while fighting militants in Malpura area, Budgam (J&K). They fought bravely and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty. Their sacrifice and gallant action have been aptly recognized by GOI by awarding Shri V P Purohit, Comdt with Kirti Chakra & PPMG (Posthumously) and Head Constable K K Hooda with PPMG (Posthumously).

Director General and all Ranks of Border Security Force remember its gallant officer Shri V P Purohit, Commandant and Head Constable K K Hooda on their Balidan Diwas. On this day, they sustained bullet injuries while fighting militants in Malpura area, Budgam (J&K). They fought bravely and made ultimate sacrifice in the line of duty. Their sacrifice and gallant action have been aptly recognized by GOI by awarding Shri V P Purohit, Comdt with Kirti Chakra & PPMG (Posthumously) and Head Constable K K Hooda with PPMG (Posthumously).

CENTRAL RESERVE POLICE FORCE		
	Veer Balidani Naik P Krishnan 36 Bn 1-7-1943 To 2-8-1969	DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Lance Naik Gokal Dev and Naik P Krishnan of 36 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely countering an ambush by Naga insurgents in Manipur on 2 August 1969. #CRPF salutes the bravehearts and pledges never to let their sacrifice go in vain.
	Veer Balidani Constable Narendra Kumar 79 Bn 3-8-1967 To 2-8-1989	DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Narendra Kumar of 79 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice on 2 August 1989 after succumbing to injuries sustained in a militant attack during law and order duties in Srinagar, Jammu & Kashmir on 2 August 1989. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
	Veer Balidani Inspector Giri Raj Prasad 60 Bn 15-11-1943 To 2-8-1992	DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Inspector Gori Raj Prasad of 60 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely combating militants during an area domination patrol in Srinagar, Jammu & Kashmir on 2 August 1992. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
	Veer Balidani Constable Lakhwinder Singh 87 Bn 15-12-1969 To 2-8-1992	DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Lakhwinder Singh of 87 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice while bravely countering an ambush by terrorists during an area domination operation in Amritsar, Punjab on 2 August 1992. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
	Veer Balidani Naik/Driver Abdul Quadir 127 Bn 1-2-1960 To 2-8-1994	DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Naik/Driver Abdul Quadir of 127 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after being seriously injured in an ambush by insurgents in Manipur on 2 August 1994. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.

	Veer Balidani Head Constable Sukhvinder Singh 39 Bn 12-10-1965 To 2-8-2005	DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Head Constable Sukhvinder Singh of 39 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after being grievously injured while bravely combating insurgents during an area domination patrol in Tinsukia district, Assam on 2 August 2005. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
	Veer Balidani Constable P Udaya 51 Bn 28-4-1973 To 2-8-2006	DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable P Udaya of 51 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice after being seriously injured in an IED blast by Maoists during a combing operation in Dantewada district, Chhattisgarh on 2 August 2006. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
	Veer Balidani Constable Manoranjan Bora 12 Bn 30-4-1976 To 2-8-2010	DG and all Ranks of #CRPF pay solemn tribute to Constable Manoranjan Bora of 12 Bn, who made the supreme sacrifice on 2 August 2010 after sustaining grievous injuries while bravely combating insurgents during an ambush in Goalpara district, Assam on 30 July 2010. #CRPF salutes the braveheart and pledges never to let his sacrifice go in vain.
	LNK SHUBHAM	"Fabulous fourteen" family fondly remembers LNK Shubham who made the supreme sacrifice at Nyoma (Eastern Ladakh) on this day of 02 Aug 2024. COMMANDING OFFICER & ALL RANKS 14 DOGRA


UJVN Limited
 (An Uttarakhand Govt. Enterprises)
 H.O.: "UJJWAL", Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
 Telephones: 0135-2763808, Fax: 0135-2763508
 CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866, Website: www.ujvn.com

पत्र क्र: 645 दिनांक: 01/08/2026
e-Tender (Time Extension-2)
04/EE(Civil-R&R-Tehri)/LMP/2026-27
 Due to unavoidable circumstances, due dates of bidding of Office of the Executive Engineer (Civil-R&R-Tehri), Lakhwar Multipurpose Project, UJVN Limited, Dakpathar (Dehradun) invites online bid from interested parties are extended as follows:
 e-NIT No : 04/EE(Civil-R&R-Tehri)/LMP/2026-27
 Name of work : Construction of RCC Retaining and Gabion Wall near Compartment No. 4, North-Binhaar (Near Nala) at left bank of Yamuna River of Lakhwar MPP.
 Date of availability of bid document on e-portal: from 17:00 Hrs of 01.08.2026 to 17:00 Hrs of 20.08.2026
 Last date for hard copy submission of bid: 22.08.2026 up to 17:00 Hrs.
 Bid opening date: 24.08.2026 up to 11:30 Hrs
 For fuller & further details, kindly visit "e-procurement portal "http://uktenders.gov.in"
Executive Engineer (Civil-R&R-Tehri)
Lakhwar Project, Dakpathar
 "Avoid wasteful use of Electricity"


NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
 E-Procurement Tender Notice No.: 211-S/TS/Tender Notice/Trial01/2026-27
E-PROCUREMENT TENDER NOTICE Dated: 29.07.2026
 On behalf of the President of India, Principal Chief Engineer, North Central Railway, Prayagraj invites the following E-Procurement Tenders:-
 Manufacturing, Supply and Field Trial of Thick Web Switches without Relief Planing of Tongue Rail, utilizing existing 1 in 12 Thick Web Switches conforming to RDSO Drawing No. T-8780 & 1 in 8.5 Thick Web Switches conforming to RDSO Drawing No. T-9775:-

S.No.	Description of material	Tendered Qty.
1	Manufacturing, Supply and Field Trial of Thick Web Switches Without Relief Planing of Tongue Rail, utilizing existing 1 in 12 Thick Web Switches conforming to RDSO Drawing No. T-8780.	10 set.
2	Manufacturing, Supply and Field Trial of Thick Web Switches Without Relief Planing of Tongue Rail, utilizing existing 1 in 8.5 Thick Web Switches conforming to RDSO Drawing No. T-9775.	10 set.

Approximate Value of Tender: ₹ 1,45,49,400/- **Earnest Money: ₹ 2,90,990/-**
Completion Period: 06 Month, **Tender Opening Date : 31.08.2026**
Note: (1) The complete information about E-Procurement Tenders is available on IREPS website i.e. <http://www.ireps.gov.in>, up to 15.30 hrs. on the due date of tender opening. **(2)** Bids other than in the form of e-Bids shall not be accepted against above Tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with class III Digital signature certificates issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. **(3)** Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall only be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form/letter head if attached by vendor shall be straight away ignored and shall not be considered. **(4)** Documents being attached should be signed by the tenderer on its body. **(5)** Store items are reserved for RDSO approved/developmental order firms. **1745/26 (A)**

 North central railways  @CPRONCR  www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

महात्मा गांधी चित्रकूट ग्रामोदय विश्वविद्यालय
चित्रकूट, सतना, म.प्र. 485334
 पत्रक्र: Pur/ 26-27/387(D-6) निविदा सूचना दिनांक 30.07.2026
 शासन में पंजीकृत/निर्माता कम्पनियों/मुद्रकों/आपूर्तिकर्ता/निविदाकार फर्मों से निम्नलिखित सामग्रियों की आपूर्ति हेतु ई-निविदाये आमंत्रित की जाती है।

निविदा क्र	सामग्री/कार्य का विवरण	निविदा का मूल्य (रु. लाख में)	निविदा प्रश्न का मूल्य (रुपये)
149/pur/etend	etender for Printing of Study materials for Distance education center MGCGV Chitrakoot	40.00	4000.00
150/pur/etend	etender for Supplying, Installation, Testing and Commissioning of fire fighting work with Fire NOC at different buildings MGCGV Chitrakoot	28.24	3000.00

1. आपूर्तिकर्ता निविदाकार/मुद्रक वेबसाइट <http://mptenders.gov.in> पर NIT एवं विस्तृत निविदा देख सकते हैं।
 2. निविदा प्रश्न पोर्टल पर आनलाइन 05.08.2026 को 4:00 P.M. से उपलब्ध रहेगा, एवं 25.08.2026 को 5:00 P.M. तक भरा जा सकेगा। अन्य महत्वपूर्ण विधियों के लिये पोर्टल पर ई-निविदा प्रश्न देखें।
 3. निविदा में किसी भी प्रकार के संशोधन की सूचना केवल mptenders.gov.in पर प्रदर्शित की जायेगी।
 e-mail: http://purchase@gramodayachitrakoot.ac.in
 Website- <http://gramodayachitrakoot.ac.in>, Ph : 07670-265411

कुलसचिव


JAIPUR DEVELOPMENT AUTHORITY
 Indra Circle, Jawahar Lal Nehru Marg, Jaipur - 302004
 No. f.6(455047)JDA/Gen. Store/Stationary Supply/2026/D-245 Date : 28.07.2026
NOTICE INVITING BID
NIB No. JDA/G. Store/10/2026-27
 Online Bids are invited for "one year rate contract for Stationary supply" up to 10.08.2026 till 6.00 P.M. The estimated cost of work is Rs. 1,00,00,000/- (One Crore Only) The last date for applying for Bid and making Online Payment on JDA Portal is 10.08.2026 by 6:00 P.M. Details may be seen in the Bidding Document available on jda.rajasthan.gov.in, www.sppp.rajasthan.gov.in and www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in.
 UBN No. JDA2627GLRC00244

To participate in the bid, bidder has to be:
 1. Registered on JDA website jda.rajasthan.gov.in, for participating in the Bid, the Bidder has to apply for the Bid and pay the Bidding Document Fee, RISL Processing Fee and Bid Security Deposit, online only.
 2. Registered on e-procurement Portal of Government of Rajasthan www.eproc.rajasthan.gov.in for online e-Bid submission.
 Raj.Samwad/C/26/8303 Deputy Commissioner (Store)

Indian Missions lean on AI-enabled videos to serve diaspora better

Divya A
New Delhi, August 1

PLANNING A trip to India? We walk you through different types of Indian visas, along with the key steps, required documents, and essential guidance to help you prepare your application with confidence, says an official, dressed in crisp formals, in a video posted by the Consulate General of India in Munich a few days ago.

It may all seem normal, but the official in the video is 'Sarathi', an AI avatar, tackling issues that Indians abroad deal with — passports, visas, OCI services, birth registration, police clearance, and consular matters — beaming one video at a time. Another such video focuses on the important documents required while applying for a passport. The initiative was launched a month ago.

Officials say, "The initiative seeks to educate and assist the diaspora in the region by leveraging artificial intelligence and modern digital communication tools."

Indicating that this is what advisories for Indians abroad would look like in the future, another official adds, "By utilis-

Sarathi, an AI avatar, now tackles issues that Indians abroad deal with — passports, visas, OCI services, consular matters, police clearance and birth registration

ing concise audio-visual content instead of traditional text-based advisories alone, the initiative makes information more accessible and easier to comprehend for a wider and more diverse audience."

At the 11th Heads of Mission Conference held in April, themed around 'Reforming Indian Diplomacy for 2047', Prime Minister Narendra Modi had stressed on 3Ts — tourism, technology and trade — while addressing more than 180 Indian envoys who had been called to Delhi for the meet.

As per official sources, the initiative by the Munich mission came out of brainstorming sessions held at the meet, where it was observed that Indian missions were way behind

in leveraging technology towards extending their outreach to diaspora members, and the need for making the messaging "engaging, interactive and contemporary".

"In pursuance of the citizen-centric governance approach consistently emphasised by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the Consulate General of India, Munich, has launched an AI-enabled video awareness series featuring a virtual avatar named 'Sarathi'," said an official, adding, "the use of digital platforms facilitates broader dissemination of authentic consular information".

Additionally, Indian missions abroad have also been promoting and integrating ecosystem tools like the government's Bhashini AI platform to bridge the multilingual communication gap for diaspora citizens. The government's official voice-first platform allows users to translate text, documents, and voice seamlessly across dozens of Indian and international languages.

In fact, over the past few years, several Indian missions — that serve a sizable diaspora population — have rolled out chatbots and digital assistants

such as 'Bharati' and 'Pramit' to help users with their queries.

Among the first ones was the New York Consulate that serves 10 American states such as Connecticut, Massachusetts, New Jersey, New York, Ohio, Pennsylvania, and Vermont, comprising 2.5 million diaspora members. It deployed 'Bharati' on its website — a chatbot asking users: "Got any question?" and then allowing for subject-specific queries to be selected. The Consulate General of India in Dubai also has AI and chatbot technology integrated into its Pravasi Bharatiya Sahayata Kendra (PBSK) digital services, developed in collaboration with Zoho Corp, to handle frequent queries from Indian workers. Additionally, the official Indian Visa Su-Swagatam Mobile App has built-in chatbot support since 2024 for visa and e-FRRO services.

Even the Indian Embassy in Hungary, which also serves the neighbouring Bosnia and Herzegovina, has a built-in 'Bharati' chatbot on its website. The emphasis now is to channelise these platforms to multiply outreach, and also make their messaging more visual and interesting than just replying to standard text.

DAY AFTER MAN ARRESTED IN BENGAL FOR 'TARGETING CM'

Police say 'Jaish operative' also tried to sabotage CJP protest; aide held

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, August 1

THE ALLEGED Jaish-e-Mohammed operative arrested by the West Bengal Police's Special Task Force had planned to target Chief Minister Suvenud Adhikari and carry out sabotage at the recent students' protest at Delhi's Jantar Mantar by wearing a police uniform, the STF said Saturday.

The accused — identified as Mohammed Hamim Mondal — was arrested on Thursday night from a gym in Purba Bardhaman district, where he used to reside.

On Friday, Mondal was produced before Bardhaman court, which remanded him to 14-day police custody. Thereafter, he was brought to Kolkata for interrogation. Police had earlier revealed that Mondal was allegedly tracking CM Suvenud Adhikari.

Addressing a press conference in Kolkata on Saturday, IG (Special Task Force) Gaurav Sharma claimed that Mondal also planned on sabotaging the Cockroach Janta Party-led students' protest in Jantar Mantar, New Delhi.

"He was also given the task to procure a police uniform and visit Jantar Mantar for sabotage activities and creating disturbances," said Sharma.

The STF said that apart from allegedly planning to target CM Adhikari, the accused was also tracking various other politicians.

"Hamim communicated with encrypted code (via WhatsApp and other apps). They (his handlers) gave him the task to track and gather information on



Accused Mohammed Hamim Mondal's 'accomplice' Arpita Sarkar was arrested from Jharkhand on Saturday. EXPRESS

the movement of the chief minister (Adhikari) as well as some other ministers and politicians. There was a plan to target the CM," claimed Sharma.

The STF claimed that Mondal got in touch with Pakistan-based handlers through social media and communicated with them, who indoctrinated the accused.

Cops flag 'honey-trap'

The STF on Saturday also arrested an alleged woman accomplice of the suspected Jaish operative Hamim Mondal. According to police sources, the woman, identified as Arpita Sarkar, was arrested in Jharkhand's Sahibganj and brought to Bardhaman in West Bengal. Later in the day, she was produced before the Bardhaman court, which remanded her to 14-day police custody.

"After going through communications made by Hamim to others, we identified the woman. According to police, while Mondal was allegedly engaged in collecting information

on Chief Minister Suvenud Adhikari and some other ministers, Sarkar allegedly used to honey-trap individuals for information.

Both Mondal and Sarkar communicated through a special app", police said. Asked about Mondal's arrest, CM Adhikari had said on Friday, "It's a sensitive issue. STF and senior police officers are handling the case. He may have international connections; the police are investigating."

The sources said that before moving to Bardhaman, Mondal had been staying at a rented flat in Kolkata's New Town, and before that in the Pilkhana area of Howrah.

Preliminary investigation suggests that he had been tracking the movements of CM Adhikari and the routes his convoy took.


उत्तर प्रदेश पावर ट्रान्समिशन कारपोरेशन लि.
 विद्युत जानपद परेषण मण्डल, आगरा अत्यकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना, दिनांक 01.08.2026

अधोहस्ताक्षरी द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु पृथक निविदा दो भागों (पार्ट - I टेक्निकल बिड एवं पार्ट-II फाइनेंशियल) में आमंत्रित की जाती है। निविदा संख्या एवं कार्य का संक्षिप्त विवरण 1. अत्यकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या-10/विं.जां.पां.मं / आगरा / 2026-27- 220 के0वी0 उपकेन्द्र किरावली, आगरा पर 02 अड 132 के0वी0 टीएसएन0 फरह 'बे' के जानपदीय निर्माण कार्य। कार्य की अनुमानित लागत ₹0 51.18 लाख (जीएसटी0 अतिरिक्त), कार्य अवधि :- 03 माह 2. अत्यकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या 11/विं.जां.पां.मं / आगरा / 2026-27- 220 के0वी0 उपकेन्द्र बाह, आगरा पर 01 नग 33 के0वी0 मेसर्स प्रकाश रेन्यूवल पावर एल.एन.पी. आगरा 'बे' के जानपदीय निर्माण कार्य। कार्य की अनुमानित लागत :- ₹0 3.74 लाख (जीएसटी0 अतिरिक्त), कार्य अवधि :- 02 माह 3. अत्यकालीन ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या 12/विं.जां.पां.मं / आगरा / 2026-27- 220 के0वी0 उपकेन्द्र छाता जानपद मधुरा पर 01 अड 33 के0वी0 बरसाना लिंक लाइन 'बे' के निर्माण सम्बन्धी जानपदीय निर्माण कार्य। कार्य की अनुमानित लागत :- ₹0 4.41 लाख (जीएसटी0 अतिरिक्त), कार्य अवधि :- 02 माह उक्त निविदा की Technical Bid एवं अन्य शर्तें इत्या मात्रा बीजक इत्यादि का विस्तृत विवरण www.upptcl.org पर देखा जा सकता है एवं <http://etender.up.nic.in> साइट पर देखा एवं प्राप्त किया जा सकता है। निविदा दिनांक 18.08.2026 को दोपहर 12:00 बजे तक साइट पर डाला/अपलोड किया जा सकता है तथा दिनांक 18.08.2026 को 15:00 बजे सार्वजनिक रूप से निविदाये खोली जायेगी। "राष्ट्र हित में बिजली बनाएँ" हस्ता./-अध्यक्षण अभिनन्दन, विद्युत जानपद परेषण मण्डल, आगरा पत्रांक:-897/विं.जां.पां.मं.0/आ०/निविदा दिनांक: 01/08/2026

‘Rs 1,800 cr loss to EPFO’: CBI books Anil Ambani

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 1

THE CBI has registered an FIR against Reliance Capital Limited (RCL) and its former chairman Anil Ambani for allegedly causing a loss of Rs 1,816.22 crore to the Employees’ Provident Fund Organisation (EPFO).

Ambani, however, denied any wrongdoing, according to a statement issued by his spokesperson.

“The CBI has registered a FIR on July 31 on the basis of a written complaint received from the EPFO, Ministry of Labour and Employment, against M/s Reliance Capital Limited, Mumbai, Anil D. Ambani, its former Chairman, unknown public servants and other unknown persons for allegedly causing a wrongful loss of Rs 1,007.55 crore, along with an interest liability of Rs 808.67 crore, by committing offences including criminal conspiracy, cheating, criminal breach of trust and criminal misconduct,” a CBI spokesperson said in a statement.

“It has been alleged in the complaint that, during 2013 and

2014, RCL issued secured Non-Convertible Debentures (NCDs), in which the EPFO invested Rs 2,500 crore through four portfolio managers including Reliance Capital Asset Management Limited. The NCDs were due to mature during 2023 and 2024,” the spokesperson alleged.

“It is further alleged that the accused persons indulged in fraudulent transactions and diversion of funds, resulting in the default in redemption of the NCDs by Reliance Capital Limited and causing a total alleged loss of Rs 1,816.22 crore to the EPFO,” the spokesperson alleged.

Responding to the complaint, Ambani’s spokesperson said, “The FIR registered by the CBI pertains to Reliance Capital Limited. Mr Ambani served as a Non-Executive Director/Chairman of the Board of Reliance Capital Limited from 2005 until November 2021, when the Reserve Bank of India superseded the Board of Directors of the company and appointed an administrator. Anil Ambani denies any wrongdoing, whatsoever, and reserves all rights available to him in law.”

The Ministry of Labour and Employment sent the complaint after it was intimidated by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) that it had found documentary evidence and a transaction audit conducted by BDO India LLP that showed prima facie a number of fraudulent transactions by RCL and the persons in charge of its management during the period from December 7, 2019 to December 6, 2021. During an earlier period too, various fraudulent transactions were found which led to the ultimate failure of RCL “as a consequence of siphoning off of money of RCL”, the complaint alleged.

According to the FIR, the ED probe prima facie indicated a series of transactions involving irregular lending, diversion of funds, impairment of security and other acts by RCL that required investigation. “If established upon investigation, such conduct may have materially contributed to the financial deterioration of RCL, its inability to honour its obligation towards Debenture Holders, and the consequent loss of Rs 1,816.22 crore suffered by EPFO,” the complaint alleged.

SC judge says calling people ‘ants’ or other names unconstitutional

Justice Ujjal Bhuyan calls for greater transparency in judicial appointments

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, August 1

SUPREME COURT judge Justice Ujjal Bhuyan said on Saturday that the lack of transparency in judicial appointments could allow people to enter the judiciary who later go on to describe a group of people as “ants” and “get away with it,” calling such remarks “completely unconstitutional.”

Urging greater public scrutiny of those being considered for judgeship, Justice Bhuyan said, “To prevent entry of such people, there should be discussion, there should be some reasons given. What harm is caused if there is some discussion in the public about that these are the people who will be



Justice Ujjal Bhuyan

judges in our country?”

Justice Bhuyan made the remarks while speaking at an event at IIC New Delhi organised by the Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy for the release of a report titled “The Judicial Transparency Index.”

The report looked at how much information the Supreme Court and the 25 high courts make publicly available, including on court proceedings, administration and judicial appointments. It noted that while recent Collegium resolutions on appointments and transfers are available online, many do not give reasons for the recommendations.

Flagging what he described as the opacity surrounding the Collegium system, Justice Bhuyan said deliberations over the elevation and transfer of judges remain confidential, and reasons for rejecting or deferring recommendations are rarely disclosed in full.

He also questioned the absence of reasons in three Supreme Court Collegium resolutions from 2025, contrasting these with earlier resolutions where he said recommendations were supported by reasons.

He said the principle underlying open courts and the public’s right to know should also extend to information about those appointed as judges. “Citizens... have a right to know what is happening in the court. They have a right to know who would be their judges. They have a right to know what kind of judgments the honourable judge has delivered. This should be in the public domain,” he said.

Justice Bhuyan also referred to the SC Collegium’s January 18, 2023, resolution reiterating its recommendation to

appoint Senior Advocate Saurabh Kirpal as a judge of the Delhi High Court as an example where detailed reasons had been given. However, that recommendation had remained pending for over three years.

Referring to the Constitution Bench judgment that brought the office of the Chief Justice of India within the ambit of the Right to Information Act, he emphasised the relationship between judicial independence and accountability, quoting the court’s observation that “judicial independence cannot be used as a byword for avoiding accountability.”

While courts had made significant advances in transparency in their adjudicatory functions, including through live-streaming, Justice Bhuyan said the same openness had not necessarily extended to the judiciary’s own institutional processes.

He said that “a judiciary that has embraced publicity in its adjudicative function has been markedly more cautious about extending the same principle to its own constitutive process.”

Chandigarh lawyer shoots at landlady over eviction demand

Express News Service
Chandigarh, August 1

A 67-YEAR-OLD advocate Saturday allegedly shot at his 57-year-old landlady in Chandigarh’s Sector 42-C when she arrived at his rented apartment with police to execute a court’s eviction order, officials said.

The landlady Manvinder Kaur sustained a gunshot and was rushed to hospital, where her condition remains critical. The police overpowered the accused JPS Chadha, an advocate at the Punjab and Haryana HC, as he tried to fire another round from his shotgun. The gun was also seized.

According to DSP, Dhiraj Kumar, “The court order authorized the use of force, including breaking locks, to carry out the eviction and hand over possession to the rightful owner,” the DSP said. He said Chadha had been residing at the property as a tenant for the past 36 years and had been involved in a legal dispute with Manvinder’s husband Rajendra Singh over possession of the flat.



Top action

An Army jawan displays his skills ahead of the match between NorthEast United FC and Bodoland FC in the ongoing Durand Cup 2026, in Guwahati on Saturday. PTI

Daman MP Umesh Patel and ex-panchayat chief convicted in 2012 case

Kamal Saiyed
Surat, August 1

A CHIEF Judicial Magistrate’s (CJM) court in Daman convicted independent MP of the Union Territory, Umesh Patel, and former acting president of Daman District Panchayat Suresh alias Sukha Patel in a 14-year-old case of obstructing a public servant from doing their duty.

The court of Chief Judicial Magistrate P P Bharsakhade-Wagh sentenced the MP and the former panchayat president to two years’ simple imprisonment and gave them a month’s time to appeal in a higher court.

Umesh Patel, 48, won the Daman seat defeating the three-term BJP MP Lalu Patel in the 2024 Lok Sabha general elections as an Independent candidate. The case dates back to March 12, 2012, when interviews were on for the post of assistant sub-inspector for the excise department, at the Sports Club football ground in Daman. The two were accused of enter-



Independent MP Umesh Patel

ing the room where a candidate’s interview was underway and making “false allegations”.

Jagmahendra Singh, the then Assistant Superintendent of Police posted at Daman police headquarters, filed a complaint against Umesh Patel, who was the then president of the NGO Youth Action Force, and Suresh alias Sukha Patel, accusing them of threatening the police personnel present at the main entry gate and forcibly entering the football ground. “They entered the room where the candidates’ interview was in progress and made false accusations against the committee interviewing them,” the FIR had said.

No junk food within 50 metres of schools and colleges: New Karnataka advisory

Express News Service
Bengaluru, August 1

THE KARNATAKA Food Safety and Drug Administration (FSDA) department has issued an advisory restricting the sale of food products high in fat, sugar, and salt within a 50-metre radius of schools and colleges in the state. The advisory comes in the wake of FSDA inspections of food business establishments located around 134 schools and colleges in July.

“During the inspections, the quality of food products, hygiene and sanitation, compliance with food safety standards, labelling requirements, sale of expired food products

and validity of licences/registrations of Food Business Operators were verified... it was observed that certain food business establishments located within and around school and college premises were selling high fat, sugar and salt food products,” the FSDA said in a statement Friday.

Based on the findings, an advisory was issued on July 24 that sale of such products within 50 metres of school and college premises be discouraged, healthy food choices should be promoted, and food business operators strictly comply with the food safety regulations.

“District designated officers and food safety officers have been instructed to effectively

implement the advisory across the state and to create awareness among school and college managements, food business operators and the general public,” the FSDA said.

The department directed all food establishments located near schools to be licensed and registered under the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006. It also said that food safety officers would conduct regular inspections around schools, colleges.

Violation of the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006 and the Food Safety and Standards Rules/Regulations, 2011 will result in “issuance of improvement notices, suspension or cancellation of licence, seizure

of food products, and judicial proceedings, wherever necessary”, it added.

The advisory recommended that school meals be designed as cereal-protein combinations rich in micronutrients. It said menus should include whole grains, pulses, millets, and animal-based foods such as milk and eggs, and use fresh, seasonal, and locally available produce. To make the meals more nutritious, “fortified wheat flour, rice, milk, edible oil and double fortified salt may be used strictly adhering to the standards specified in the Food Safety and Standards (Fortification of Foods) Regulations, 2018”, the advisory further said.

AFTER SUPREME COURT ORDER

Gujarat DGP sets up SIT to probe ‘custodial death’ of 70-year-old

Aditi Raja
Vadodra, August 1

THE GUJARAT Police has constituted a three-member special investigation team (SIT) to probe the alleged custodial death of 70-year-old Zahiruddin Shaikh at Ahmedabad’s Vejalpur police station, days after the Supreme Court directed the registration of an FIR and ordered an independent probe.

The SIT has been constituted by Gujarat Director General of Police G S Malik in compliance with the SCs July 23 order. The team will be headed by SP (CID Crime) Rohan Anand and comprise CID Crime Deputy SP P D Vala and CID Crime Police Inspector N H Siddiqui.

In a communication to the Ahmedabad police commissioner, the DGP has directed that an FIR be registered on charges of murder and abetment of suicide, in accordance with the Supreme Court order. The SIT was constituted following a July 23 SC order by a bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana. The bench observed that there was a prima facie case for registration of an FIR after considering the submissions made by Senior Advocate I H Syed, appearing for the petitioner’s family.

“We are satisfied that a prima facie case for registration of an FIR under Sections 103 and 108 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023, without naming any suspects at this stage, is made out. Consequently, the said FIR shall be investigated by an Special Investigation Team, comprising of a police officer of the rank of deputy commissioner of police

along with two more officers, to be nominated by the director general of police, Gujarat...”, the order states.

The SC order further directed, “The members of the SIT must be those who are not posted in the district where the alleged occurrence took place. The SIT is directed to file the final report after investigation before the jurisdictional magistrate as early as possible, and preferably within two months.”

The SC’s intervention came on an appeal filed by Zahiruddin Shaikh’s son, Tofik, challenging the failure of the authorities to register a criminal case over his father’s death after he was taken into custody by the Vejalpur police. Shaikh was arrested on May 18 in connection with an alleged cow slaughter case registered by the Vejalpur police. His family has alleged in their petition that police personnel forcibly administered 30 to 40 tablets of prescription medicines to Shaikh, resulting in a fatal overdose on May 20.

The SC’s directions came nearly two months after the Gujarat HC declined to order registration of an FIR, holding that the petitioner must first exhaust the statutory remedies available under the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita. Even while dismissing the petition on May 29, the HC had observed that it was “ironic” that an alleged violation of the SC’s Constitution bench judgment in Lalita Kumari vs Government of UP on mandatory registration of FIRs in cognisable offences could not be directly enforced through a writ petition because of the doctrine of alternative statutory remedy.



पर्यटन मंत्रालय
MINISTRY OF
TOURISM

Institute of Hotel Management, Dehradun
(Under the aegis of Ministry of Tourism, Govt. of India, Affiliated to NCHMCT, Noida)

PUBLIC NOTICE

Applications invited for vacant seats for Academic Session 2026-2027

- Applications are invited from eligible candidates for vacant seats in the 3-year B.Sc. HHA degree program for the Academic Session 2026-2027. This degree is awarded by Jawaharlal Nehru University (JNU), New Delhi.
- In addition, applications are invited from eligible candidates of all categories for admission to Craftsmanship and Diploma Programs.
- Government Scholarships available as per norms.

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Principal, IHM Dehradun
Nimbuwala, Garhi Cantt., Dehradun-248 003



CHANDIGARH HOUSING BOARD
A Chandigarh Administration Undertaking

PUBLIC NOTICE

CHANDIGARH HOUSING BOARD

Notice for inviting e-bids for auction of 14 residential properties on freehold basis, in U.T. Chandigarh.

It is hereby notified for the information of general public that e-bids are invited for the sale of 14 residential properties on freehold basis in U.T. Chandigarh. E-bids are invited individually for each Unit.

- The E-Bid process is open for all the citizens of India as well as NRIs/PIOs above 18 years of age.
- The Units shall be allotted to the highest eligible bidder, quoting above the reserve price of the Unit. GST will not be applicable on the consideration/premium of the unit on built up residential properties.
- All willing participants may visit the official website of the Chandigarh Housing Board www.chbonline.in and https://gem.gov.in/training/training_module to understand the detailed procedure for submission of Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) and e-bids. The Terms & Conditions and the detailed List mentioning localities/sectors of the Units, EMD and reserve price can be downloaded from the official website of the Chandigarh Housing Board and GeM Portal.
- In order to submit e-bids, every prospective bidder is required to get himself/herself registered at GeM Portal.
- Stickers have been pasted at each of the Unit for better identification and Site Offices have been provided at different Sectors/Location to facilitate inspection by the prospective bidders. The location of each of the unit on google map, address of the Site Offices and contact details of the officials are available on the official website www.chbonline.in. The days specified for the inspections of the units are as under:

Sr. No	Units	No. of Units	Days for inspections (10.00 AM to 05.00 PM)
1	14 residential properties on freehold basis	14	Every Saturday till the end of Deposit of EMD amount

Schedule of Auction	
Start date for payment of EMD	03-08-2026 (10:00 AM)
End date for payment of EMD	12-08-2026 (05:00 PM)
Start date of E-Auction	14-08-2026 (09:00 PM)
End date of E-Auction	24-08-2026 (04:00 PM)

Chief Accounts Officer,
Chandigarh Housing Board,
Chandigarh,



भारत निर्वाचन आयोग
Election Commission of India

SIR 2026

हरियाणा

SIR 2026 का ड्राफ्ट इलेक्टरल रोल 31 जुलाई, 2026 को प्रकाशित कर दिया गया है।



आप अपनी वोटर डिटेल्स <https://ceoharyana.gov.in/> पर चेक कर सकते हैं।



अगर आपकी डिटेल्स में कोई गलती है तो फॉर्म 8 एवं घोषणा-पत्र भर कर अपने क्षेत्र के ERO/AERO को 30 अगस्त, 2026 से पहले जमा करवाएं।



**सही जानकारी, मजबूत लोकतंत्र
आपका वोट, आपकी ताकत**

अधिक जानकारी के लिए अपने बूथ लेवन ऑफिसर (BLO) से संपर्क करें



फॉर्म 8 (घोषणा पत्र)

VOTE

Classifieds

PERSONAL

I, Jasvinder Kaur, W/o Davinder Pal Singh R/o 40, J&K Block, Laxmi Nagar, Delhi, have changed my name to Jasvinder Kaur. 0040869537-1

I, MOHD HASEEN, S/O MUNNA KHAN, R/O 49, GALLI NO. 9A, ZAKIR NAGAR, JAMIA NAGAR, OKHLA, NEW DELHI-110025, inform that in my sons's (SAIF ALI) 10th Class Mark-Sheet my name is wrongly-written HASEEN AHMAD instead of MOHD HASEEN, for all future purposes. 0040869553-8

I, NEELU D/o DHARAMBIR SINGH, R/o Village Hansawas Khurd, Hansawas Khurd (39) Charkhi Dabri Haryana-127308 have changed my name to NIMRAT. 0040869558-10

I, Mr Shaurya Anand, s/o Mr Umesh Kumar age 36 yrs resident of 391 sec 15 Gurgaon Haryana 122001 declare that my name in PAN card changed from Shaurya Anand to Shaurya Anand and new name to be used for all purposes in future. 0130067519-1

I, Deepika, W/o-Sahil Kukreja R/o-76-C, UGF, Single Storey Ramesh-Nagar Delhi-15 have changed my name to Deepika Kataria. 0040869553-1

I, KM. SEEMA MALIK W/O Avdresh Kumar, R/o 89/90, Gali number 6 Wazirabad, Delhi-110084 have changed my name to Seema. 0040869558-2

I, Umashankar Biswas S/o Tapan Chandra Biswas, residing at shop no 11, 25 feet road, Shyam vihar phase 1, Delhi, 110043, do hereby declare that the name [Umashankar Biswas] and [Uma Shankar Biswas] belong to one and the same person, which is myself. Both names refer to me identically for all legal intents and purposes. 0071051544-1

I, Geeta, wife of Mr. Jagdish Chand R/o Flat No. 3235, 2nd Floor, Block - E, Adarsh Apartment, Sector - 4C, Vasundhara, Ghaziabad - 201012 do hereby solemnly affirm and declare that Geeta and Geeta Rani both are same person and shall be known as Geeta Rani for all future purposes. 0040869534-1

I, Oswaldo Romeo Pereira S/o Cyprian Pereira R/o H.O. C-25, Near NTPC Flats, Sector-33, Noida, UP-201307, have changed my name to OSWALD PEREIRA for all future purposes. 0071051532-1

I, Mohammed Salim, S/O Mohammed Hussain, R/o- 1038, Gali. No.-5, Rajeev Garden, Loni Dehat, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201102, have changed name of my minor son Anash aged-15 years and he shall hereafter be known as Anas. 0040869558-12

Anjani Kumar Singh S/o Dinesh Kumar Singh R/o Kapashera New Delhi-110037 changed my minor daughter's name from Varsha Kumari to Kirat Singh vide affidavit dt. 27-07-2026. 0050294191-1

I, NEHA MADAN, D/O DEEPAK MADAN, R/O-108, 2ND FLOOR, POCKET-1, SECTOR-21, ROHINI, DELHI-110086, have changed my name to NEHA SHARMA. 0040869558-4

I, RASHI D/o Ajit Kumar, R/o: F-264, First Floor, Vikasपुरी, Tilak Nagar, New Delhi-110018 Have Changed My Name to RASHI KUMAR. 0071051579-1

I, Rahul Sisodia S/o Virendra Singh Shishodia R/o 3-H-160, Nehru Nagar, Ghaziabad, U.P-201001, have changed my minor daughter's name Soumya to correct name as Soumya Sisodia for all purposes. 0040869524-1

I, NIDHI KHANNA, W/o-Ram Kumar, R/o: DB-25F LIG Flats, Hari Nagar, New Delhi-110064, Have Changed My Name to NIDHI CHAUDHARY. 0040869583-1

I, PRABHUOT KAUR RAINU W/O PRITAM SINGH born on 24-09-1990 residing at 1117 RANI BAGH DELHI-110034 have changed my name to PRABHUOT KAUR vide affidavit 0050294193-1

I Sumit Goyal Father of Raghav Goyal R/o AG-386, 1st Floor Shalimar Bagh, Delhi-110088, that my son is minor and I have changed my Son's Name from Raghav to Raghav Goyal for all future Purposes. 0040869533-1

I, hitherto known as Sidharth, S/O Girdhari Lal, R/O H.O. No. 24, Nehru Kutia, Malka Gani, Delhi-110007, have changed my name and shall hereafter be known as Sidharth Kumar. 0040869553-5

I, SUDHA SINGH W/o-PRADEEP KUMAR RANI R/O H.O. No. 9, Pocket-8, Sector-21, Rohini, Delhi-110086 have changed my name SUDHA SINGH after marriage 0040869558-6

I, Aditya, son of Rishipal Ghangas, resident of Flat S1, 2nd Floor, Gokulam, No. 1 Kamashil Rao Street, Patel Nagar, West Tambaram, Tamil Nadu-600045, have changed my Name from Aditya to Aditiya Ghangas vide Affidavit: IN-TN68258670749509, dated 22/07/2026 before Combined Court Complex, Tambaram, Chennai. 0040869548-2

I, Madhu Satija W/o, Shri Laxmi Narayan Satija R/o, 9102/10F, Homekraft Nobility, P No.-1/GH04, Gr. Noida West, Sector-4, Noida hereby declare that I have changed my name Madhu Devi to Madhu Satija for all the future purpose. 0040869261-1

I, MOHD HASEEN, S/O MUNNA KHAN, R/O 49, GALLI NO. 9A, ZAKIR NAGAR, JAMIA NAGAR, OKHLA, NEW DELHI-110025, inform that in my sons's (SAMEER) 10th Class Mark-Sheet my name is wrongly-written HASIN MOHAMMAD instead of MOHD HASEEN for all future purposes. 0040869553-7

I, Surpreet Arora@ Surpreet Kaur Arora, W/o-Bhavdeep Singh R/o-J-50-Kirti Nagar New Delhi-110015, have changed my name to SURPREET KAUR, for all purposes. 0040869558-8

I, WASEEM KHAN, S/O-MOHD YAOOOB, 2106, Gali. No-37, Naivawla, Hasall Bagh, Delhi-110005, I have Changed My name WASEEM, MD. WASEEM, MOHAMMAD WASEEM, WASIM, MOHD WASEEM, to WASEEM KHAN, For All Purpose. 0130067518-1

I, Vishvjit S/o Aatar Singh R/o 59, Aurangabad Ristal, Ghaziabad-201003 confirm that Vishvajet Singh Verma S/o Aatter singh Verma, Vishvajet Singh S/o Ater Singh, And Vishvjit S/o Atar Singh names are belongs to same person. Will be Known as Vishvjit S/o Atar Singh 0071051542-1

I, Riyaz Ahmad Ganai/Dr Riyaz Ahmad Hassan, S/o-Ghulam Hassan Ganai, R/o-H. No. F-3/109, Southend Apartment, Charmwood-Village, Faridabad, Haryana, have changed my name to Riyaz Ahmad, for all purposes. 0040869553-3

I, Geeta Jain, W/o Rattan Chand Jain, R/o-Plot No-155, Block-B, Maharana Pratap-Enclave, Pitampura, Delhi, have changed my name to Daya Rani. 0040869537-2

I, Varinder Singh S/O SWARN Singh Kalsi R/O 399, Kohat Enclave, Pitampura, Delhi-110034 Have Changed my Name to Varinder Singh Kalsi. 0040869558-1

I, Asha Ashik, wife of, Ashik S, R/O-vill- Pattazhy post-Pattazhy dist- Kollam, State-Keralam pin- 691522, have changed my name, from Asha Ashik to Asha S Das, vide-affidavit, date, 01/08/2026 0040869558-11

I, AZRA UBAID W/o UBAID KHALIL R/o 4714, GALI RAZIA BEGUM, HAUZ QAZI, DELHI-110006, CHANGED MY NAME AS "AZRA" 0130067520-1

I, KM SHASHI, W/O BHURA SINGH R/O VILLAGE GANESHPUR, POST SAHAJPUR, ALIGARH, UP have changed my name to SHASI KUMARI. 0040869553-2

I, Savita W/o Sanjeev Kumar, R/o-Kh. No.37/5, Gali No. 1, Sanjay Colony, Narela Delhi-110040, have changed my name from Savita Chauhan, to Savita, for all purposes. 0040869558-3

I, Yogendra Sharma S/o Devi Prasad R/o-100B, New Mandi, Muzaffarnagar, UP have changed my name to Yogendra Kumar Sharma. 0071051546-1

I, Chander Prakash, R/o-17/7, Indira Vikas Colony, North Side Near MukherjeeNagar, Delhi-09, declares the parents name of TAKSHEEL LOHIA, haswornly given as Kanchan & Chander Parkash in school records whereasis parents actual names are SMT. KANCHAN LATA & CHANDERPRAKASH which may be amended accordingly. 0040869525-1

I, Nikita Maheshwari wife of Mr, Janak Maheshwari resident of C-3/173, sector-31 Noida 201301 want to inform that my former name was Nikita Bhandari daughter of late Manoj Bhandari and after marriage I have changed my name to Nikita Maheshwari. 0060144562-1

I, Usha paroha mother of NB SUB Lokmani paroha resident of VILL-LIG-380, Madhavnagar, murwara, karnati, madhyapradesh-483501 I have changed my Name from Usha divedi to Usha paroha, vide affidavit dated- 30/07/2026, before Shashif Thakur, Advocate, Delhi/Area, NCT/Delhi. 0050294198-1

I, Kuldeep Sharma S/o-Ishwar Dutt Kaushik, R/O B-6/44-45, GF/F, F, sector-8, Rohini Delhi-110085, have changed my name to KULDEEP for all future purposes. 0040869553-4

I, Maanana Atray W/o Tejas Kapoor R/o, Flat-No-359, DDA SFS-Flat, Pocket-1 And 2, Sector-3, Dwarka, South-West Delhi-110078, have changed my name to Maanana Kapoor permanently. 0040869558-5

I, Kamlesh, W/o Suraj Pal Singh, R/o 98, shanti Nagar, Behind Modern Public School, Near RahisPur, Sector-23, Sanjay Nagar, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201001, Declare that Kamlesh and Kamlesh Singh are one and the same person. 0071051597-1

I, Rishipal, resident of Flat S1, 2nd Floor, Gokulam, No. 1 Kamashil Rao Street, Patel Nagar, West Tambaram, Tamil Nadu-600045, have changed my Name from Rishipal to RishipalGhangas vide Affidavit: IN-TN68258344585150Y, dated 22/07/2026 before Combined Court Complex, Tambaram, Chennai. 0040869548-1

I, RAM KUMAR, S/o-Duli Chand, R/o:DB-25F LIG Flats, Hari Nagar, New Delhi-110064, Have Changed My Minor Daughter's Name from AKSHITA to AKSHITA CHAUDHARY. 0040869583-2

I, Rattan Lal S/o Jagannath Prasad Gupta, R/o Flat No-262, Sangam Apartment, West Enclave, Pitampura, Delhi-110034, hereby declare that I have changed my name from Rattan Lal to Rattan Lal Gupta for all future purposes. 0040869548-3

I, Ramayan prasad paroha father of NB SUB Lokmani paroha resident of Vill-LIG-380, Madhavnagar, karni murwara, madhyapradesh-483501 I have changed my Name from Ramayan divedi to Ramayan prasad paroha, vide affidavit dated- 30/07/2026, before Shasti Thakur, Advocate, Delhi/Area- NCT/Delhi. 0050294200-1

I, Surinder Raiilya alias Surender Kumar, S/o-Suraj Prakash Raiilya, R/o-302, Third-Floor, Ambica Vihar, Paschim Vihar, Delhi-110087, have changed my name to Surinder Kumar Raiilya 0040869553-6

I, RENU JAIN W/o ALOK JAIN R/o-C-5205 Yamuna Vihar North, East Delhi-110053, have changed my name to MRIDULA JAIN. 0040869558-7

I Ashish Kumar S/o Madan Gopal Sharma R/o H. No. F-13, B-13-C, Khasra No. 74/4, Block K-2, Krishan Vihar, Sultanpur, Delhi-110086 declares that in my son Anshu Kumar School Record my and my wife name wrongly mentioned as Ashish Sharma And Sunita but our correct name is Ashish Kumar And Sunita Sharma. 40869193-2

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SITUATION VACANT

Applications are invited for the JRF position in an ANRF-funded project at the Department of ECE, Faculty of Technology, University of Delhi. Visit the University website under Work with DU - Advertisement - Department. Email your CV and supporting documents to drsamanataray@fot.du.ac.in by August 14, 2026. 0050294250-1



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Sikh 38M 5'10" BTech seeks homely / professional match. Family Delhi based. Whatsapp 9818559090, 9936092227. 0050293425-3

PUBLIC NOTICE

MY CLIENT NARESH KUMAR S/O DASS RAM AND KUSUM LATA W/O NARESH KUMAR R/O A-1/55 GALLI NO. 22 KATYANI VIHAR, RAJEEV NAGAR EXT. NEW DELHI, 110086, HAVE SERVED ALL THEIR INTERESTATIONS & DISOWNED THEIR DAUGHTER AKTI FROM ALL THEIR MOVABLE/IMMOVABLE PROPERTIES DUE TO HER DISOBEDIENT. MY CLIENT SHALL NOT BE RESPONSIBLE FOR HER ACTS.

Sd/-
KAPIL SINGH
Advocate
Office: C-31/09,
Sector-11, Rohini,
Delhi-110085.

PUBLIC NOTICE

My client Sri Ganga Ram S/o Shri Ram Gopal R/o Block AG-580, Shalimar Bagh, Delhi, 110088 hereby declares that he has disowned and debarred his son Sri Dinesh Kumar his wife Smt. Deepti and their two children from all his movable and immovable properties due to their misconduct and improper behaviour and my client will not be responsible for his any acts/deeds.

Sd/- Pankaj Kumar Pandey Advocate, Enrl. No.: UP1739/06

PUBLIC NOTICE

GENERAL PUBLIC IS INFORMED HEREBY THAT MY CLIENT SRI ABHISHEK TYAGI SON OF SRI NARESH TYAGI BORN IN, 43, BRAHMAN CHAUHAL, PANA, DHANWARA, VILLAGE BAWAL, DISTRICT LUDHIANA, PUNJAB, AGREEMENT TO SELL, WILL, POSSESSION LETTER, AFFIDAVIT AND RECEIPT IF ANY ALL DATED JUTIZED IN FAVOUR OF ABHISHEK TYAGI SON VIRENDER TYAGI IN THE NAME OF PROPERTY IN REGD. NO. 3, AREA MEASURING ABOUT 90 SQ.YARDS, NEAR BALMI MANDIR, OLD LALDORA, RAWANA, DELHI-11009, BEING PRATENTED AND FORGED AND ANY TRANSACTION BASED UPON THE ABOVE SAID DOCUMENTS SHALL BE DEEMED AS NULL AND VOID.

Sd/-
S.K. SAKSHI
Advocate
CH-130K, LAWYERS CHAMBER BLOCK,
ROHINI COURTS, DELHI-110085

PUBLIC NOTICE

General Public is hereby informed that my client, Sh. Raju Thapar Son of Late Sh. Shyam Swaroop Thapar, Resident of K-86, Third Floor, Kalkaji, New Delhi-110019, is filing application in I & O for substitution of property No. K-454K Kalkaji, New Delhi-110019 in his own name which was earlier in the name of Late Sh. Shyam Swaroop Thapar on the ground of Rajgushnigini Deed. If there are any objections/claims from general public on this application, the same shall be communicated to I & O with respecting documents through Registered Post or by visiting LDO Sankalp Bhawan, K-86 Marg, New Delhi or through an E-Mail at klogidc.in within 30 days of the publication of this Notice.

Puneet Dhwani (Advocate)
Ch. No. 339, Saket Courts New Delhi-17

PUBLIC NOTICE

IT IS HEREBY INFORMED THAT SMT. MANJEET KAUR HAS APPLIED FOR DEED FROM LICHER IN RESPECT OF THE RESIDENTIAL FIRST FLOOR WITHOUT HER RIGHTS OR INTERESTS IN THE PROPERTY 2/48, AREA MEASURING 130.50 YDS, OF RECTANGLE, NEW DELHI-110032, SITUATED IN THE AREA OF VILLAGE KIVYALA AND THE COLONY KNOWN AS VASINI GARDEN FALGOK, NEW DELHI-110032. COLONY REGULARIZED BY MCD NEW DELHI RESOLUTION NO. 863 ON 08/07/2010. THE SELLER SMT. KULVINDER KAUR DOES NOT HAVE THE ORIGINAL SALE DEED. HEREBY SHE IS DISOWNED BY SRI JOGINDER SINGH IN FAVOUR OF SMT. RANI BAL, BEING REGISTERED DOCUMENT NUMBER 7298, BOOK NUMBER 1, VOLUME NUMBER 1588, FILE NUMBER 1177, IN THE OFFICE OF SRI H. DELHI. THE ABOVE ORIGINAL DOCUMENTS HAVE BEEN LOST MISPLACED, AND AN FIR IN THIS REGARD WAS LOGGED ON 31/07/2026. IF ANY OTHER CLAIMANT HAS ANY RIGHT IN THE ABOVE SAID PROPERTY, HE/SHE SHOULD INFORM A CRIMINATION TO THE UNDER SIGNED WITHIN 15 DAYS FROM THE DATE OF ISSUE OF THIS NOTICE.

Sd/-
B.K. MUKHERJEE
Advocate
NORTH-CE-2, Naraina Colony,
Tis Hazari, Delhi-110005.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Informd that my client Mr. Rahul Gupta is the owner of First Floor, without roof rights, of Prop. No. F-223, area 83.6 sq. mt., old Plot No. 5, Block-4, Khasra No. 373 Situated at Vill. Salempur Marza, Madpur, Kishi Nagar, Shakur Basti, Delhi-34. Initially the aforesaid Property was in the name of Mr. Hans Raj Kaur. Thereafter it was executed a Regd. Will dt. 12.10.2012 in favour of his wife Ms. Samosh Kaur. After the death of Prop. No. F-223, area 150 sq. yrd. & other properties. Later on Mr. Hans Raj Kaur died on 05.12.2014, after which Surviving Member Certificate of above died person was not obtained. Any person dealing with the same document may do so at his/her own risk and I, the undersigned, have no claim on the basis of the title document will be entertained within 15 days of publication, failing which any such rights, title interest or claim if any, will be deemed to have waived and not binding on our clients.

Sd/-
Yogesh Kumar
Advocate
Office No. 2, First Floor,
Kalyan Kunj Chaudhary Farm,
Near Piller No. 37, Sector-49,
Noida, G. B. Nagar

PUBLIC NOTICE
Under instructions of my clients, **Mrs. Laxman Kumar S/o** Late Vidho Ram & **Mrs. Krishna Devi W/o** Mr. Laxman Kumar both R/o T 235/43C, Road No.20, Balajpet Nagar, Patel Nagar, Central Delhi-110008, General Public is informed that my clients hereby declare their son **Mr. Hemant Kumar** and his/her daughter-in-law **Mrs. Chanchal** & their children from all their immovable properties and Movable assets, as well as accounts, liabilities, disbursements, & rude behaviour with my client. My clients & their family members will not be responsible for their any kind of liabilities, dealings, acts, criminal proceedings, obligations, financial transactions, claims etc. My clients have severed all relations with them.
Shashi Ranjan (Advocate)
Ch.No.509, Patiala House Court, Delhi-01.

PUBLIC NOTICE
I know to all that my clients **Sh. Vijay Pal Jagannad, S/o** Late Sh. Dev Singh and **Smt. Manju Jagannad W/o** Sh. Vijay Pal Jagannad both R/o 6/97, First Floor, Gali No.4, Block No.8, Dev Nagar Karol Bagh, Delhi, GPO, Central NCT Of Delhi-110026, New Delhi, have broken all connections with their son **Sh. Manav Jagannad** and his wife **Smt. Sakshi**. Due to his misconduct and hostile behavior, they will have no right, title, claim or share in any of their properties present or in future. My client shall not be responsible for any acts & deeds of **Sh. Manav Jagannad** and his wife **Smt. Sakshi** relate any person related to them, in any manner whatsoever.
RISHABH GULATI (Advocate)
Ch. No. 119-A (Basement), Civil Side, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi-110054

TO WHOMSOEVER IT MAY CONCERN, Notice is hereby given that **Mrs. Rewa Lamba, w/o** Sh. Vinod Lamba, owner of the front portion of the 3rd Floor, Property No. C-17, Friends Colony (East), New Delhi, with terrace rights, servant quarter, one car parking, common facilities, and proportionate undivided share in the land, has agreed to sell the said property to **Mr. Nalin Tripathi**. Any person having any claim, right, title, or interest in the said property through her or her predecessor(s) may contact 8527757230 within 15 days of this notice, failing which the sale shall proceed without further reference. **Nishank Tripathi** Advocate

PUBLIC NOTICE
Be it known to all that my clients, **Sri Sarabjit Singh, Shri Bhupinder Singh alias Bhupinder Singh Ahluwalia** both sons of Late **Shri Des Raj Singh, Smt. Anita Kaur W/o** Shri Bhupinder Singh, Smt. Gurdev Kaur D/o Shri Bhupinder Singh, Shri Gursaraj Singh S/o Shri Bhupinder Singh all R/o 34/1 Punjabi Bagh, New Delhi-110026 are the joint owners of freehold property bearing No.54, Block-88, known as House No.3, Doctor Lane, Gole Market, New Delhi-110001 measuring total land area 1672.22 Sq. Yds or there about. My entire superfluous built up thereon (the said Property) vide Conveyance Deed dated 25.04.2007 registered as Doc. No.11235, Sub-Regd. No.1, Volume No. 2575 at pages 150 to 196 on 15.06.2007 with Registrar-VII, New Delhi executed by President of India through Land & Development Officer, Nirman Bhawan, New Delhi. Original title documents of aforesaid property i.e. Parganah Gaothar Deed dated 09.02.1923, Sahi Deed dated 25.05.1993 registered on 25.06.1993, Conveyance Deed dated 25.04.2007 registered on 15.06.2007 and other certified documents are in laminated form. Aforesaid owners intend to create a charge viz mortgage or otherwise, on the said Property on basis of above mentioned laminated original Title Deeds & other documents as guarantor for loan/credit facility granted to be granted to M/s Indusindia Tapes Private Limited by State Bank of India, Industrial Finance Branch, CCG, 14th Floor, Jawahar Vihar, Convent, New Delhi-110001. In case any person/entity has any claim/objection towards above said property, the same should be lodged with the undersigned within (fifteen) days from publication of this notice.

Rajendra Gupta, Advocate
Ch. No. E-516, Karkardomma Court Complex, Delhi-110032
Mob-9811477690, 9311477690
Email: riyanshlegals@gmail.com

PUBLIC NOTICE
Aforesaid owners intend to create a charge viz mortgage or otherwise, on the said Property on basis of above mentioned laminated original Title Deeds & other documents as guarantor for loan/credit facility granted to be granted to M/s Indusindia Tapes Private Limited by State Bank of India, Industrial Finance Branch, CCG, 14th Floor, Jawahar Vihar, Convent, New Delhi-110001. In case any person/entity has any claim/objection towards above said property, the same should be lodged with the undersigned within (fifteen) days from publication of this notice.

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PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED
(See Section 82 Cr PC/84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Gulab Chand S/O Sh. Ram Shankar R/O Village Bhaktawar Pur Distt Saharsa Bihar Also at Kuki Ka Plat Near Pandit Murga Farm Bangali Basti Rangpur, New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 476/2015 U/s 354/C IPC at P.S. V.K. South, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Gulab Chand** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Gulab Chand** have absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Gulab Chand of FIR No. 476/2015 U/s 354/C IPC at P.S.: V.K. South, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 07.09.2026**
By order
Ms. Kavita Bist
Judicial Magistrate, First Class-01
Mahila Court No.01, 11 First Floor
Main Building Patiala House Court
New Delhi
DP/10554/SW/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 (ii) Cr. P.C.
Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Sandeep Pandey S/o** Sh. Ram Naresh Pandey R/o H.No. E-1, Flate No. 7, Mahaveer Campus Rajpur Khurd, Chhatrapur, New Delhi also at: JMD Apartment 134, Flate No. G-1, G.F, Kh. No. 619, 21, Block-B, Chhatrapur, New Delhi, have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under **CC No. 1760/2021 U/s 138 NI Act.**, has been registered at **PS: Sangam Vihar, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **Sandeep Pandey** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Sandeep Pandey** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Sandeep Pandey** under **CC No. 1760/2021 U/s 138 NI Act.**, registered at **PS: Sangam Vihar, New Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **01.09.2026**.
By Order
Ms. Pooja Kumari
JMFC (NI Act-01), Room No. 25
Saket Court, Delhi
DP/10661/SD/2026 (Court Notice)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED
(See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Md. Shahrukh S/o Md. Akram R/o H.No. D-54, Batla House Jamia Nagar New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 140/2024 U/s 25/54/49 Arms Act at P.S. Hazrat Nizamuddin, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrants of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Md. Shahrukh** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Md. Shahrukh** have absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Md. Shahrukh of FIR No. 140/2024 U/s 25/54/49 Arms Act of P.S.: Hazrat Nizamuddin, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 09.09.2026**.
By order
Manuj Kaushal
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
South East District, Room No.512
Saket Court, New Delhi
DP/10570/SE/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82(2) (ii) Cr. P.C./84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita
Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused person Namely **Govinda S/o** Ratnada R/o Vegabond, Mother Dairy, Delhi, have committed (or is suspected to has committed) the offence under **FIR No.158/2022 U/s 379/411 IPC.**, has been registered at **PS: Darya Ganj, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **Govinda** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Govinda** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Govinda** of under has been under **FIR No.158/2022 U/s 379/411 IPC.**, registered at **PS: Darya Ganj, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **11.09.2026**.
By Order
Ms. Nidhi Bala
JMFC (NI Act-05), Room No. 241
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi
DP/10629/CD/2026 (Court Notice)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)
Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Sherdin Singh S/o** Prem Chand R/o H. No. 110, Main Chowk, Bhorgarh, Delhi-110040 has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **CC NI ACT 41/2022 U/s 138 NI ACT, PS Nihal Vihar, Delhi** and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Sherdin Singh** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my

Space beyond political parties



ACROSS THE AISLE
BY P CHIDAMBARAM

THE JANTAR Mantar agitation started by the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) taught a lesson that was not learned by political parties in 79 years of democratic politics in India. The first hint of such a 'lesson' was visible earlier this year, but of that a little later.

Hitherto, history has taught us that political parties, through struggle and winning elections, can bring about change. That lesson still remains true. Congress led the movement that won independence. By winning successive elections, Congress erected several pillars of Indian democracy such as Constitutional rule, secularism, reservation, linguistic states, an independent central bank, devolution of resources, etc. Regional parties — for example, the Dravidian parties — won elections in states and asserted the primacy of the State's language, States' rights, cultural identity, land reforms, etc. The JP-led movement in 1975 replaced a central government and enacted Constitutional safeguards for liberty. The AASU movement in 1978 triggered legal provisions to control cross-border migration. In fact, it can be confidently asserted that *all* major changes in the governance of India were

brought about by political parties through struggle and elections.

Unusual Qualifications

CJP is not a political party in the conventional sense. It was born out of the angry reaction of one person, Mr Abhijeet Dipke. Evidently, Mr Dipke and some of his friends were deeply hurt by a seemingly provocative remark. Mr Dipke started a platform and asked "*What if all cockroaches got together?*". He declared that anyone can join the platform who is '*unemployed, lazy, chronically online and having the ability to rant professionally*'. Apparently, there are many including students and scholars who meet the unusual qualifications! There are also many who are employed but are chronically online and can rant professionally. These include honourable men and women such as artistes, teachers, doctors, nurses, advocates, businesspersons, journalists, other professionals and junior government employees.

The platform has a founder-leader, spokespersons, grit and little else. As far as is known, there is no organization, no membership, no registration, no declaration of policies, or any other features of a political party. Yet, through a 35-day protest, CJP has obliged two Cabinet ministers to negotiate, extracted the resignation of a minister, forced the government to withdraw the cases against the protesters, and got written commitments from the government. This is unprecedented.

Hint of New Phenomenon

As I said, the first hint of such a space *beyond* and *outside* political parties was

Yet, through a 35-day protest, CJP has obliged two Cabinet ministers to negotiate, extracted the resignation of a minister, forced the government to withdraw the cases against the protesters, and got written commitments from the government

sighted in 2026 in Tamil Nadu. Mr Joseph Vijay announced a political party (Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam or TVK) in February 2024 but it not take the 'form' of a regular party; by all accounts it remained an amorphous Fans' Association. Mostly, the office bearers of the Fans' Association became office bearers of TVK at various levels. TVK candidates were selected defying conventional political wisdom — ignoring caste, religion, gender, legacy, wealth, etc. Over 200 of the 234 candidates did not have or spend money. In the vast majority of constituencies, TVK candidates did not have the semblance of a campaign. Many TVK candidates were strangers to the constituency concerned and they had few booth agents or polling agents or counting agents. Mr Vijay held a few roadshows and spoke at fewer meetings. Apparently, the only things that mattered to the voters were 'Mr Vijay' and the 'whistle' symbol. The alchemist was the social media (Instagram and YouTube): Mr Vijay was seen *everywhere* and he was heard in *every home*. TVK won in 108 constituencies against the two formidable political and election machines of DMK and AIADMK, and polled 35 per cent of the votes.

No political party, no leader, no journalist, and no pollster foretold a TVK victory. When election results poured in, it was received with as much surprise by the TVK as it was received with shock by the established political parties.

The political change in Tamil Nadu was brought about by citizens occupying the space *beyond* and *outside* political parties. Following the Tamil Nadu example, it is not beyond imagination that change can be brought about by citizens who may not

know each other, may not talk to each other, may not belong to an organization, but vote in the same manner and elect sufficient number of representatives to form a government.

Challenge to Political Parties

Political parties should closely examine the phenomenon of the election result in Tamil Nadu and the outcome of the Jantar Mantar protest. Organized political parties may not become obsolete but traditional concepts such as High Command, Executive Committee, General Council, *Maha-sabha*, membership and party elections may become irrelevant. The obnoxious phrase 'vote bank' may vanish.

The citizens have shed silence thanks to the mobile, Twitter (now X), Facebook and Instagram; now, they seem to have shed fear. *Khaki* or blue, police, *lathis*, tear gas, guns, and arrest/detention no longer intimidate the youth, and older citizens may follow. I wish the political space beyond and outside political parties will grow larger.

Gen Z and other protesters have challenging tasks ahead of them:

- First, they must drag the Universities out of medievalism and obscurantism.
 - They must stand up to the brute force of the uniformed police, moral policing, and Bajrang Dal-like 'enforcers'.
 - They must fight against legislated morality and discrimination.
 - Gen Z must stop the oppressive corruption in local revenue and registration offices, hospitals, ration shops, local bodies, etc.
- After Jantar Mantar, every change for the better seems possible.

No lessons from cockroaches



FIFTH COLUMN
BY TAVLEEN SINGH

SADLY, I must begin this piece on a gloomy note. It appears that no lessons were learned from Jantar Mantar by either the government or the opposition. If they had been learned, the opposition would have chosen to speak inside Parliament about students being shot at instead of playing into the government's hands by making the usual racket and reckless demands. Rahul Gandhi led the charge by insisting that the Home Minister would have ordered pellet guns to be used and that he should resign for doing this. The government, for its part, lied that no guns were used when there is clear evidence that they were.

The government should have discovered from the Cockroach Janta Party's remarkable protest in Jantar Mantar that they are dealing with a new generation of Indians who will not accept lies and will not be afraid. It should have learned that going back on its promises will be immediately spotted and opposed. Since it did not, it reverted to the typical tactics that we have seen against dissidents, which is to bully them into obedience. Criminal cases have been filed against young people who mocked the Prime Minister in Jantar Mantar and the founder of the CJP has been personally threatened with dire consequences.

This newspaper in a report last week had this comment from Abhijit Dipke. "I received threats saying that it would be better if I join the BJP...otherwise we will beat you up and shoot you." He said that intimidation devices had been used not just against him but against his family as well. Anyone vaguely familiar with the BJP's methods will find this comment from Dipke credible. Anyone who follows politics even slightly knows that opposition political parties have been broken because of these methods. And that supposedly corrupt politicians became miraculously cleansed as soon as they entered the ranks of the BJP.

The only person who appears to have learned a lesson of sorts is the Prime Minister himself who has taken to popping up on Instagram every other day to make some announcement or other. What he has not learned is that he needs to change his message if he wants to reach the generation he is trying so hard to reach. His videos are neither well-made nor interesting. In them he stares woodenly at the camera and then proceeds to deliver a monologue on his latest achievements. Surely, he should have discovered by now that this generation of young Indians can be reached much better with dialogue than monologue.

Unlike older Indians, like your aged columnist, younger Indians are mercifully unwilling to accept the mess that our political leaders and officials have made of India. They do not accept that year after year when the rains come, there will be states like Assam and Himachal in which people will lose every one of their possessions because the government has been unable to prepare better for the rains. They do not accept that the rains will bring chaos in our cities because of badly built roads and drains. They are impatient with politicians who tell them that by next year our sacred rivers will be clean and the air in our cities will be fit to breathe.

They know well that the real reason why the education system is broken is because of massive corruption in which politicians collude with mafioso types to make sure that nothing changes. If real change ever happens, then political leaders will lose the so-called educational institutions that enable them to get government land and grants. If real change happens, then the coaching centres who thrive on the misery of students will close and be replaced by real colleges. If real change happens, government schools will have properly trained teachers instead of highly paid frauds. If real change happens, Indian children will be taught to think instead of being taught to learn by rote.

These are not problems that have been created only in the age of Modi. They are legacy problems that have developed over decades of neglect and criminal negligence. What is sad is that Modi has done so little to rectify the problems he inherited. What is sad is that he has paid so much more attention to non-issues like making it a criminal act to interrupt the singing of Vande Matram. We did not need a new law for this, but it is one of only two that so far got passed in the monsoon session of Parliament.

If opposition leaders had understood the cockroach protest better, they would have allowed Parliament to function this time instead of using the usual tactics to make it non-functional. They are right to demand that the Home Minister explain why protesting students were shot at with pellet guns, but it would have been so much better if this had been discussed and debated. When are the opposition parties going to discover that they should leave street fighting to a new generation of Indians who know how to do this much better?

All in all, none of our political leaders covered themselves in glory in the week gone by in which we saw the aftermath of the cockroach protest. And since no lessons were learned, we are likely to see much more of what Bob Dylan unforgettably described as 'music in the cafes at night, revolution in the air'. This could be good.

A call for disaster drills for Indians



ROXY MATHEW KOLL

WHEREVER WE live in India, we now face some form of extreme weather. The danger may be a heatwave, cyclone, cloudburst, flash flood or landslide. The hazards differ, but no part of the country can assume it is safe. Yet most of us have never taken part in a disaster drill.

Every summer, people collapse. Every monsoon, children and adults are swept away. During the recent Assam floods, 13-year-old Hridip Panika entered the floodwaters to save his puppy. He saved the animal, but lost his life in the current. Many of these deaths unfold within minutes, before trained help can arrive. Survival depends on a few immediate decisions.

In a recent assessment, we found that hot days have increased by about five to ten days per decade since the 1950s, while extreme rain events causing floods over India tripled. Meanwhile, India has improved its ability to forecast heatwaves, cyclones and heavy rain. Alerts now reach millions through television, mobile phones and social media. However, a warning only tells us that danger is approaching. It does not teach us what to do. That knowledge has to be learnt and practised before the emergency.

A World Health Organization regional report cites 36,362 drowning deaths in India in 2021. Just 15 centimetres of fast-moving water can knock an adult down, while about 30 cm can carry away many cars. Yet people routinely walk, ride or drive into floodwater without knowing its depth, speed or what lies beneath. India needs a national culture of disaster drills. Every school, college, government office and workplace should conduct two mandatory seasonal drills each year, one before the heatwave season and another before the monsoon.

A heat drill should simulate a student or worker developing severe weakness, dizziness or confusion. Participants should know who calls for medical help, where rapid cooling will begin and who checks on those at greater risk. Every institution should identify a shaded or cooled room, maintain drinking water and know when outdoor work, sports and assemblies must stop.

A monsoon drill should be equally practical. Students and staff should walk the evacuation route to higher ground, practise head counts and test an alternative route in case the main exit is flooded. They should learn never to enter or drive through moving water, and to stay away from submerged drains and electrical wires. Children should be taught to throw a rope or flotation aid from a safe position and call trained rescuers, instead of jumping into the water. Survival swimming and basic water-rescue skills should become part of education in flood-prone districts.

Disaster management must become a practical part of education from the primary level. Children should learn local hazards, warning colours, safe routes, signs of heat illness and basic first aid. Older students can learn emergency communication, evacuation and community volunteering. These abilities should be demonstrated, not memorised. A child who learns them at school will also carry them home.

India is not starting from zero. The National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA) already provides for school disaster plans, mock drills and village-level drill calendars based on local hazards. Yet a six-state survey found that most schools had not held the drills, many lacked evacuation plans and only about a quarter had trained staff and students.

Japan shows what sustained preparedness can achieve. During the 2011 tsunami, around 3,000 schoolchildren in Kamaishi reached safety after years of disaster education taught them to move quickly to higher ground. In June 2026, Taiwan tested how multiple agencies would respond to three consecutive days at 40°C. Bangladesh has built a standing network of about 76,000 coastal volunteers trained to carry warnings to communities, organise evacuations, manage shelters and provide first aid.

Every panchayat and urban ward should designate at least one local safety point. It should be accessible to people with disabilities and have water, cooling, first aid, toilets, backup lighting and communication. Its location and routes should be displayed publicly. District disaster management authorities should coordinate drills with schools, health departments, fire services, local governments and trained volunteers. Strong infrastructure, health services and emergency response remain essential.

Half an hour of practice twice a year is a small demand. In an emergency, the decisions made during those first few minutes can determine who reaches safety.

Koll is a climate scientist at the Indian Institute of Tropical Meteorology

Santiago to Shopian and Delhi — pellet guns in crowd control



HISTORY HEADLINE
BY MURARI

ON JULY 30, inside the Supreme Court, legal arguments clashed with a physical tragedy. At the heart of the debate were Sahil Lochab, a 19-year-old student fighting to save his eye after a metal pellet tore into it, and Irshad Sheikh, a young worker who underwent surgery for embedded pellets.

The court refused an outright ban, noting exceptional situations, but left the door open for an inquiry. Yet, a chilling question hung in the air. How did a shotgun, used for years in conflict zones, end up being fired at unarmed students in the heart of Delhi?

To understand how we got here, we must look at the history of pellet guns and their use in crowd control. Using them on civilian crowds is a modern nightmare born from an attempt to be 'merciful'. The blueprint was drawn in 1950s' Hong Kong. Following the bloody Double Ten riots, colonial police fired wooden baton rounds, or projectiles made of wood, to control violent mobs. The British military improvised further during The Troubles in Northern Ireland. In 1970, facing Catholic civil rights protests, soldiers fired rubber and later, plastic bullets. Fired at close range, they shattered bones and skulls. A 10-year-old boy in Derry was completely blinded, and 17 people were killed. Pellet-firing shotguns followed, causing immediate, severe facial injuries.

The weapon travelled the world, almost always finding the fragile human eye. During the First Intifada between 1987 and 1993, the Israeli military fired rubber and plastic rounds directly at Palestinian protesters, starting decades of life-altering eye injuries affecting children. This approach to riot control eventually found its way to Europe. In France, during Yellow Vest protests over



During the Cockroach Janta Party protests at Connaught Place. GAJENDRA YADAV

economic inequality, police fired heavy rubber-pellet launchers at crowds, leaving protesters with torn ears, shattered jaws, brain trauma, and irreversible eye damage.

During Chile's 2019 civil unrest over inequality, health agencies recorded up to 445 cases of severe eye trauma. Anger boiled over when a university study proved the supposedly rubber pellets were actually 80% heavy metals. Forced into a corner by blinded citizens, Chile's military police chief finally suspended their use. Following racial justice protests in 2020, 19 American cities agreed to pay 80 million dollars in settlements to maimed people. Meanwhile, during protests in Iran, shotguns became tools of mass blinding. On January 9 and 10 alone, a Tehran hospital reported nearly a 1,000 patients arriving for ruptured eyeballs, with scans from Mashhad showing metal pellets lodged deep inside eyes.

For years, the police fired these weapons into crowds with no clear international rules. The United Nations finally stepped in with the UN Human Rights Office releasing in 2020 its first-ever comprehensive guidance on less-lethal weapons to fill this void. They realised that governments were deploying these weapons with zero global standards on their design, test-

ing, or use. When it came to metal shotgun pellets, the UN was absolute: they should never be used for crowd control. Because they scatter wildly, it is physically impossible to aim them safely, making them inherently indiscriminate.

India too has a documented history of deploying pellet guns. The pump-action shotguns used by paramilitary forces are made at Rifle Factory Ishapore in Ichhapur, West Bengal. A single cartridge shoots hundreds of high-velocity metal pellets that scatter wildly. Beyond Kashmir, the weapon has surfaced in other civilian protests. During the 2024 farmers' protests along the Punjab-Haryana border, farm leaders alleged several protesters were injured by pellets, though police firmly denied using them. Similarly, allegations of pellet gun usage during the late 2025 unrest in Ladakh were met with official denials. The weapons were also reportedly used during ethnic violence in Manipur.

At least 2,524 people were injured by pellets, many in the eyes, in eight of the 10 districts in the Kashmir valley during the crackdown on protests that followed the killing of militant Burhan Wani on July 8 last year, according to data compiled from official records by the J&K government for the State Human Rights Commission (SHRC) in 2017.

During that 2016 unrest, schoolgirl Insha Mushtaq was hit by pellets while standing by her window, losing her sight completely. Ten years later, the government finally released funds to help her run a gas agency.

Following the 2016 outcry over Kashmir, the Union Home Ministry formed a committee, deciding that forces must first use chilli shells and stun grenades, keeping pellet guns as a final resort.

Governments worldwide often reach for these weapons hoping to control crowds without killing. But as courts argue over police manuals, for many young people with pellet injuries — from Santiago to Shopian to New Delhi — the reality on the ground remains unchanged.

The writer is Senior Assistant Editor, Indian Express Hindi

Until my mother was diagnosed with lung cancer

THERE ARE things they don't tell you about lung cancer until your feisty mother is diagnosed with it, and they say it is terminal. They don't tell you that lung cancer has no symptoms in the early stages, and that the lungs have few pain nerve endings, and tumors can grow large before causing any discomfort. They don't tell you that even at an advanced stage, symptoms are mild — a persistent cough, hoarseness, wheezing, a little chest pain, and perhaps some breathlessness, which is what your mother complained about. Because she was a Hindustani classical vocalist, and the breathlessness was interfering with her *riyaz*, which was also her *sadhana*, her deeper, spiritual discipline.

They don't tell you that even if your mother never smoked a single cigarette in her life, bore four healthy children, ate clean, and was rarely sick, a single PET scan can quickly unravel that illusion of good health, show it for what it is — smoke and mirrors — and alter the trajectory of her life on her birth-

day. They don't tell you that it was the polluted air she breathed for most of her adult life that triggered her disease. And when they do, they say it almost casually, like you should have known. Aren't you the daughter who studies air pollution, simplifies and amplifies that research, and writes to bring awareness about the health harms air pollution triggers? All that information seems to have coalesced in your mother's lungs. What sort of a cosmic joke is this?

August 1 is World Lung Cancer Day. Here are some things they don't tell you that you should know. It is preventable, but rising sharply. It was previously mostly linked to smoking, targeting older, male smokers; it now attacks more non-smoking women, and younger people. The WHO classifies outdoor air pollution and PM2.5 as Group 1 carcinogens, the same category as tobacco smoke. Delhi's annual average PM2.5 in 2025 was nearly 20 times the WHO safe limit. Children, older people and pregnant women are the most vulnerable. Every newborn in



SHE SAID
BY JYOTI PANDEY
LAVAKARE

India is a smoker from their first breath. Smoking kills. Breathing is the new smoking. But more than data, what they don't tell you is what your family will go through. That, at first, everything will feel normal — until it doesn't. They don't tell you about the collective denial amongst your mother's dearly beloved; the tears and fights that will lead to tests and retests, CT scans, MRIs, X-rays, molecular testing, genetic and biomarker testing. They don't tell you about the many doors of doctors, pathologists, and technicians you will wait outside, the many labs you will visit to repeat biopsies and cytologies in the hope that one of them may cast doubt on the death sentence served to your mother. They don't tell you about the rise and the fall of hope. They especially don't tell you about the despair.

Yes, things will still feel normal — until they draw pleural fluid from your mother's lungs during the first biopsy. The thought of a needle in her lungs is scary, but the relief she feels immediately after makes it bear-

able. Even when it happens again, and again. You wish you hadn't learnt that pleural effusion is the buildup of fluid in the narrow space between the outer lung lining and the chest wall, so the lung can't expand fully. It feels like slow drowning, someone tells you, and you wish they hadn't. After nearly two litres of pleural fluid are removed over three extractions, tested and retested, malignant cells are found, then a malignant mass, and dismay turns to despair — they don't tell you how quickly. They don't prepare you for the stunned disbelief in your mother's eyes when she finds out, even when no one tells her. A death sentence on a birthday. Just days after Diwali, when you were happy and lit oil lamps and celebrated the Supreme Court banning firecrackers.

Lavakare is the author of 'Breathing Here is Injurious to Your Health'

Editor (Planning & Projects) Shalini Langer curates the fortnightly 'She Said' column

Hungary to shut down its only nuclear plant as water levels dip in Danube River

Associated Press
Budapest, August 1

HUNGARY'S ONLY nuclear power plant will shut down for the first time in its history due to record-low water levels in the Danube River, Prime Minister Peter Magyar said Friday, adding that the plant may not come back online for several weeks as the river is expected to continue receding. The Paks nuclear plant, located around 90 kilometers (50 miles) south of the capital Budapest, is operating at less than half its normal capacity, producing 965 megawatts of power rather than the usual 2,000.

The plant uses water from the Danube to cool its reactors, but the exceptionally low water level has tested the ability of pumps to bring sufficient quantities into the plant. Speaking at a news conference on Friday, Magyar said further reductions in output were imminent later Friday and that the entire plant will likely be powered down by Tuesday or Wednesday. He stressed that the shutdown can be performed safely and poses no risk to the public or environment.

The Soviet-built, four-reactor plant at Paks accounts for nearly half of Hungary's electricity production. If it is powered down, it will be the first time in its 44 years of service.

67 BODIES RECOVERED

Spain installs floating barrier in Ceuta after deadly migrant rush

EU governments call for emergency meeting on border security

Michael Francis Gore
Ceuta, August 1

SPAIN SAID migrant crossings into its North African enclave of Ceuta had stopped overnight, as police began installing a 500-metre floating barrier on Saturday off its border with Morocco following a mass rush that killed at least 67 people.

According to Spanish authorities, about 50,000 people had crossed into Ceuta by land and sea from Thursday in an unprecedented surge at one of the EU's only land borders with Africa. More than 48,000 of them returned to Morocco within 48 hours without major incident, Spain said.

Reuters footage on Saturday showed Spanish soldiers and police patrolling a mostly empty Tarajal beach shrouded in fog. Civil Guard police started laying the new barrier at 7:50 a.m. (0550 GMT) on the Tarajal breakwater, one of the main points used by people trying to enter the tiny Spanish



Spanish soldiers rescue an injured migrant on the beach in Ceuta on Saturday. REUTERS

territory, the government said in a statement.

The pneumatic barrier, alongside a line of anchored naval buoys, is designed to stand 30 to 70 centimetres (12 to 28 inches) above water and extend as much as one metre below the surface, it added, while a channel between the barriers will allow Civil Guard vessels to patrol the area.

At least 67 bodies have been recovered on the Spanish side

of the frontier, officials said, after some migrants drowned and others were crushed while trying to climb the breakwater and border fence. Many were driven to migrate by economic hardship and encouraged by social media rumours.

Spanish Interior Minister Fernando Grande-Marlaska blamed people-smuggling networks for exploiting vulnerable migrants and spreading misleading interpretations of a re-

cent Spanish Supreme Court ruling that migrants intercepted at sea cannot be summarily returned in the absence of a physical barrier.

Speaking from Ceuta, Grande-Marlaska told reporters Spain had largely restored order within 24 hours, but warned that the crisis was not yet formally over and that reinforced police and military deployments would remain as long as needed, though over-

night crossings had fallen to about zero.

"Morocco isn't any threat to Ceuta or the rest of Spain — it's a fully reliable partner," he said, adding there had been no intelligence indicating a mass entry was imminent.

Ceuta and Spain's other North African enclave, Melilla, sit on Morocco's Mediterranean coast and periodically face attempted crossings by migrants seeking to reach Europe.

The latest attempt caused division in the EU, with several countries calling for Spain to ensure that the incident was contained.

Twenty-two EU governments called on Saturday for an emergency meeting of interior ministers over the Ceuta crisis, urging the bloc to help Madrid regain control of its border with Morocco. Meanwhile, Spain's centre-left Prime Minister Pedro Sanchez also asked EU leaders to convene interior ministers urgently, but criticised governments that had called for Spain's exclusion from the bloc's passport-free Schengen travel area.

Madrid said the people who entered Ceuta irregularly could not travel onwards to mainland Spain or elsewhere in the Schengen zone. REUTERS

US urges its nationals to leave West Asia, cites region's 'complex security situation'

Press Trust of India
Jerusalem, August 1

US EMBASSIES in several West Asian nations on Saturday called upon American citizens there to consider leaving or be "prepared to depart" amid heightened tensions with Iran and a "complex security situation".

US embassies in Jerusalem and other West Asian capitals released identical security alerts warning American nationals about travel to or within the region.

The advisory called the Iranian regime "unpredictable" and warned of a "potential for unforeseen escalation".

"Americans currently in the Middle East should exercise caution and heightened vigilance and should be prepared for flight cancellations, periodic airspace closures, and potential travel disruptions", the advisory said.

Noting that some airlines in the region have postponed resumption of earlier flight schedules and others have cancelled some routes, it advised Americans in the region to "consider departing, or be prepared to depart should there be escalation."

The embassies asked

Americans currently in the Middle East should exercise caution and heightened vigilance and should be prepared for flight cancellations, periodic airspace closures, and potential travel disruptions"

ADVISORY BY U.S. EMBASSIES

Americans outside planning to travel to the region to "seriously reconsider" their travel plans.

Those who do travel to or from the region should monitor information about airport and airline operations, the advisory said.

The release noted that US diplomatic facilities, including outside West Asia, have been targeted.

Iran and groups supportive of Tehran may target other US interests overseas or at locations associated with the US and Americans throughout the world, including US businesses and other institutions, it added.

Russia pounds Kyiv, kills at least 10 as Ukraine appeals for Patriot interceptors



Residents look at a burnt car after a Russian missile strike in Kyiv on Saturday. REUTERS

Olena Harmash & Yurii Kovalenko
Kyiv, August 1

RUSSIA POUNDED Kyiv and the region in a heavy ballistic missile attack early on Saturday, killing 10 people, as President Volodymyr Zelenskyy warned that Ukraine had run out of interceptor missiles for its US Patriot air defence systems.

Zelenskyy said that Russia launched 35 missiles at Ukraine, including 27 ballistic missiles, and also 185 drones. Only one ballistic missile was intercepted, "simply because there are no interceptors for the Patriot system", he said. More than a dozen explosions reverberated through the city during several waves of attacks, according to Reuters witnesses.

"Every package of ballistic missile interceptors saves the lives of our people. And every night without them results in

more casualties," Zelenskyy said on the Telegram app.

With the war in its fifth year, fighting is raging along about 1,200 kilometres (750 miles) of front line. But Russian advances have slowed by more than half this year, and Ukraine has been launching strikes inside Russia hitting its oil facilities, logistics sites and weapons production.

Saturday's is the second major attack on Kyiv this week after nine people, including six members of one family in a village near Kryvyi Rih, were killed on Thursday. Damage was recorded in seven districts across Kyiv, a city of about 3 million people, the Prosecutor's General Office said after Saturday's attacks. Zelenskyy said that fires broke out across Kyiv and 18 residential buildings, a school, the Lithuanian Embassy, and infrastructure facilities were damaged. REUTERS

China issues new rules to assert its control over South China Sea shoal

Press Trust of India
Beijing, August 1

CHINA ON Saturday issued management measures for the Huangyan Dao National Nature Reserve in the disputed South China Sea, a move likely to further escalate its maritime row with the Philippines, which has counterclaims over the shoal.

The measures are a key step in safeguarding the diversity, stability and sustainability of the Huangyan Dao natural ecosystem, an official announcement said here tonight.

Under the rules, a routine patrol system will be established to promptly investigate and handle violations in accordance with the law.



Under the rules, a routine patrol system will be established. FILE

Violators will be held accountable under relevant laws and regulations, state-run Xinhua news agency quoted the rules jointly issued by the Ministry of Natural Resources, the National Forestry and Grassland Administration, the China Coast Guard, and the Hainan provincial government.

Without prior approval, any activities such as fishing, mining, and the extraction of corals, coral reefs or giant clams that damage rare marine species and the natural ecosystem are prohibited, it said.

No individual or organisation may enter the reserve, except as otherwise provided by laws and regulations or for activities organised for conservation and management purposes, it said.

Earlier, the PLA Southern Theatre Command (STC) conducted a joint naval-air training exercise focusing on multiple realistic training subjects in the territorial sea and airspace of Huangyan Dao and its surrounding areas on Saturday, the Chinese military said. AP

US F-35B stealth fighter crashes in California, pilot ejects safely

San Diego: The US Marine Corps says the pilot of an F-35B stealth fighter is expected to live after ejecting from the jet before it crashed in California.

The jet went down Friday near the Miramar air base in San Diego. "The pilot ejected, was transported to a local medical facility in stable condition for evaluation and treatment of non-life-threatening injuries," the Marine Corps said in an updated statement.

Aerial video from a news helicopter showed black smoke rising from the wreckage in a dirt field, with multiple military and firefighting vehicles and people standing nearby. AP

Nepalese climber Purja dies in PoK avalanche

Yubaraj Ghimire
Kathmandu, August 1

NIRMAL PURJA, also known as Nimsdai, the world-famous mountaineer who set a world record seven years ago by successfully climbing all 14 peaks above 8,000 metres within just six months, has died along with nine fellow climbers after an avalanche swept them at least 1,000 metres down during their ascent of Broad Peak located in Pakistan-occupied Kashmir's Gilgit-Baltistan.

The avalanche swept the group—six Nepalis, and one each from China, Oman, Pakistan, and the US—on Thursday from somewhere between Camp Three and Camp Two of the 8,051-metre mountain, the 12th highest in the world. The death of the group led by Purja,



Nirmal Purja was among 10 climbers swept away by the avalanche on Broad Peak

who had earlier served in the British Gorkha, was officially announced today. His life was cut short long before he was planning to set another record by conquering all the peaks above 8,000 metres without oxygen.

Elite Exped, his expedition group said in a statement: "Today, with profound sadness and immense heartbreak, we confirm that Nirmal 'Nimsdai' Purja tragically lost his life fol-

lowing the avalanche on Broad Peak. We have also received confirmation that other members of the expedition did not survive."

"Today we mourn not only Nirmal, but every life lost in this tragedy including his trusted climbing partners and guides — Pur Bahadur Gurung and Nima Sherpa," it added.

A graduate from the Small Heaven School in Chitwan district, some 160 km away from here, Purja joined the British Army when he was 18.

"He always used to talk about joining the British Army like his father and not so much about the climbing mountains then," recalls Sabin Thapa, his school friend. His first trip to the Mount Everest Base Camp came in late 2012. Since then, he remained determined to

summitting various peaks.

Soon, he scaled Lobuche East in Nepal and Mount Everest in quick succession.

Back in Nepal after retirement, the ascent of 14 peaks within six months in 2019 brought him worldwide fame.

Nepal PM Balendra Shah extended his condolences on the death of Purja and five other Nepalese climbers.

"Only the physical journeys of Nirmal Purja and all the other departed mountaineers have come to an end; the legacy of their courage, dedication, and contributions will forever remain alive and inspiring.

Heartfelt tributes to all the departed mountaineers. Sincere condolences to the bereaved families, relatives, and well-wishers," he said in a social media post.

• WHILE PRIME MINISTER ANDY BURNHAM CALLS IT 'A NORTH POLE THAT BALANCES THE SOUTH POLE' OF WESTMINSTER POLITICS IN LONDON, HIS CRITICS HAVE CALLED IT A GIMMICK

Britain's new leader shifts power from Downing Street to Manchester with 'No. 10 North'

Jill Lawless
Manchester, August 1

BRITAIN HAS a new hub of power: a bland modern office block about 260 km from the prime minister's official London office and residence at 10 Downing Street.

The Manchester low-rise is home to "No. 10 North," the flagship of new Prime Minister Andy Burnham's pledge to be a different kind of UK leader.

Burnham was mayor of Greater Manchester before vaulting back into national politics, and one of his first acts was to set up a branch office in the city. It's both symbol of and engine for his pledge to give

local leaders more powers and spread economic growth around the country.

Burnham calls it "a North Pole that balances the South Pole" of Westminster politics in London. Critics have called it a gimmick.

It's certainly a novelty. While past British leaders have spent weekends in their local constituencies, or at the prime minister's official Chequers country retreat, none in living memory has had a large-scale office outside London.

Burnham plans to work there at least one day a week, alongside a full-time staff of aides, experts and civil servants. "It's not another office,"

Burnham said Friday. "It is a fundamental change to the way the country thinks about growth and investment."

Burnham believes Manchester holds the key to avoiding the fate of Keir Starmer, his predecessor as Labour Party leader and prime minister.

Starmer stepped down in July after two years in office, following missteps, policy U-turns and his failure to get Britain's sluggish economy growing.

During nine years as Manchester mayor, Burnham was praised standing up to central government on behalf of a proud, battle-scarred northern city that gave birth to the Indus-



Britain's PM Andy Burnham at No 10 North at Heron House in Manchester, England. AP

trial Revolution, movements for social change and a dynamic music scene. He gained

the nickname King of the North for his championing of the city - and his political ambition.

Burnham promoted what has been called "Manchesterism," a form of business-friendly socialism that involves harnessing private investment for major projects and decentralising government to give communities more control over housing, transport, training and public services.

The city centre boomed during his mayoralty. Skyscrapers sprouted from vacant lots, service industries grew, a thousand coffee shops bloomed and a municipally run network of bright yellow buses and trams crisscrossed the city.

Now Burnham wants to replicate the approach across the country, using No. 10 North

as the engine room for redistributing wealth and economic opportunities to areas blighted by shuttered industries, lost jobs and an exodus of young people.

In a first step, Burnham announced Friday that mayors will get to keep a greater share of income and business tax revenue from their areas, calling it the "biggest transfer of power, funding and responsibility from Westminster in a generation."

Many of the details haven't been announced, however, including how much new money mayors will be getting.

Rob Ford, professor of political science at the Univer-

sity of Manchester, said Burnham's bold early moves suggest "he does mean business in terms of changing the overall mechanics of government".

"We have one of the most centralised countries out of all developed democracies in terms of how much money and decision-making power gets hoovered into the centre, how little there is for the provinces to do," Ford said. "He does seem quite determined to change that, but that's a huge job." Burnham's critics point out that Manchester's boom hasn't spread to all its outskirts, and the anti-immigration party Reform UK has been a beneficiary of voters' discontent. AP

epaper.indianexpress.com

BRIDGE

The central idea in last week's problem was about saving the honours. Why waste an honour when a lower card will suffice? Keeping this mind could you manage to avoid the loss of four trump tricks in last week's problem.

DEALER: East VULNERABLE: North/South

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ 2	—	♠ J10 9 6 5 4 3	—
♥ J8 5 2	—	♥ A K	—
♦ Q 8 4	—	♦ A K	—
♣ 10 6 4 3 2	—	♣ 7 5	—
SOUTH		NORTH	
—	—	—	pass
1♠	dbl	pass	1NT
2♣	pass	pass	pass

West leads the king, ace and queen of clubs; East plays the eight, nine and jack. Plan the play. After ruffing the third round of clubs declarer can attack the trump. With five trumps including the three top honours in the closed hand, what do you think is the best line for declarer?

THE WEST HAND

♠ A ♥ 10 9 6 4 ♦ 10 9 7 5 2 ♣ A K Q

THE EAST HAND

♠ K 8 7 ♥ Q 7 3 ♦ J 6 3 ♣ J 9 8

The theme in this problem is to save the honours. Declarer's only problem is to avoid the loss of four trump tricks. If the first spade lead is the jack, ten or nine, the contract will be made only if the missing spades divide three-two. But if the first spade lead is a low card, it can also be made against a four-one split, if the singleton is the ace, king or queen.

Your problem for the week:

DEALER: East VULNERABLE: East/West

NORTH		SOUTH	
♠ J 5 3	—	♠ A K 10 4 2	—
♥ Q 8 5 2	—	♥ A 7 4	—
♦ A Q J 6	—	♦ K 8	—
♣ A 3	—	♣ K Q 2	—
WEST		NORTH	
—	—	—	pass
1♠	pass	2♦	pass
5♣	pass	5♠	pass
6♣	pass	pass	pass

Club six, ace, five, deuce. Spade three, six, ace, heart nine. Plan the play.

SUNDAY CROSSWORD

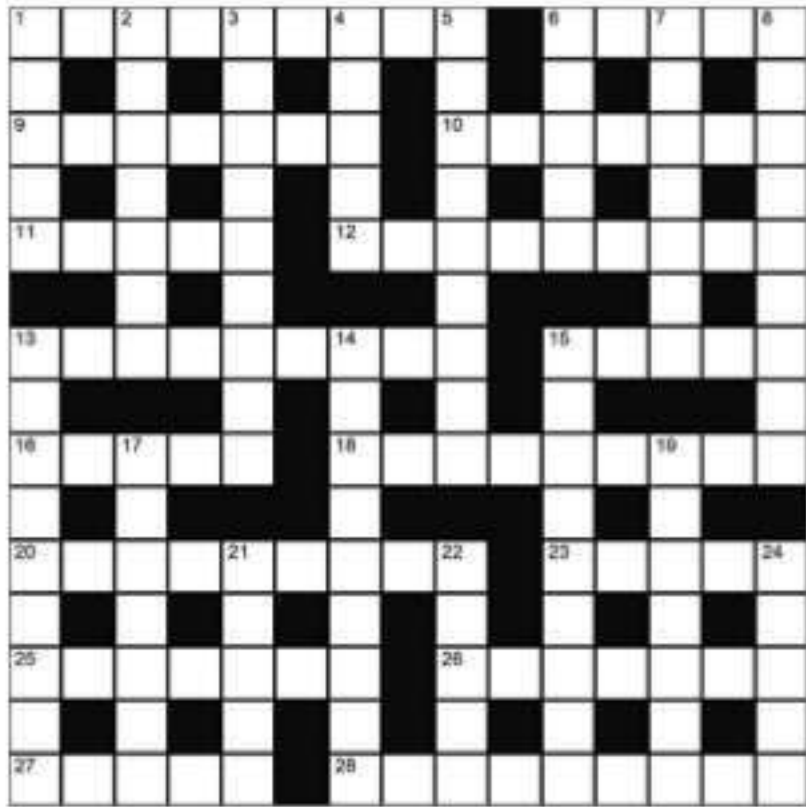
QUICK CLUES

ACROSS

1. Instrument panel of a car (9)
6. Australian marsupial (5)
9. Any person (7)
10. Frenzied (7)
11. More sensitive (5)
12. Bribe colloquially (9)
13. Very light glider (9)
15. Argentina's World Cup winning captain (5)
16. Horrid (5)
18. Formal ball (9)
20. Greenspan or Keynes? (9)
23. Port of ancient Rome (5)
25. Admit (7)
26. Wiry (7)
27. Former Egyptian ruler (5)
28. Crosses (9)

DOWN

1. Cleans by using a cloth (5)
2. Japanese warrior caste (7)
3. Life story (9)
4. Helps a felon (5)
5. Not the same (9)
6. Venomous snake (5)
7. Pays heed (7)
8. Squeezebox (9)
13. Prison terms (9)
14. Building design creator (9)
15. Australian city (9)
17. Passed out (7)
19. Chants (7)
21. Fragrant — "telon" anagram? (5)
22. Out of port (2,3)



24. Bottomless gulf (5)

CRYPTIC CLUES

ACROSS

1. The most advanced digital component having light controls (9)
6. Joint headgear (5)
9. Pecked right through by the bird (7)
10. After drinking port, small individual is seen to act without restraint (3,4)
11. Zeal is misplaced about one girl (5)
12. Everlasting ringing of changes, outside inside, upside down (9)
13. Diamond possibly taking on a new air among old Italian

plotters (9)

15. Pancake student found in receptacle number one (5)
16. City miser's rehouse (5)
18. Becoming fully proficient at teaching? (9)
20. Philanderer more knowledgeable about sultanate (9)
23. They are bent on asking for a girl's hand (5)
25. Find fee revised by old gentleman in Asia Minor (7)
26. Not backward at the scene of conflict, man (7)
27. Ordinary people found it in the song (5)

SOLUTIONS TO 2592 **QUICK CLUES ACROSS:** 1 Purchase, 5 Wake up, 9 Impelled, 10 Europe, 12 Needy, 13 Associate, 14 Forced, 16 Well set, 19 Offhand, 21 Turner, 23 Passed out, 25 Flees, 26 Recoil, 27 Viva voce, 28 Sashes, 29 Aggrieve **DOWN:** 1 Pliant, 2 Ripped off, 3 Hilly, 4 Steward, 6 Avuncular, 7 Ebola, 8 Pretexts, 11 saw, 15 Ceasefire, 17 Stevedore, 18 Compares, 20 Doom, 21 Tooting, 22 Essene, 24 Sacks, 25 Flair **CRYPTIC CLUES ACROSS:** 1 Lion cubs, 5 Emblem, 9 Splendid, 10 Skylab, 12 Ellis, 13 King's Head, 14 Scorer, 16 Titanic, 19 Desktop, 21 Wiping, 23 Minor role, 25 Vials, 26 Attain, 27 Bird's eye, 28 Eulogy, 29 Assaults **DOWN:** 1 Lasted, 2 Oil slicks, 3 Cents, 4 Blinker, 6 Makes it up, 7 Lille, 8 Moby dick, 11 Gnat, 15 Returning, 17 Nonpareil, 18 Adam's ale, 20 Prow, 21 Weevils, 22 Assess, 24 Natal, 25 Vodka

2593

28. Public schoolboys welcoming southern European (9)

DOWN

1. It is not true a moral can be taught by it (5)
2. A man having a row is better turned out (7)
3. Lifts might be given to several (9)
4. Travelling fast — the fashion when riding (3-2)
5. Personal representations (9)
6. People used to get on with this old time Indian politician (5)
7. One pound I invested in TSB? I lost capital (7)
8. Former spouse ringing, celebrating (9)
13. Floor spring damaged whaler etc (9)
14. Truce — it's a crime if one breaks it (9)
15. Crack up, strangely enough (5,4)
17. Mini-dress hold up foot out of uniform (2,5)
19. Diet ace blended something cool (4,3)
21. Simpleton leaves a pub in New York (5)
22. Trifle mix without having left a facelift (5)
24. Markets a measure in a vessel (5)

IF IT'S YOUR BIRTHDAY

SUNDAY AUGUST 2: This is a slower paced year. Take time to rejuvenate your energy. Focus on business and personal relationships. Focus on your needs and what brings you happiness.

MONDAY AUGUST 3: This is a fun-loving year. Your zest for life is at a pinnacle! Enjoy socialising with others. Let your guard down and loosen up a bit. Have fun.

TUESDAY AUGUST 4: This year is about creating solid foundations in your life. Simplicity is key. Take charge of your health. Physical exercise is important. Explore martial arts or yoga.

WEDNESDAY AUGUST 5: This year change will bring you increased personal freedom. Let go of whatever holds you back. Seek out new opportunities. Be ready to act fast.

THURSDAY AUGUST 6: This is a year of service to others, probably to family. Take care of yourself so you can be a resource to those who turn to you for guidance, comfort and courage.

FRIDAY AUGUST 7: This is a year of learning and teaching. Take time to renew your religious beliefs. Explore philosophies that give you a better self-awareness.

SATURDAY AUGUST 8: This year you will reap the benefits of all your hard work. Expect power and leadership. Seize opportunities in business dealings and act on them. Expect acknowledgement.

YOUR WEEK AHEAD



ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): Today is a mixed bag. There are fun opportunities to play and enjoy socialising with others. Be careful who you choose to associate with, because they might irk you. This Week: Work hard, party harder.



TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): Home and family are your primary focus right now. Discussions about money, kids, vacations and fun outings might trigger disputes or confrontations. This Week: Warm family relations. Be patient on Wednesday.



GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Today people will notice you more than usual. However, it's easy to find yourself at odds with authority figures, parents, bosses and even the police. Even family members are not sympathetic. This Week: You impress others. Go for the gold.



CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Steer clear of controversial subjects today because some people are just itching for a fight. Don't let them find you. This Week: It's a friendly week with warm conversations.



LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): Despite your interest in cash flow, earnings and financial matters today, don't discuss these issues with anyone else, especially if someone owes you money. Keep to yourself as much as possible. This Week: Make your pitch.



VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): Relations with partners, spouses and close friends, as well as authority figures, are dicey. Seek solitude for your own peace of mind. This Week: You're ambitious and charming.



LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): You like to keep the peace, and you like harmonious surroundings. Today people are too quick to be on each other's case or to dispute issues and even criticise others. A friend might help. This Week: Go after what you want.



SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): This is a tough day for romance because people are in a bad mood. Your feelings might be quickly hurt. Or you might hurt someone else's feelings. Do your best to be friendly and diplomatic. This Week: Job interview; pitch a project; impress the boss.



SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): This is a poor day to approach authority figures to ask for permission or approval. Don't do it. Likewise, discussions with partners, spouses and close friends also might be alienating. This Week: Travel. Patience with partners.



CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Because people are sensitive and also unnecessarily critical, issues with work colleagues might come to a head today and create problems. It's not good. Say as little as possible. This Week: You're confident!



AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): This is the perfect day for a nap. Romantic relationships are stressed and disappointing. Parents might find dealing with their kids to be an increased responsibility or challenge. This Week: A laid-back, upbeat mood. Enjoy.



PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Bury yourself in work or escape somewhere, because your relations with others are challenged today. Be sympathetic and understanding. Social outings, sports and activities with children might be an excellent choice for you. This Week: Good times.

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Once the game is over, the __ and the __ go back in the same box - Italian proverb (4,...,4)

DLPAI

CINOGP

AEXNN

CDEIKW

same box - Italian proverb

ANSWER: Once the game is over, the king and the queen go back in the same box - Italian proverb

SUDOKU 6398

DIFFICULTY LEVEL 5s INSTRUCTIONS
To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL
1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

				5				
		3						
8	6			7			6	
	7	9						1
	2					4		
1				3		2		
	8	2	6			1	5	
5		4			8			
			5					

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6397

6	9	1	5	2	3	8	7	4
4	7	2	1	8	6	5	3	9
8	5	3	7	4	9	6	2	1
5	3	4	2	7	8	1	9	6
1	6	7	3	9	5	2	4	8
2	8	9	4	6	1	3	5	7
9	4	8	6	5	2	7	1	3
3	2	6	9	1	7	4	8	5
7	1	5	8	3	4	9	6	2

Government of Odisha
Corrigendum to Bid Identification No. CCE.Ctc. (R&B) 6/2026-27
E-mail: ID-secterb_2006@yahoo.co.in,
Tel/Fax-0671-2301751/2302751

34001/571/2627

Office Order No. 4419 Dt. 30.07.2026

Tender Reference-No. CCE.Ctc. (R&B) 6/2026-27

The Bid availability period and Date of opening of the tenders have been modified due to unavoidable circumstances. The modified dates are as follows:-

Sl. No.	Bid Identification No.	Bid Availability period as per Tender Notice	Revised Bid Availability period	Bid opening Date as per Tender Notice	Revised opening Date
1	CCE.Ctc.(R&B)6/2026-27	30.07.2026 to 5.30 Hours of 13.08.2026	04.08.2026 to 5.30 Hours of 18.08.2026	14.08.2026 at 11.00 Hours	19.08.2026 at 11.00 Hours

All other terms and conditions remain unchanged. Further details can be seen from the website <http://tendersodisha.gov.in>

Sd/-
Chief Construction Engineer
Kataka(R&B)Circle

OIPR-34001/34012/1/26-27/0024

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CHITTARANJAN LOCOMOTIVE WORKS

E-Tender Notice
E-Tenders under work contracts are invited for and on behalf of the President of India for the following works: SL No.: 1011. Tender Nos.: Engg-28-2026-27. Name of the work: Provision of G+1 RPF Insp. chamber, CCTV Room & Ladies RPF Barrack at Dankuni Loco Works of CLW at Dankuni. Advertised Value (Rupees): ₹ 51,22,758.54. Earnest Money Deposit (Rupees): ₹ 1,02,500.00. Period of Completion : 4 months. Date of Closing: 18.08.2026@12:00. Note : (1) Complete details can be seen in the Railways website www.ireps.gov.in & www.clw.indianrailways.gov.in. (2) Contact Number: 9163340201. Dy. Chief Engineer/ PR6/446 CLW/Chittaranjan
Visit us on: www.facebook.com/clwrailways

SOUTH COAST RAILWAY VISAKHAPATNAM

Follow us on @SCoRailway Website: www.scorailways.gov.in
Tender Notice No. 78265001 Dt. 30.07.2026
SCOR HQ-STORES/SOUTH COAST RAILWAY, acting for & on behalf of The President of India invites E-Tenders against Tender No. 78265001 Closing Date/Time 20-AUG-26 14:30 Hrs. Bidders will be able to submit their original/revised bids upto closing date and time only. Manual offers are not allowed against this tender, and any such manual offer received shall be ignored.;

Tender No. 78265001 Dt: 30.07.2026, Description: Supply and Installation of Workstations, Qty.: 275 sets, **Bid Closing Date & Time:** 20.08.2026 at 14:30 Hrs, **Estimated Value (₹):** 50,87,500.00, **Earnest Money (₹):** 1,01,750.00, **Validity of Offer:** 90 Days
Tender conditions/other particulars such as the details of Name of work in full, the similar nature of the above works, eligibility criteria etc., are available in the Tender documents published in website at "www.ireps.gov.in".

Principal Chief Material Manager/ SCOR-A147 Visakhapatnam

For further tender conditions/ details and for downloading the tender documents, please visit the website at <https://www.ireps.gov.in>.

UJVNL Ltd.
(An Uttarakhand Govt. Enterprises)
H.O. "UJJWAL" Maharani Bagh, GMS Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephone-0135-2763808 Fax: 0135-2763508
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website: www.ujvnl.com

RO No. 639 Tender Notice Date: 31.07.2026
Office of the Executive Engineer (Civil), UJVNL Ltd., Lohiahead Khatima, invites sealed tenders from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below:
Tender No.: 03/EE(Civil)/Lohiahead/Khatima/2026-27 & 04/EE(Civil)/Lohiahead/Khatima/2026-27
Name of Work: 1. "Annual M&R works of residential Buildings of Lohiahead Colony for the year 2026-27".
2. "Annual M&R works of Non residential Buildings of Lohiahead Colony and other miscellaneous civil works at Sharda Power House Complex for the year 2026-27"
Estimated Cost: Rs. 24,99,836.00, and Rs. 24,99,841.00 respectively
Date of availability of bid Document on website: From 17:00 hrs of 01.08.2026
Last Date for submission of Tender: Up to 13:00 hrs of 25.08.2026
For fuller & further details, kindly visit our website, the tender document can be downloaded from the Nigam's website www.ujvnl.com
Executive Engineer (Civil)

"AVOID WASTEFUL USE OF ELECTRICITY"

कार्यालय, नगर पालिक निगम, कोरबा (छत्तीसगढ़)
ई-प्रोक्च्यूरमेंट निविदा सूचना

क. 1507/ज.प्र./2026 दिनांक 30.07.2026
एकोकृत पंजीयन प्रणाली अंतर्गत सक्षम श्रेणी में पंजीकृत टेकंदरों से निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु शेड्यूल अनुसार लमसम दरों पर E-tendering के माध्यम से निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है:-

क.	कार्य का विवरण	अनुमानित लागत (रु.लाख में)	निविदा दालने की अंतिम तिथि
1	Design, construction, erection, testing and commissioning of 20 MLD Tertiary Treatment Plant for NTPC Korba including operation and maintenance of entire scheme for 15 Years (3rd Call)	16438.95	11.08.2026 T.No. 196436)

उपरोक्त कार्यों की निविदा की जानकारी ई-प्रोक्च्यूरमेंट वेब पोर्टल <http://eproc.cgstate.gov.in> से डाउनलोड की जा सकती है, साथ ही निगम के वेब साईट www.korbamunicipal.in एवं www.korba.urbanecg.gov.in पर भी देखी जा सकती है।

हस्ता/-
अधीक्षक अभियंता
नगर पालिक निगम
कोरबा (छत्तीसगढ़)

॥ स्वच्छ भारत निर्माण में योगदान दें ॥

VASANTDADA SUGAR INSTITUTE
Manjari Bk. Tal. Haveli, Dist. Pune 412307.
Ph.: 020-26902316/26902286 Website : www.vsisugar.com

E-Tender Notice

We are inviting e-Tender for the following works from the reputed /registered Government / PWD Civil contractors of mentioned above class and above or having bid capacity equivalent amount of work can apply for tender which is on percentage basis.

Sr. No.	Name of Work	Contractor Class
1	Construction of Foundation for Digesters in Bio Digester Demo plant at Manjari.	Class VII
2	Proposed Construction of Brick Masonry Wall for Plinth Protection at Alcohol Technological Demonstration Park, VSI Manjari Campus.	Class VII
3	Construction of Toilet Block near Alcohol Technological park at Manjari.	Class VA
4	Construction of Foundation for Tensile roof structure for AGM shed at Manjari.	Class V
5	Providing and Fabricating Tensile Fabric Roof for AGM shed at Manjari.	Class IV

● **Note :** For Detailed tender notice please visit MKCL website : sugarmart.sets.co.in All right to reject any or all tenders without assigning any reason whatsoever is reserved by VSI.

Director General

UJVNL LTD.
H.O. "UJJWAL" Maharani Bagh, G.M.S. Road, Dehradun-248006
Telephone: 0135 - 2763808, Fax 0135-2763508
CIN No. U40101UR2001SGC025866 Website: www.ujvnl.com

Letter No 641 Dated 31.07.2026
Office of the EE(IC&CM) Ganga Bhawan, Yamuna Colony, Dehradun, invites online bids from interested parties. Brief summary of tender is given below:
Tender No: 04/EE(IC&CM)/2026-27
Name of work/ Supply/Service: Procurement of Safety Equipment's for different power houses of UJVNL Ltd.
Estimated cost : Rs.1,61,33,200.00 GST Extra
Date of availability of bid documents on website: 01.08.2026 from 16:00Hrs. Last date for submission of bids on website: 22.08.2026 up to 17:00 Hrs. For fuller & further details, kindly visit e-procurement portal <http://uktenders.gov.in> **EE(IC&CM)**

"Avoid Wasteful use of Electricity"

U.P. RAJYA VIDYUT UTPADAN NIGAM LIMITED

ANPARA - SONEBHADRA

E-Tender notice and scope of work

- E-Tender Notice no:- GEM/2026/B/7814603**, Overhauling of main boiler viz drum, Deaerator, replacement of coal nozzle assembly and dampers of unit #2 of 3x210MW, ATPS, Anpara. EMD Rs. 25,500.00, Last date of tender: 20.08.2026 (16:00 Hrs).
- E-Tender Notice no:- GEM/2026/B/7808769**, Insitu boiler tube coating by HVOF technique (high velocity oxygen fuel) during overhauling of unit no. 4, 2x500MW, BTPS, Anpara. EMD Rs. 31,000.00, Last date of tender: 10.08.2026 (17:00 Hrs).
- E-Tender Notice no:- GEM/2026/B/7817577**, Supply of MDV & MPO for XRP 803, 3x210MW, ATPS, Anpara. EMD Rs. 25,000.00, Last date of tender: 05.08.2026 (13:00 Hrs).
- E-Tender Notice no:- GEM/2026/B/7825134**, Construction of temporary store of size 15.0m x 12.0m/3.5

MEDAL Tally

	Country	G	S	B	Total
1	AUS	61	37	50	148
2	ENG	24	40	34	98
3	CAN	18	18	21	57
4	IND	13	16	8	37
5	SCO	11	8	17	36

*TILL 01/08, 11:45 PM

INDIA watch



Triple jumper Praveen Chithravel. PTI

Chithravel, Selva clinch silver, bronze in triple jump

Praveen Chithravel and Selva Prabhu won silver and bronze medal in the men's triple jump to repeat the double podium after men's javelin throw last night at the Commonwealth Games in Glasgow. Praveen won the silver medal with a best jump of 16.58m while Selva Prabu won the bronze medal with 16.52m. It was redemption for Praveen who finished a close fourth in the 2022 edition in Birmingham. While Praveen is Asian Games bronze medalist, this was Selva's first major international medal.

Jamaica's Jordan Scott won the gold medal in the event with a 16.72m jump. This is the eighth and ninth medal for India in Athletics with a total of five silver medals and four bronze medals. Disappointment continued in the women's 10000m race walk event as well after Priyanka Goswami ended up at seventh despite clocking a season's best 45:53.93. The other Indian in the fray, Ravina, was disqualified. ENS

TODAY'S SCHEDULE

CYCLING

Men's 40km points race qualifying round: Harshveer Singh Sekhon (Heat 1), Dinesh Kumar (Heat 2) **2:09 pm**
Men's 1000m time trial final: Ronaldo Laitorjam **3:51 pm**

PARA CYCLING

Women's C4-C5 1000m TT final: Lisha Das **8:40 pm**

JUDO

Women's -78kg round of 16: Ishroop Narang vs Nicole Wood (Scotland) **2:30 pm**
Men's -100kg round of 16: Avtar Singh vs Aristos Michael (Cyprus) **2:36 pm**
Men's +100kg round of 16: Yash Ghanghas vs Joshua Whitehouse (Wales) **2:48 pm**

9 MEDALS & COUNTING IN TRACK AND FIELD, ONE MORE THAN 2022 HAUL

Red-hot Pathirage throws down the gauntlet to Chopra

Lankan wins gold ahead of Asiad; Neeraj, Yash Vir make it double podium for India

Nihal Koshie

New Delhi, August 1

SRI LANKA'S Rumesh Tharanga Pathirage registered just one legal throw in the final of the men's javelin but with 89.75 metres, he outclassed a world-class field, comprising the Olympic Champion, the World Champion and India's golden boy Neeraj Chopra to win the gold medal at the Glasgow Commonwealth Games.

As compelling as Pathirage's story is - a fast bowler-turned-javelin thrower from an island nation known more for producing sprinters - the bigger picture was the continuing shift in the power centre of the discipline. For the first time at the Commonwealth Games, all three javelin medallists were from South Asia, with Chopra winning the silver (85.83m) and another Indian, Yash Vir Singh, finishing third with 85.41 metres in his sixth and final throw.

Pathirage also showed why he is special. When Chopra went into the provisional first position with 85.83 metres in the second round, the Sri Lankan immediately responded with his best throw of the day, close to 90 metres. From there on, everyone was playing catch-up.

While mainland European nations, the traditional powerhouses in javelin, are hardly a part of the Commonwealth Games, recent results have shown that challengers from other parts of the world are making major progress and



Neeraj Chopra bagged the men's javelin throw silver medal at Commonwealth Games 2026 with a best effort of 85.83m. PTI

winning the big medals.

This is not the first time Asians have won major medals in javelin throw. Chopra is an Olympic and World Champion. At the 2024 Paris Olympics, Pakistan's Arshad Nadeem and Chopra completed a 1-2 on the podium, while Grenada's Anderson Peters finished third to mark the first time no European was on the podium in the history of the Summer Games.

At last year's World Championships, a resurgent Keshorn Walcott of Trinidad and Tobago, who stunned the world when he won the 2012 London Olympics gold, finished first. Peters and USA's Curtis Thompson won silver and bronze respectively to keep the Europeans off the podium again.

Kenya's Julius Yego played

The biggest takeaway from Glasgow for India is not the silver medal for Chopra but Yash Vir finishing third

his role in pushing the Europeans aside by winning the 2015 World Championships. No European has won gold at the World Championships or Olympics in nearly a decade.

Lot of contenders

The biggest takeaway from Glasgow for India is not the silver medal for Chopra but Singh finishing third, making a double podium for the country. While Chopra has been the trailblazer by becoming the

first Indian to win gold in track and field at the Olympics or the World Championships, others like Singh have been inspired to dream big.

Singh made a mark when he bettered Chopra's Under-20 Federation Cup record in 2021. But he bided his time before shining on the big stage.

Others like Kishore Kumar Jena (Asian Games silver medallist) and Sachin Yadav (Asian Championship silver medallist) have made an impact, but consistency and bouncing back post injury have been the biggest challenges for those aiming to emulate Chopra.

As for Pathirage, winning gold in tough conditions with headwinds, is a considerable achievement. He had been the only thrower this year to cross

the 90-metre mark, achieved at the Diamond League in Rome last month, to lay down the marker ahead of the Commonwealth Games. While he was undoubtedly talented, the world was waiting to see if he had it in him to deliver in a final when competing among some of the finest in the world.

The fierce competitor in Chopra won't be happy with a second-place finish despite a season-best throw in Glasgow. On his return from a nine-month injury layoff, he had finished fourth at the Doha Diamond League. At the Asian Games, he will again face Pathirage and Nadeem, the reigning Olympic champion. Failure at the CWG will spur the Pakistani to prove a point in Aichi-Nagoya. In global javelin, being the best in Asia carries weight.

Yash saves best for last to script success post surgery

Nihal Koshie

New Delhi, August 1

YASH VIR SINGH was expected to go places when he broke Neeraj Chopra's Under-20 Federation Cup record five years ago. A shoulder surgery in late 2023 set him back as it took him nearly a year to throw in a competition again.

In the meantime, others moved up the pecking order; Kishore Kumar Jena won an Asian Games silver medal, while Sachin Yadav came second at the Asian Championships. But when the stars aligned, the 24-year-old son of a former Railways javelin champion, stepped up with his best effort to win a bronze at the Commonwealth Games and make it a double podium finish, along with Chopra who won the silver.

In cold and windy conditions, Chopra produced his biggest throw of 85.83 metres in the second round, also his season's best. Yash Vir left it for the last round.

After his five prior throws, his best of 81.33m had placed him sixth. Reigning World Champion Keshorn Walcott's last attempt of 82.55m had pushed Yash Vir to seventh place before he came up with a personal best of 85.41 to clinch a bronze, his first major international medal.

While watching his son compete in Glasgow, Rai Singh said he didn't feel any nerves, even when he was well outside the medal standings after round five.

"There was wind but in javelin, a 2-3 metre improvement can happen suddenly because there are so many factors. He had thrown well in practice, it was just a question of getting that one good throw. I just told him to be confident because he has a big throw in him. Thankfully, he produced it at the right time," Rai, who hails from the boxing hotbed of Bhiwani, said.

Yash Vir started training for javelin at the age of 13. His first coach was his father, who has won multiple national medals.



Yash Vir Singh came up with a personal best of 85.41 metres. PTI

Though Rai's parents live in Devsar in Bhiwani, a nursery of Olympian boxers, he wanted to keep his son away from the ring. Yash Vir grew up in Jaipur but would often visit his paternal grandparents.

"Even if you win, you get punched in boxing. I did not

want him to get into boxing. If he was to take up some sport, it had to be javelin throw. When there is a coach at home, why try any other sport? Today, he has achieved what I could not. In a way, I am living my dream through him," Rai said on Saturday.

He was overjoyed as he watched his son clinch the CWG bronze. The shoulder surgery and the rehabilitation phase were tough for the father-son duo.

"Injuries do happen in javelin. That's part and parcel of the sport. He was out of the sport for almost a year. If not for the shoulder injury, he could have progressed much faster. But there is a time for everything. You get what you deserve if you work hard. Yash Vir had the potential, he just needed the right moment," the proud father added.

Rai's also keen that Yash Vir avoids the mistakes he made when he was an active athlete.

"Our era was different. We were not aware of the latest training techniques or even diet. But now things have changed not only in sports science but also in Indian javelin. Youngsters these days have a lot of confidence and can win medals at big events. This medal will give Yash Vir the needed boost," Rai added.

'Tejaswin is the complete picture of grit, resilience'



WAYNE LOMBARD

I TRAVEL with Tejaswin Shankar for the majority of his decathlons. At the Commonwealth Games, we knew it would be a challenge for him to do both the high jump and the decathlon.

The flare-up

Tejaswin had this tendon issue for quite some time but we had been able to manage it on most occasions.

The flare-up occurred in the warm-up before the high jump, and he came to me on the side and mentioned it. We tried a few things to see if it could settle down but it didn't get better.

It became very sore by the time of his first jump. The good thing is that TJ knows his body well and if he hadn't pulled out, it would have been very difficult for him to recover.

Was there any doubt that he would be able to participate in the decathlon? For sure, there was doubt. There was doubt right up until he was on the starting blocks for the 100m.

The recovery

After my conversation with Dr Dinshaw Pardiwala, I was relieved. He said there wasn't a significant change in the tendon structures. That's when I knew there was a viable chance of him competing, if we attacked the rehab and recovery as aggressively as possible.

Doc prescribed a few anti-inflammatories, which he took up until the first day of the competition, which helped with pain sensation and exactly what we were going to do with the installation of the tendon.

We wanted to get the knee as quiet as possible. So, in the first 24 hours, the main focus was keeping the knee quiet. So, between the anti-inflammatories, there was a lot of icing and rehab. Instead of one big rehab session, we did two or three smaller rehab sessions throughout the day, just to stimulate that healing process of the tendon. We did some of the isometric-type work. We didn't do eccentric work as it could have caused him more discomfort.

We needed some alternative modalities and that's when I googled to locate a Hyperbaric Chamber that allowed us to put in more oxygen to recover and promote healing.

After that, we used focal red-light therapy that allowed us to stimulate that exact spot where he was feeling pain. We also did some magnetic energy therapy,



Tejaswin claimed India's maiden decathlon medal at CWG. AP

which sends magnetic pulses through the entire joint and targets any inflammation within that joint.

With 24 hours gone, we did basic upper-body strength sessions with power movements. It helped us stimulate his central nervous system and keep it primed. We repeated the modalities for the first day as we had got a good response.

Decathlon Day 1 and 2

On the morning of the event, he felt really good. He did his warm-up in the hotel gym. While leaning on the starting blocks, he felt confident. I have known TJ for 10 years now and know how his body responds. So, I knew that he would start the event well.

Tejaswin started slow off the blocks in 100m but then did a massive jump in the second event which gave him a lot of confidence. The tendon didn't flare up during the long jump or the high jump. He looked like he was in pain but eventually the pain subsided.

After he came back, we did the set routine for recoveries and he went off to sleep as it was necessary to get as much rest as possible.

When I met him in the morning, he said it felt like a normal day two and that was the best response I could get as it meant there was no sign of tendon inflammation or flare.

We went for a hot bath rather than cold because I felt that it would be better for the tendon as it was chilly outside. He did some mobility and isometrics with me and looked good to go. The second day was much better than the first as his knee was responding and he looked more comfortable in the 110m hurdles than he looked in the 100m.

Mental resolve

When he came back after the injury, he was really emotional. He felt that he had let everyone down and I felt my role there was to just support him and let him express his emotions. Once he was done with negative thoughts, I said that I am here to deal with all this and let me work on him. After we were done, it was all TJ.

For someone to go into an event knowing they're only 80 percent and take it one step at a time, concentrating on each event without letting the pain and sensation of their tendon disrupt his performance, gives a complete picture of grit and resilience. That's just who TJ is.

(Dr Wayne Lombard is a renowned strength and conditioning coach and works with elite Indian athletes. He talked to Pritish Raj.)

HURLING ADVERSITY AWAY

A landmine took his leg and sport; he found both again in a different throw

Nitin Sharma

Chandigarh, August 1

WITH A throw of 13.40m, Indian Army havildar Soman Rana became the first Indian shot putter to win the title in the men's para F57 category at the Commonwealth Games, in Glasgow on Saturday. Compatriot Shubham Juyal took silver with 13.28m, completing India's first-ever one-two finish in the event.

"The conditions were a bit cold here and we have seen para athletes as well as athletes struggling a little with the conditions. The talk with both Soman and Shubham was to assess the conditions and make the throws keeping in mind the cold. We are glad that both could throw their season

best and give India a one-two finish. These performances will also motivate both Soman and Shubham for improved performances in the Asian Para Games," Indian para coach Subedar Major Rakesh Rawat told *The Indian Express* from Glasgow.

The title followed a medal at last year's World Para Athletics Championships in Delhi, where Rana finished on the podium behind Iran's world-record throw. On December 1, 2006, Rana, then a sepoy with the 2/8 Gorkha Rifles, lost his right leg to a landmine blast on a search operation in the Poonch sector of Jammu and Kashmir. A national-level middleweight boxer who had trained alongside Vijender Singh, his boxing career ended



Soman Rana won in the men's para F57 category. REUTERS

with the blast, and he spent the next ten years in administrative roles within his unit.

A visit to Pune for a new

prosthetic leg changed that. There, Rana met Colonel Gaurav Dutta, head of the Army Paralympic Node, who recom-

mended him for training. Competing in the F57 category, where athletes throw from a seated position, Rana found the mechanics of a shot put throw were not far removed from the punch he had spent years perfecting.

"I was a middleweight boxer for five years at the national level and served in my unit in missions as well before the landmine blast. But as an Indian Army soldier, I was always ready for something like this happening to me. When I heard about para sports on the visit to Pune in 2017 with Col Gaurav Dutta leading the centre, I thought I can bring laurels for India in this field too. One of my initial throws was about 10m but then as we all, including eventual Paris Paralympics

bronze medallist Hokato Sema, would train together under specialist coaches, we all tried and learned from each other's technique," Rana said.

Within three years of taking up the sport, Rana had qualified for the Tokyo Paralympics. He finished fifth at Paris 2024, added silver at the 2022 Asian Para Games, and now stands on top of a Commonwealth Games podium.

Watching from Guwahati was Som Bahadur Poon, a former Services team-mate and the 2002 Manchester Commonwealth Games silver medallist in boxing, now a coach at the Khelo India Centre in Guwahati. Poon remembered how Rana's old boxing teammates had rallied around him after the amputa-

tion. "All of his boxing teammates from the Gorkha Rifles would motivate him and spend time with him at the Gorkha Training Centre in Happy Valley, Shillong. As he won the title today, I plan to call him and reshare all the boxing memories," Poon said.

Beside Rana on the podium was 30-year-old Shubham Juyal, a Roorkee native and Lance Naik with the 51 Engineer Regiment, who threw his own season best of 13.28m. Juyal lost his right leg in a motorcycle accident on the day he was due to appear for his Army Cadet College exam.

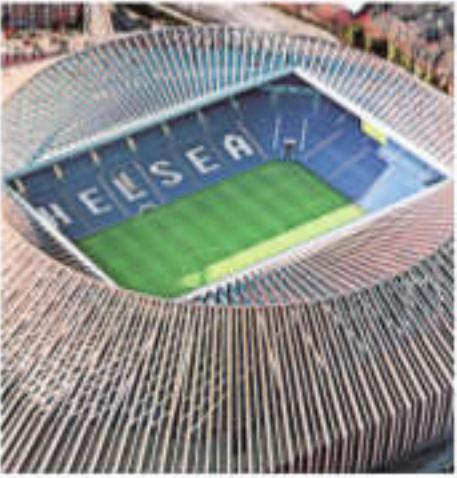
He turned to para sports in 2023, after also being recommended for the Army Paralympic Node, and has since finished seventh at last year's

World Para Athletics Championships and won medals at the Indian Open Grand Prix, the Nationals and the Khelo India Para Games.

His silver in Glasgow arrived, by coincidence, on the exact anniversary of the day his leg was amputated, in 2022.

"I have never felt dejected in all these years. Even after my accident, prior to which I was hoping to clear the ACC exam and become an officer with the Indian Army, I did not lose hope. When I started para sports at the Paralympic Node in Pune, I knew that I could bring laurels to the country by winning medals. Today's medal is a message to all the countrymen who feel dejected after such losses: do not lose hope," Juyal said from Glasgow.

Chelsea fined £10 million for FA rule breaches



A view of the proposed Chelsea home stadium. FILE

Reuters
August 1

CHELSEA HAVE been fined £10 million (\$13.41 million) by the English FA after admitting to multiple historical breaches of regulations, the governing body said on Friday.

The breaches were self-reported by Chelsea following its takeover by U.S. investor Todd Boehly and private equity firm Clearlake Capital in May 2022. The Premier League club avoided a points deduction after successfully appealing part of the original punishment. However, Chelsea will face a suspended two-window registration ban through to June 30, 2027.

After reviewing the case, an independent Regulatory Commission initially imposed a suspended six-point deduction, but that sanction was later set aside on appeal.

“Chelsea FC admitted to 74 breaches of FA Rule E1.2 prior to a hearing and an independent Regulatory Commission imposed a six-point deduction, which was to be suspended until 30 June 2027, and a £10 million fine,” the FA said in a statement.

“The club appealed against the suspended points deduction and an independent Appeal Board allowed the appeal and set aside this sanction following a further hearing.”

Rule breaches included of regulations relating to third-party investments and on working with intermediaries, among others.

The £10 million fine was not subject to appeal, with the FA adding that the full amount will be directed towards grassroots football initiatives.

“In 2022, the club self-reported potential historical rule breaches to all applicable regulators,” Chelsea said in a statement.

“Following that report, it has worked openly and transparently with all regulators, including voluntarily and proactively disclosing many thousands of documents.”

The latest sanction follows other financial penalties imposed on Chelsea for historical regulatory violations.

In March, the club was fined a record £10.75 million for breaches of the Premier League regulations. Chelsea were also handed a one-year first-team transfer ban, suspended for two years, along with an immediate nine-month ban on academy player transfers.

The £10 million fine was not subject to appeal, with the FA adding that the full amount will be directed towards grassroots football initiatives.

MEDAL SURGE IN BOXING

Indian boxers a class apart as seven golds set a new standard

Apart from three pugilists, every Indian who entered the ring tasted victory in the final

Shashank Nair
New Delhi, August 1

A SINGLE boxer was yet to step into the ring on Saturday when India had already broken Commonwealth Games boxing records. Ten assured medals before a punch was thrown on the final day of the boxing programme in Glasgow. Weakened field or not, it's a rare feat in Indian boxing, especially considering the administrative mess that the sport finds itself in the country.

The seven gold medals and three silver won by the pugilists makes India the top boxing contingent at the 2026 Commonwealth Games and sets up the Ahmedabad edition four years hence rather well.

With traditional strong suits like shooting, wrestling and badminton absent from the diluted Commonwealth Games, boxing was the only discipline where Indian muscles could be flexed.

After finishing second in the medal tally at Gold Coast 2018 (3 x Gold, 3 x Silver, 3 x Bronze) and Birmingham 2022 (3 x Gold, 1 x Silver, 3 x Bronze), anything under eight medals would have been considered a regression.

But India's team, especially the women boxers, have steadily ascended towards the top at the world level over the last year, and continued that same run without many of the heavy hitters from England and Australia.

Sakshi Chaudhary —who replaced Nikhat Zareen in the 51kg category — Preeti Pawar, Jaismine Lamboriya and Lovlina Borgohain are all capable of being in the mix for multi-sport event medals.

They form the backbone of a strong all-weather women's team that can go toe-to-toe against some of the best boxing countries in the world. Priya Ghanghas added a gold to the tally as well and concluded a successful campaign for the Indian women.

In the men's category, Sachin Siwach and Ankush both were declared victorious on the judges scorecard.

On Saturday, barring Lovlina and Jadumani Singh, every Indian boxer tasted success in their title bout.

Lovlina came up against current Worlds bronze medalist Emma Sue Greentree of Australia and suffered a 1-4 loss in a contest that went down to the wire before the Assamese boxer's in-bout fatigue management – a familial issue that has been plaguing her since moving up weight categories after her Tokyo Olympic bronze



India's Jaismine (R) and Michaela Walsh of Northern Ireland compete in the women's 57kg boxing final. AP

● Rocking in the ring



India's Preeti Pawar reacts after winning against Canada's Scarlett Delgado. PTI

BOXER	CATEGORY	RESULT
Women		
Preeti Pawar	54 kg	Gold
Jaismine Lamboria	57 kg	Gold
Sakshi Chaudhary	51 kg	Gold
Priya Ghanghas	60 kg	Gold
Arundhati Choudhary	70 kg	Gold
Lovlina Borgohain	75 kg	Silver
Men		
Sachin Siwach	60 kg	Gold
Ankush Panghal	80 kg	Gold
Jadumani Singh	55 kg	Silver
Narender	90+ kg	Silver

*TILL 11:30 PM

medal – decided the fight in her opponent's favour.

Best in business

Jaismine is the reigning world champion in the 57kg class. But at 25, she is still learning how to use her considerable gifts in her category. On Saturday, she was provided yet another test of her range – this time against Michaela Walsh, a boxer who has medals from the 2014, 2018, 2022 and now the 2026 Commonwealth Games.

Walsh is the typical of boxers that Jaismine struggles against – shorter but skillful in short bursts when moving inside. But the world champion has continued her growth and showcased it in the win.

Out of all Indian women's gold medals on Saturday, Jaismine went through the toughest bout and came out on the other side with a gold to add to her already burgeoning medal cabinet.

Later Olympic Gold Quest CEO Viren Rasquinha said that the Indian had got little time to practice ahead of the CWG.

“40 days ago, Jaismine was

in hospital for continuous high fever and stomach issues. She had only three weeks of training post recovery. Today, she wins GOLD at CWG after beating the reigning Champion from NIR,” he tweeted.

Perhaps the best Indian boxer at the event was the one with the easiest bouts on her hand.

Smooth run

The 54kg category in India itself is a minefield with multiple boxers vying for the spot. Competition has been fierce for years. But at the Commonwealth Games, Preeti's run to the gold medal was as smooth as it could get.

There is an argument to be made that the CWG gold was easier than some of the national competitions that she has competed in.

The southpaw easily landed the best shots among all Indians.

The most eye-catching among them was a blow from the right, masked as an uppercut but landing as a cross, used on multiple occasions.

Arundhati from Kota shines in the ring, with help from YouTube

Shashank Nair
New Delhi, August 1

IT'S TOUGH to find a subject for which there isn't a tutor in the city of Kota, but Suresh Choudhary and his studious daughter managed to do the unimaginable: their search for a subject-matter expert failed, because Kota did not have a single boxing coach.

The daughter in question, Arundhati Choudhary, won gold in the women's 70kg on Saturday at the SEC Centre in Glasgow, one of seven Indians to win gold on a record-breaking day for India's boxing programme at these Commonwealth Games.

“She used to enjoy playing all sports, but basketball was the one she used to play regularly. She was the captain of her school team. I used to try to convince her that there is no career in sports and to focus completely on studies. But when she was in 6th standard, we had a fight because she wanted to continue playing sport, and I felt that 'Kota ka mahaul padhai ke liye bohot acha hai' — Kota's environment is very good for studies,” says Suresh.

“All of India comes here to study. But she threw a tantrum and insisted she wanted to play sports.”

Suresh came around, on a compromise: she could play sport, but one where her individual excellence could shine rather than get lost in a team game. Basketball was out. Wrestling and shooting were discussed, but Suresh says his daughter's eyes lit up when she realised boxing was an Olympic sport. A girl known for picking fights with kids at school, Arundhati had just found out that what she did in the schoolyard could become a profession.

Finding a coach, though, stumped them both. Eventually they landed at the doorstep of Ashok Gautam, a local instructor who taught martial arts like wushu and taekwondo. Gautam admitted he knew nothing about boxing. So he started watching Muhammad Ali and Mike Tyson videos on YouTube, working through whatever instructional footage other coaches had uploaded, and relaying what he learned back to Arundhati.

Kota had found itself another tutor, and a future boxing gold medalist. It wasn't until Arundhati was 16, and reached the junior nationals despite barely any competition to prepare her in Kota,



Arundhati Choudhary won gold in the 70 kg category. AP

that her father realised boxing was serious. When she forced a referee to stop a contest against a boxer from Haryana, the state that has long dominated Indian contact sports, Suresh finally accepted that only one of his daughters was going to be the studious one, and it wasn't going to be the one boxing.

Carrying injury

Twenty-three now, Arundhati won this medal the way many athletes at these Games have: carrying an injury. “She has a plate near her wrist from an injury she suffered earlier. Her other wrist needs to be looked at as well, and she also has a linear fracture in her heel,” Suresh says. Surgery would have meant inactivity, and inactivity, in a competitive Indian boxing scene, risks losing your spot to someone else.

That fear was real for years before it ever became a medal story.

Arundhati spent a long stretch on the sidelines because she shared a weight class with Lovlina Borgohain, whose height and reach carried her to Olympic and Asian Games medals. Once Lovlina moved up to 75kg, Arundhati finally got her run in the team. There was a kind of vindication, then, in beating Rosie Eccles in the semi-final, the same Welsh boxer who had beaten Lovlina a weight class above at Birmingham in 2022.

In the final, it was another India-England contest, the two countries that have traded blows at the top of CWG boxing standings for years. Arundhati convinced all five judges, a unanimous decision over her English opponent, for gold.

Tanvi sets up Taipei Open final showdown with Nguyen

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, August 1

INDIA'S TEEN badminton ace Tanvi Sharma unleashed a torrent of varied strokes to defeat World No. 24 Huang Yu-Hsun 21-17, 21-11 and make the Super 300 Taipei Open finals. In the second semifinal, Unnati Hooda found Vietnamese Thuy Linh Nguyen's swift, canny movements too much to negotiate as she went down 21-15, 21-18 in 41 minutes.

The Indian World No.28 couldn't recover from a 13-6 deficit in the opening set, as the 28-year-old opponent, ten years her senior, used all her experience to play steady and retrieve cleanly. In the second,

Unnati had a hefty 16-11 lead, but rushed through the points winning only 2 of the next 12.

Nguyen was easily beaten 21-19, 21-9 by Tanvi the last time the Indian made finals at US. She has made three finals since – at Canada, Vietnam and Korea Masters but only has Orleans quarters to show for this season. Against Huang, a serve into the net after Tanvi comfortably led 17-11 was the only blip phase in an otherwise dominant show against an opponent who couldn't handle the Indian's stinging attack.

Tanvi has crosscourt whip-lash smashes on both flanks and it was a simple matter of getting the local Taiwanese rooted on the other side. She



Tanvi Sharma beat World No. 24 Huang Yu-Hsun in the semis. PTI

can manoeuvre opponents with her forecourt drops though it was her deception on pushes to the back line that dealt the most damage.

Skirting the lines

Error-prone on bad days, Tanvi would do well to not change her game that skirts the lines when she aims pinpoint shuttle deliveries to the corners. On Saturday, she was nailing most of those back court pings. The most exquisite was the back-of-the-wrist push that she pulled back at the last moment to send it straight and land it just close to the line, which with full force would've gone long. It oozed skill that goes beyond the power-attack.

Coach Park Tae Sang had his quibbles, before she took a 11-9 lead in the second and corrected her first set dawdle by taking 10 of the next 12 points.

With Tanvi, the strokes are placed as full-stops, not commas, so the rallies tend to stay short. Huang, 22, just did not possess the breadth of defense to prolong the rallies. Her flank defense was poor and the talented Tanvi's smashes tend to travel with a zip. Perhaps Huang's only chance was in drawing the Indian ranked 34, forward. There is a massive striding caginess in Tanvi's lunge. A dangerous movement fault that can cause injury if not addressed. She over-estimates the length of her long stride at the net, lands

on the out-sole and puts her ankle at risk. At least 4 times in the match, the lunge drew gasps. Her recovery from the lunge for the next return also needs work. But making her first final after last year's US Open, you couldn't fault her much on how prolific her winners-to-errors ratio is.

The falling-short lunge combined with her serving into the net and a line error would've posed trouble if Huang had pounced on her own 15-17 recovery from 11-17 down. But as is her wont, Tanvi simply sent down a cross smash to pull away again and take the opener. If Tanvi had been nervous in finishing – Huang was even more in grabbing the lead, and served into the net herself.

● SWIFT REVERSAL

In a U-turn, FIFA scraps World Cup stake sale proposal; UEFA ‘loses confidence’

Reuters
August 1

UEFA SAID it had lost confidence in FIFA President Gianni Infantino on Saturday after world football's governing body abandoned plans to sell a stake in the commercial rights to the World Cup.

FIFA's proposal had triggered a fierce backlash from regional confederations who said they had been blindsided by Infantino's plans to raise up to \$4.2 billion by selling about a 20% stake to private investors in a new unit that would run FIFA events, including the World Cup.

“UEFA thanks all the fans, leagues, clubs, players, individuals, associations and confederations that opposed the scheme, alongside the many Prime Ministers, Heads of State and commentators who have demonstrated to the FIFA President that football is not for sale,” it said in a statement.

“We cannot keep going on like this with secret schemes on fast-track timescales, cooked up by faceless individuals and of dubious benefit to the game. We must identify those responsible and hold them to account.” The backlash raised questions about Infantino's political capital as he prepares to seek another term in office.

“On both these promises, he has failed to deliver. The shabby, back-room, opaque deal he hatched and tried to force through was anything but transparent,” UEFA added.

“And with reserves standing at over \$5 billion, he has also failed to use associations' money for the benefit of the game. UEFA will begin work immediately with partners and stakeholders all over the world and right across the game to propose a new way of distributing resources through the existing FIFA Forward programme.”

FIFA and Infantino declined to comment on UEFA's statement.



FIFA president Gianni Infantino had earlier announced plans to sell a stake in the commercial rights to the World Cup. REUTERS

The controversy comes at an awkward moment for Infantino, who said in April he intends to seek re-election for a fourth term as FIFA president.

UEFA reminded Infantino about the promises he made when he was elected FIFA president in 2016 — vowing to work with transparency and saying FIFA's money belonged to the national associations.

Infantino's plan, announced on Tuesday, quickly ran into a storm of opposition from regional confederations, who complained they had not been consulted on a move that could alter the commercial structure of world football.

Following the backlash, Infantino said world soccer's governing body had abandoned the plans after listening “carefully to all the views”.

The controversy comes at an awkward moment for Infantino, who said in April he intends to seek re-election for a fourth term as FIFA president.

Since taking over from Sepp Blatter in 2016, he has been re-elected unopposed twice.



‘I let Naseer direct himself’

Gurvinder Singh on reimagining Ajeet Cour’s short stories for his latest directorial *Refimat* and working with Naseeruddin Shah

AliAkbar Baldiwala’s community learning



ETERNAL CITY (From left) A glimpse of Harmandir Sahib; an aerial view of the city centre; inside Harmandir Sahib

FINDING Amritsar

Tracing the city that’s home to one of the most notable places of pilgrimage, Amritsar unravels as a place that was built to be a refuge for all — before it became an epicentre for all of Punjab. After four centuries and a half, this is its story

Vernika Awal

TIME, WITHIN the old walled city of Amritsar, feels like something you can almost put your hand on. The weight of eras gone by have settled down upon the peeled plasters on the walls of *havelis* — which even today carry a faint trace of grander days they have once seen. Look above, and you can’t find the open sky, only a series of ornate, carved balconies that sag under the weight of their centuries.

I walked through carefully but with intent, amid faded frescoes peeled gently in the damp morning air, and heavy wooden doors that remained firmly shut — as if guarding memories that no one had opened in decades.

Somewhere nearby, a ladle struck the rim of a large iron *kadhai* with a ringing clang. The air carried the scent of hot jalebis twisting in bubbling sugar syrup, and the comforting warmth of kadah prashad.

A restless *bheed* surged past me at what would anywhere else be a deserted, unwise hour to wander out. Around the Harmandir Sahib area — what the Golden Temple is formally called — even at 4 am, there is frantic urgency, as if the city had forgotten how to slow down. High above, *shabads* (prayer ballads) from the *gurbani* echoed around slivers of an overcast sky. As I caught my first glimpse of the gurdwara’s facade, the alleyways rang with a *shabad* around the promenade: “*Amrit vela sach nao, vadiae vee-char*.” When the world is quiet and your mind is open, remember the truth that endured — let reflection of the divine show you the way.

Just as night slowly surrendered to light, there may perhaps be no greater way to gauge Amritsar’s story, than this epiphany.

The fifth century

Next year, Amritsar, named after the *amrit sarovar* (the holy pond), turns 450 but celebrations have already begun. Founded in 1577 by Guru Ram Das, the fourth Sikh Guru as Chakk Ram Das or Ramdaspora, it is one of the few Indian cities whose birth was rooted not in conquest, commerce or colonial ambition but in ideals of equality, community and service.

“Amritsar was envisioned as a sanctuary that embraced all, indifferent to gender, faith, or caste,” says Tarundeep Singh Ghuman, a local storyteller and an expert in the city’s history. “It was a city crafted specifically to welcome those who found no refuge anywhere else. They recognised only human merit, kindness and grace,” he says.

Over the years, Amritsar evolved as a place of commerce, an area of interest for the royals, and even one of historical importance during Partition. Amritsar, in the 19th century, was the summer capital of Maharaja Ranjit Singh. A century prior, the city was plundered and ransacked by an Afghan invasion — and was gradually rebuilt by devotees who survived the invasion.

Today, the ethos of the city’s origins combine all of this history. Remnants of each of these are then found in the way the city



SIMRANJIT RANA



VERNIKA AWAL

ATASTE THAT LASTS FOREVER (Left) In the communal kitchen; the famous Amritsari kulcha

sleeps, remembers and celebrates. Around the Golden Temple, walk up at any hour of the night and on any day of any year, strangers find themselves a quiet corner to lie down for a few hours. Divides, even today, disappear both inside the city’s epicentre and outside — inside the gurdwara’s *langar* (community meal) kitchen, men and women from all walks of life devote themselves to public service or *seva*. In Amritsar, this is no narrative or occasion — it is a way of life.

Remembrance in rebuild

Photographs still accessible in the open, most of all in the Partition Museum that’s within the vicinity, show how until even as recently as the previous century, homes of families opened right at the edge of the pond surrounding the Golden Temple. The goal, as it stands true even today, was not to showcase the gurdwara as an elusive sight — but as one where pilgrims and residents alike came by, in happiness and melancholy.

Manjit Singh, a retired professor of planning and architecture from Guru Ramdas School of Planning at Guru Nanak Dev University, said that a key facet of Amritsar was that it was rebuilt across eras, as it withstood invasions over time — from Shah Jahan in the Mughal era, to the tragedy of Jallianwala Bagh massacre by Reginald Dyer during the

British colonial brutality. “While most cities naturally grow, decline and die like living organisms, certain cities endure permanently due to their profound contributions to human thought,” says Singh. “Despite being destroyed multiple times, Amritsar has earned its status as an immortal city.”

One of the most recent examples of this rebuild is as recently as October 2016, when the government of Punjab built the area around the Golden Temple as ‘Heritage Street’, with the goal of organised shops, better cleanliness, less chaotic driveways and a multi-level parking tower for cars.

But, the city still remembers its past in ways that one least expects. For instance, in one of the walking alleyways in Katra Ahluwalia, I stumbled across a renovated *haveli* — just as its neighbour looked weathered and wary.

Beneath the present moment, another Amritsar breathed along, quietly. Standing in those lanes, it was impossible not to imagine a softer, sepia-toned past layered beneath the chaos. These same *havelis* must once have echoed with laughter that spilled into open courtyards. Women leaning over *jharokhas* to exchange gossip with neighbours across balconies; children racing through the lanes without a care.

Even though modernism has caught up in various ways, the old story of Amritsar has refused to fade. Ask any historian studying Partition, and they will tell you that Amritsar and Lahore are twin cities — reflections of one another separated by a border that arrived much later. Separated by only a few kilometres and a line that altered countless lives, the Amritsar today still makes its history felt beneath the everyday bustle. It’s as if the city itself remembers a time when the road ahead did not stop at the border.

“Despite all the invasions, rapid urbanisation and Partition, one can still read the layers of history in Amritsar. In fact, even Partition can be read — not just by what is

present, but also by what is absent. For instance, during the riots in Amritsar’s walled city, large areas were burned, pulled down and redeveloped. When you see parts of the old town where redevelopment took place, you know that those structures belong to a later time,” says Gurmeet Sangha Rai, heritage conservationist and architect.

Beyond the architecture

Rai underlines how even today, the city continues to be home to houses from different times in history — starting with basic urban planning. “If you see the meandering roads, you know that in most of our historic cities, the plan or footprint is still historic. What is significantly altered in many cases is the vertical, third dimension. Only when you build large plazas do you bulldoze buildings and streets to consolidate, leading to a loss of the historic cityscape,” says Rai.

The evolution of a cityscape, however, is inevitable. As population grows, Amritsar, too, is today home to high-rise five-star hotels, flyover bridges and glass-faced austere office buildings. While much of this evolution has continued to retain Amritsar’s spirit of *nimrata* (oneness), conservation of Amritsar’s rich, diverse past is today trying to save what’s left of the city to document. Ghuman, on this note, says that governmental interventions of conservation cannot preserve heritage by themselves. “A city’s true heritage lies in its stories, crafts, languages, music, food, relationships and festivals. If traditional artisans were to disappear tomorrow, only to be replaced by

generic commercial outlets, there would no longer be much left for the youth of tomorrow to connect with their city’s values,” he says, “The heritage of a city survives not because its walls are preserved, but because its values continue to be lived. Intangible heritage like the *gurbani kirtan*, local crafts, literary history and food give meaning and experience to visitors, too.”

In Amritsar, food is not merely sustenance. The signs of faith adorn the walls of most places, who do not skimp in their generosity to feed whoever comes to seek a morsel. In one stretch, generational businesses sell kulche, and only a few feet away, lassi and jalebi take over the glass counters. At each of these stores, sellers smile with a faint familiarity — as if no one here is a stranger. Perhaps, that is why leaving Amritsar always carries a faint ache. The city continues to stand today not just as one of Punjab’s most important strategic and economic hubs, but in an underlying familiarity that beckons its people to return.

Efforts to conserve the city’s evolution and cultural significance has today led to socio-cultural festivals such as Agla Varka and Sacred Amritsar — places where literary history, music and local crafts are finding voices of revival to cling to. It’s a rare feat for a grand old city to be a crucial hub of commerce without losing its significance in history and culture. As Singh says, “Amritsar is a major hub for tourism yet it retains its immortal character.”

Vernika Awal is a Delhi-based food and lifestyle writer

It’s a rare feat for a grand old city to be a crucial hub of commerce without losing its cultural and historical significance

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Women the World Forgot

Why Nadia Hashimi hopes that her new novel, *City of Widows*, will evoke outrage

Aishwarya Khosla

NADIA HASHIMI’S new novel, *City of Widows*, opens in the precarious years before the 2021 Taliban takeover, back when Afghan women were still soldiers, journalists, and pursuing an array of professions. Hashimi evokes that bygone world to show us exactly what was lost. The book, a story of resistance, grips one by the cuff, plunging the reader into a relentless sequence of events that never loosens its hold. Its fascinating title comes from a real settlement on a hillside outside Kabul known as Zanabad, which literally translates to ‘city of women’ but is referred to as ‘hill of widows’ in Afghanistan. Hoping to escape the stigma, widows started inhabiting the hills in the ’90s, forming a tightly knit community where they could eke out independence, as per a 2017 *AFP* report. Hashimi says she would never have thought that she would one day write the sequel to *The Pearl That Broke Its Shell* (2014), her internationally acclaimed debut, which just goes on to prove ‘never say never’. She was inspired to write this story when she came across an article about Afghan women soldiers, one of whom said, “If I die tonight, I die pretty.” It was that *AFP* article that planted the seed for Hashimi’s novel. “I don’t actually know how I first came about it, but I did find an article,” she told *The Indian Express*. “And this is where a lot of my stories come from — these journalistic pieces where there’s either a line in a piece of journalism or an introduction to something. Whenever I find something that surprises me, I feel like that’s where the story is going.”

City of Widows follows three women. Marjan, a former soldier in the Afghan army, is on the run with her young daughter Hawa, desperate to escape before the Taliban discovers her past. In her earlier life, she was Rahima, a *bacha posh* — a girl raised as a boy — forced into an early marriage from which she fled. Soraya, who defiantly wore red lipstick as she led the army’s all-female combat unit, is now a wanted woman whose own brother may not shelter her. Mina, a journalist and broadcaster, is known to everyone in Kabul, including the new regime.

Hashimi, a paediatrician-turned-novelist and the daughter of Afghan immigrants, conducted in-depth interviews to flesh out her protagonists. She spoke to a commander of the Female Tactical Platoon, a musician who conducted the Zohra Orchestra, and a woman who runs shelters for the vulnerable. “I always try to be authentic when it comes to these social aspects within the country,” she said. “There are so many misrepresentations and stereotypes that are opposite of what these women are actually experiencing.”

The *bacha posh* tradition, central to Marjan’s backstory, reveals everything about Afghanistan’s relationship with gender. “It reveals the difference in the value placed on a son and a daughter,” Hashimi said. Families engage in the practice either from superstition — believing the next child will be a boy — or “to logistically have a child who can navigate the outside world with a little bit more freedom and maybe with less risk.” She predicted that as women develop economic value, the practice would fade. “But with the Taliban coming back and making life impossible for girls, you can see where it would be really necessary to have a way to skirt around these rules.”

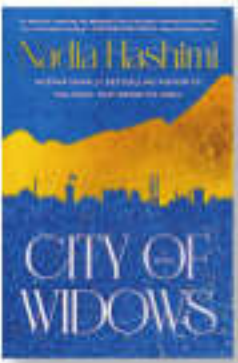
That sense of a world turning its back animates the novel. “It felt like the world overnight decided they did not want to care about Afghanistan anymore,” Hashimi said. “We had had 20 years of saying we must fight the Taliban in Afghanistan because we must liberate Afghan women. And then, overnight, it was like, ‘Well, actually, we are just kind of tired of doing this and we are going to turn our backs.’”

What makes *City of Widows* so powerful is that Hashimi refuses to reduce her characters to victims. The novel is occasionally terrifying and, at times, almost unbearable, because one cannot forget that the stakes are real and high.

Hashimi has taken a break from clinical medicine to write full-time. “Both my husband and I feel that these stories create some legacy, that there’s an empty space on the shelves for Afghan stories,” she said. “These are the stories that I would have wanted to read when I was young.”

She hopes that the novel will evoke outrage. “That there will be a degree of respect and recognition for the women who are fighting for themselves and have always been,” she said. “That there will be a bit of outrage over what is happening. That we are allowing this to happen, this egregious violation of human rights and the state of gender apartheid that is being created.”

City of Widows is not a light read and, at the end of the day, is a reminder that the women of Afghanistan are not voiceless. The world has, unfortunately, simply turned a deaf ear.



CITY OF WIDOWS

NADIA HASHIMI
William Morrow
HarperCollins USA
432 pages
₹599

Anil Sasi’s *The EV Evolution* cuts through the noise with a balanced, deeply reported account of India’s electric mobility transition

Ajay Srivastava

ELECTRIC VEHICLES have attracted an unusual amount of certainty for a technology still in flux. Governments promise an all-electric future, auto-makers make billion-dollar bets, climate advocates champion battery-powered transport, while consumers remain unsure whether to buy an EV, a hybrid or simply wait for the next breakthrough. In the middle of this noisy debate arrives *The EV Evolution*, a timely and unusually balanced book by Anil Sasi, National Business Editor at *The Indian Express*.

This is not another cheerleading account of electric cars. Nor is it a sceptic’s manifesto. Instead, Sasi offers something rarer: a deeply reported, accessible guide to one of the biggest industrial transformations of our time, viewed through the lens of India.

That perspective matters. India is not Norway, where generous subsidies created the world’s highest EV penetration. Nor is it China, whose state-backed industrial strategy built globally dominant battery and EV manufacturers. India must navigate a different path — one constrained by income levels, infrastructure gaps, energy security concerns, manufacturing ambitions and geopolitical realities. Sasi understands that complexity, and resists the temptation to reduce it to simple slogans.

The book’s greatest strength is its breadth. It begins with the surprisingly rich history of India’s early electric-vehicle experiments before examining how Tesla transformed global expectations and how Chinese manufacturers rewrote the rules of competition. Along the way, readers encounter battery chemistry, charging infrastructure, hybrids, plug-in hybrids, autonomous driving, intelligent connected vehicles, battery supply chains, rare-earth dependence, industrial policy, employment, energy security and evolving regulations. Yet, despite covering so much ground, the book rarely feels overwhelming.

That is largely because Sasi writes like an experienced journalist rather than an engineer. Technical concepts are translated into plain English without being dumbed down. Policy debates are explained with clarity rather than ideology. The result is a book that welcomes general readers while offering enough depth to satisfy industry professionals



GETTY IMAGES

Making sense of India’s electric future

and policymakers.

One of Sasi’s recurring themes is uncertainty. Much of the public conversation assumes battery electric vehicles will inevitably dominate every market. *The EV Evolution* asks readers to slow down and examine the evidence. Hybrid vehicles are making a comeback in several advanced economies. Battery technologies continue to evolve rapidly. Charging infrastructure remains uneven. Consumer preferences are shifting. Software is becoming as important as hardware. None of these trends fits neatly into a single narrative of inevitable technological victory.

This willingness to embrace complexity gives the book unusual credibility. Sasi argues that India’s transition should remain technology-neutral and pragmatic rather than locking itself prematurely into one pathway. Given India’s dependence on imported critical minerals, the continued evolution of battery chemistry and the country’s unique dominance in two- and three-wheelers, he makes a persuasive case that flexibility may prove more valuable than ideological commitment.

POWERED BY ENERGY

When it comes to EVs, India must navigate a path constrained by income levels, infrastructure gaps and other factors

able than ideological commitment.

The writing remains refreshingly free of jargon. Sasi has the reporter’s instinct for anecdotes, memorable chapter titles and well-chosen examples.

If the book has one limitation, it is that its neutrality occasionally leaves readers wanting firmer conclusions. Sasi deliberately refuses to declare winners in the contest among battery electric vehicles, hybrids, plug-in hybrids and emerging technologies. His caution is intellectually honest — the technology landscape is evolving too quickly for sweeping predictions — but after over 200 pages, some readers may wish he had ventured into a clearer ranking of the most promising pathways for India over the next decade. The book excels at mapping possibilities more than prioritising them. That restraint is understandable, though it slightly tempers an otherwise authoritative narrative.

Still, that criticism is minor compared with what the book accomplishes. Few works on emerging technologies manage to remain simultaneously comprehensive, balanced and enjoyable to read. Fewer still avoid becoming obsolete almost as soon as they are published. By focusing on the forces shaping

the transition rather than merely today’s products, Sasi gives *The EV Evolution* a durability that many technology books lack.

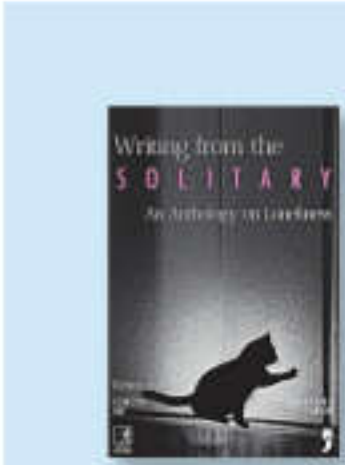
For policymakers, it offers a thoughtful framework for evaluating industrial strategy. For business leaders, it provides a clear understanding of the competitive landscape. For students and researchers, it serves as an excellent primer. And for ordinary readers trying to decide whether the future belongs to batteries, hybrids, hydrogen or something yet to emerge, it offers the rare gift of informed clarity without false certainty.

Electric mobility is often presented as a destination. Sasi reminds us that it is, above all, a journey — and one whose route remains open. That insight alone makes *The EV Evolution* one of the most valuable books yet written on India’s automotive future. It is likely to become the standard reference for anyone seeking to understand not only where India’s EV revolution is headed but also why the road there may prove far more interesting than anyone expected.

Srivastava is founder, Global Trade Research Institute



THE EV EVOLUTION: THEN, NOW AND NEXT OF ELECTRIC VEHICLES
ANIL SASI
Hachette
248 pages
₹399



WRITING FROM THE SOLITARY — AN ANTHOLOGY ON LONELINESS
SEMEEN ALI, PRIYANKA SARKAR
Yoda Press.
Simon & Schuster India
176 pages
₹399

SHELF LIFE

In Praise of Solitude

WRITING FROM *the Solitary* — *An Anthology on Loneliness* reminds one of the lines that British novelist Olivia Laing wrote, “Loneliness is personal and it is also political. Loneliness is collective; it is a city. As to how to inhabit it, there are no rules and nor is there any need to feel shame...” Indeed, the Introduction by the editors, Priyanka Sarkar and Semeen Ali, mentions how the anthology is “a gathering of voices... they have stepped forward to take loneliness out of the shadows, to articulate it...”

It is this articulation that runs like a thread through an eclectic collection of essays, short fiction, conversations and poems, which are diverse in their substance as well as style. For instance, the essay by Sumana Roy, ‘Dying Alone’, sets the tone of acute observation about the lack of use of almost everything — furniture, food, crockery, towels — around her that living alone brings, and of how one lives alone and dies alone, “perhaps because I’m alone here.”

Poet Mani Rao describes the feeling of being alone in ‘The Large House’, even when you are in a group or with a family: “In such a large house/ don’t you feel/ lonely?/ ...family/ is exactly/ a large house/ Each person a big room/ Each unique room incompatible with every other...”

Arunava Sinha’s translation of *Maradona* by Kamal Chakraborty: “The wind — food — their feathers flying,” and the poems in ‘The Birdwatcher’ by Nitoo Das, “Ceaseless beginnings flat like the

verdigris/ light on the flycatcher and the slate/ bait of the parakeet...” offer other perspectives of loneliness — of questioning and differentiating between a performance versus the truth. Bhaswati Ghosh’s essay, ‘The Mysterious Gifts of a Fake Snake’, on the other hand, describes loneliness as a snake that had her mind in its grip. She talks about the constant anxiety it caused in her life, until she travelled for a writing fellowship, and how the solitude there finally led her to accept and confront the fear.

While lack of space prevents one from mentioning more selections from the anthology, an important perspective is offered by the conversation between Jeet Thayil and Nilanjana S Roy in ‘The Pleasures of Solitude’. It brings out the importance of solitude, which is different from loneliness, for a writer. As Thayil mentions, “...what we do sit alone in a room for hours...that kind of solitude is not just necessary but essential for the kind of work a book involves.”

Nabina Das’ essay, ‘Lonelitude and Love: Building Castles in Moonlight’, also describes how “the loneliness of writing is as much or more overpowering than the loneliness of love, and empowering in equal measure.”

In today’s day and age, when connection is increasingly being replaced by screen time, and loneliness is reaching epidemic proportions, this anthology is important in the multifaceted views it offers on this phenomenon. Most importantly, perhaps, is the acceptance of the fact that it is a part of each of our lives, an observation made by Suryakant Tripathi ‘Nirala’ in his poem, ‘Main Akela’, translated by Ruth Vanita in the anthology: “I, alone,/ See approaching the evening of my day.../ I know I’ve crossed the rivers and streams/ I had to cross./ Laughing, I see, No boat remains.”

JONAKI RAY
(Ray is a New Delhi-based poet, writer and editor)

A Walk On Delhi’s Wild Side

By encouraging us to rediscover nature in the cracks of an expanding metropolis, *Wild Capital* makes a compelling case for reclaiming our own capacity for coexistence with nature

Kaushik Das Gupta

PEOPLE WHO love Delhi often cherish very different versions of the city. For some, its cosmopolitan character and rich mosaic of languages and cultures is the greatest attraction. Others are charmed by Delhi’s extraordinary historical legacy, where the remnants of successive empires coexist with the institutions of a modern Republic. For many, the city’s commercial dynamism and promise of opportunity and a better life remain its defining appeal. And then, there is Delhi’s unique status as the nation’s political and administrative capital, where the country’s most consequential decisions are made and where power, policy and public debate converge.

In *Wild Capital: Discovering Nature in Delhi*, however, naturalist Neha Sinha in-

vites readers to discover another Delhi. Hers is a city inhabited not only by people of diverse cultures and communities but also by towering semal and vajradanti trees, amaltas blossoms, kites circling above Old Delhi, golden jackals slipping through the Ridge after dusk, nilgai wandering the city’s fringes, migratory birds returning to its wetlands and countless insects, frogs, reptiles and plants that have adapted to an intensely urban landscape. It is the Delhi of the Aravalli, where the Yamuna is not dead and where nature may seem to have retreated before the concrete but continues to endure and improvise alongside human life.

The book is, in more ways than one, the naturalist’s tribute to the city in which she grew up. As a child, Sinha found comfort not in dolls or toys but in the garden at her



GETTY IMAGES

WATCH ‘EM BLOOM

Semal trees in the Capital

home — an intimate observation station where she marvelled at the ways of insects, watched birds build nests and learnt to distinguish seasons by the flowers of trees. It was shaded by trees, all of whose names she did not yet know. For the budding conservationist, this patch of green nurtured a habit of patient observation and an instinctive curiosity about the living world.

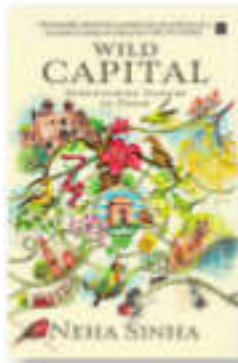
Nature also became the medium through which Sinha forged friendships

that transcended social boundaries. With her friend Shakuntala, she spent carefree afternoons racing to gather fruits that were often more enticing than delicious. Recalled with quiet tenderness, her account of the friendship is a meditation on the unequal trajectories of childhood, where nature offered a shared space of joy even as the realities of the world imposed very different futures on the two youngsters.

Like Shakuntala, several of the places and landscapes of Sinha’s childhood have lost their ebullience. Wetlands have shrunk, old trees have been felled and the city’s natural rhythms have been disrupted by relentless urbanisation. However, nowhere does Sinha betray any sense of lament. Instead, *Wild Capital* nudges readers to recognise that nature has not disappeared altogether — it has become less visible, more fragmented and more vulnerable. “How do we save these bewildering places?” Sinha asks. The first thing to do is to pay attention to plants and water, even on a small scale. And as her interlocutors tell her, some species do make their way out of apathy. The naturalist also suggests simple things that can help. Instead of manicured lawns with thirsty grasses, one can grow native species of the

city. This faith in nature’s resilience runs through *Wild Capital*. For Sinha, the natural world is also a source of moral insight. As she observes: “I have found in gardens and forests an order that’s missing in human society: The capacity to feel challenged by physical difficulties, yet never feel oppressed.”

Speed, productivity and constant growth are today seen as hallmarks of urban society. *Wild Capital* alerts us to another reality: Trees mature over decades, rivers carve their pathways over millennia, and seasonal cycles remind us that periods of dormancy are as essential as periods of growth. A forest may not be efficient in the industrial sense, yet its diversity and interconnectedness allow it to weather shocks and withstand stresses. By inviting readers to look more closely at the life that persists around them, Sinha reminds us that conservation need not always be about ambitious policies. Protecting the astonishing riches of the natural world could actually begin with the simple act of paying attention. By encouraging us to rediscover the wild that persists in the cracks of an expanding metropolis, *Wild Capital* makes a gentle yet compelling case for reclaiming our own capacity for coexistence with nature.



WILD CAPITAL: DISCOVERING NATURE IN DELHI
NEHA SINHA
HarperCollins India
320 pages
₹799

It can be a woman's world

As *Omkara* completes 20 years, a look at how Vishal Bhardwaj turned the story into a searing commentary on patriarchy



SHIFTING NARRATIVES
A still from *Omkara*

Anas Arif

AMONG VISHAL Bhardwaj's reimaginings of Shakespearean tragedies, *Maqbool* (2003), perhaps, remains the trilogy's boldest reinvention and *Haider* (2014) its most searingly political work. But for me, Bhardwaj's Moor of Meerut, *Omkara* (2006) will always be the most cerebral and dramatically volatile. In Bhardwaj's earthy reimagining of *Othello*, Venice gives way to the dust and violence of Uttar Pradesh, plunging audiences, for the first time in mainstream Bollywood, into the Hindi heartland in all its grime and glory. *Omkara* walked, so that the likes of *Gangs of Wasseypur* (2012), *Mirzapur* (2018) could run. However, what truly makes *Omkara* the film it is are its women. In a world inhabited by men, and governed by their appetites, egos and insecurities, the women become its moral centre. *Omkara* is a story of the tragedies that marriages become under patriarchy. Dolly (Kareena Kapoor), Indu (Konkona Sen Sharma) and Billo (Bipasha Basu) are written with a depth that far exceeds their Shakespearean counterparts. Through them, Bhardwaj arrives at a simple realisation: Shakespeare's men are vain, vile and dumb, and his women are condemned to inherit their violence.

At the outset, Bhardwaj tells us how Dolly will be seen. Her father warns Omkara (Ajay Devgn): "May you never forget the two-faced monster a woman can be." We see two Dollys: one through Omkara's eyes — elusive and inscrutable — and the other, innocent, free of his gaze. She sways between the two images for the rest of the film; between her own truth and the fiction men spun about her. Bhardwaj reaches his most profound register when he frames Dolly through the figure of Sita. Much like Sita, who was compelled to prove her chastity to Ram, Dolly, too, is condemned to prove her innocence. It is an intriguing invocation of mythology, one that reveals how marriages are so often built upon the insecurities of men. The idea finds its most vivid expression in a plot point revolving around a *kamarband*.

When Dolly misplaces the heirloom gifted to her by Omkara, the loss threatens to become an affront to the husband's honour, suggesting a failure to command his own household. Bhardwaj reveals how little it takes for patriarchy to unravel. A missing *kamarband* is enough for Omkara to put Dolly's fidelity on trial. Very much like Dolly, Billo, too, yearns for the comfort that the institution of marriage promises. She, too, is a woman of contradictions, her public persona forever at odds with the life she inhabits in private. As the audacious performer, she commands every gaze in the room but in private, it is her breath that is held by Kesu (Vivek Oberoi). Then there is Indu, the film's fiercest woman. Bound within the conventions of a traditional marriage to Langda (Saif Ali Khan), she is, paradoxically, the freest soul in *Omkara*. She fears no man. Not her husband, not her brother. Time and again, she emerges as the film's moral conscience, nowhere more powerfully than when she holds a mirror to Omkara and reminds him that no matter how much a woman loves, sacrifices, or endures, men inevitably find a way to put her character on trial. Bhardwaj's most radical departure from Shakespeare arrives in the film's final act, where he lets Indu reclaim the story. By killing Langda, in a moment that invokes the imagery of Durga, she does not simply avenge Dolly, she restores a measure of justice to a world corrupted by masculine vanity. Shakespeare might have called it a tragedy. Bhardwaj knows it is simply patriarchy.

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'Short stories excite me more than novels'

Alaka Sahani

SET IN present-day Punjab, Gurvinder Singh's *Rehmat* weaves together three short stories by Punjabi writer Ajeet Cour into a single cinematic narrative. In *Rehmat*, meaning compassion, a woman secretly shelters a wounded stranger in her home while his family grapples with grief and difficult choices. Elsewhere, a mysterious elderly man arrives in a village claiming to be God. In its exploration of human resilience, faith and compassion, the film addresses the issue of migration that continues to shape the region.

One of India's leading contemporary filmmakers, Singh has previously made critically acclaimed films such as *Anhey*

With non-professional actors, I never conduct conventional auditions. I simply ask them to read the lines and observe their face and listen to their voice

Ghorhey Da Daan (2011), *Chauthi Koot* (2015) and *Adh Chanani Raat* (2022) — all of them drawn from literary works. In an exclusive conversation, the National Award-winning filmmaker discusses casting Naseeruddin Shah, adapting literature for the screen, his decision to reject background scores and finding the soul of *Rehmat*. Excerpts:

You have earlier adapted the writing of Waryam Singh Sandhu (*Chauthi Koot*), Gurdial Singh (*Anhey Ghorhey Da Daan*, *Adh Chanani Raat*) and now stories by Ajeet Cour. What draws you to literature?

Gurvinder Singh on reimagining Ajeet Cour's short stories for his latest directorial *Rehmat*, rejecting background scores, working with Suvinder Vicky and Naseeruddin Shah

Some years ago, when I met painter Arpana Caur, the daughter of Ajeet Cour, she said she was aware how difficult it was to raise money for independent projects and offered to fund the film based on her mother's work. That set everything in motion. I re-read all the stories by Ajeet Cour to see them from a fresh perspective and to also find links between the stories, both thematically and narrative-wise.

Rashid in the original story and the character of Rashid (essayed by Shah) in the film have nothing in common. Everything is reimagined, rewritten and recreated. Somehow, the short stories excite me more for adaptation than the novel.

When I directed *Sea of Lost Time* (2019) with Film and Television Institute of India (FTII), Pune, with acting students featuring in it, we picked 11 characters from Gabriel García Márquez's stories and brought them together in a new presentation. This is both a subversive and cerebral act.

You had previously worked with Suvinder Vicky in *Chauthi Koot* but this is the first time you are directing Naseeruddin Shah in a movie.

I had an outline for the film before developing the script. While thinking of Rashid, who is visiting his ancestral village from abroad, I kept imagining Naseer in this character. He isn't a Punjabi and he doesn't speak the language. But he is such a great actor that language would never be an obstacle for him.

During my first call to him, he said: 'I am definitely doing this film. I really don't need to read the script. But just out of curiosity, I want to see the script.' That is when I started



STRANGER PLACES
(Top) Naseeruddin Shah in *Rehmat*; filmmaker Gurvinder Singh

writing the script. So, Rashid was written with him in mind. That was new for me.

When I called Vicky, I told him it wasn't a big role but an important one. The moment he heard his scenes are with Naseeruddin Shah, he said 'yes'.

The cast of *Rehmat* also features non-professional actors. How do you handle them alongside the professionals?

Bringing professional and non-professional actors together is something I've done right from my first film. If I don't find a professional actor suitable for a role, I naturally turn to a non-professional.

I cast Jaswant Zafar, a poet, as a grieving father after failing to find anyone convincing. We did a script reading, and that was enough. With non-professional actors, I never conduct conventional auditions. I don't expect them to perform emotions in an artificial setting. I simply ask them to read the lines and observe their face and listen to their voice.

Do you do much hand-holding before the shoot?

Before the shooting, my chief assistant usually rehearses with the actors. Once they present the scene to me, my involvement begins. I make adjustments, suggest changes and fine-tune it. Many filmmakers spend days discussing character psychology, motivations and backstories. None of that is particularly important to me. For me, the cinematic image comes first. I construct the shot, and the actors have to find their place within that image. The image is not created for the actor; it exists as a spatial and

temporal construct into which the actor fits.

Naseer put me completely at ease when he told me that all the great directors he had worked with had never really directed him. From then on, I simply let him direct himself, while offering inputs wherever necessary.

It is interesting how you have used classical music, which Rashid plays while relaxing, in *Rehmat*.

By putting a background score, you are basically using something external to help you create certain moments or ideas or emotions in a film. This time, there was a possibility of the music being woven into the script itself.

So, I used a group of women singing *bhajans* in the first part; a school prayer; and a girl who sings at the school function. I wanted Rashid to listen to music. For that, I chose songs of Ustad Nazakat Ali Khan and Ustad Salamat Ali Khan who, for me, represent the finest of the classical music tradition in Punjab.

Your previous features are currently not on streaming platforms. Are you planning to release *Rehmat* in theatres?

A theatrical release (of an independent movie) lasts for a week at most, perhaps two weeks on one or two screens. After that, the film has to find another life. Earlier, films were released on DVDs. You could buy a film and keep it with you for as long as the disc survived. That power has been taken away from us.

Now, everything depends on streaming platforms deciding whether to host your film and for how long. What was supposed to become a more democratic distribution channel for independent and low-budget cinema has, in some ways, created another struggle.

Perhaps, this time the platforms will be more interested in acquiring *Rehmat* because it has actors like Naseeruddin Shah and Suvinder Vicky.



MAKING ROOM FOR EVERY SOUND

(Above left) A still from the song *Shararat* from *Dhurandhar*; Madhubanti Bagchi

'AI is more annoying than unnerving'

Singer Madhubanti Bagchi on reimagining Usha Uthup's *Rambha* ho, issues with music labels and why AI leaves her unimpressed



Suanshu Khurana

THE DISTINCT identity of *Rambha* ho, Bappi Lahiri's riotous disco anthem pictured on the '80s actor Kalpana Iyer in *Armaan* (1981), has always been held by playback singer Usha Uthup's booming voice. So much so that, Uthup's theatrical swagger and distinct timbre remain etched in mass imagination. Almost half a century later, composer Shashwat Sachdev approached 37-year-old Madhubanti Bagchi to recreate the song for Aditya Dhar's *Dhurandhar*. Her first instinct was to say no. "With remakes, when the first version has worked so well, I don't think one is required to mess with it, unless you are thinking about something revolutionary or placing it in a new context,"

says 37-year-old Bagchi, who was equally uneasy about comparisons.

It was Sachdev's treatment of the song that changed her mind. His idea was to let the original and the new flow into each other, punctuated by gunshots on screen. "Shashwat is an impulsive composer and he lets you be in your element," says Bagchi, who recorded the song in her full-bodied voice two days before the grand music launch of *Dhurandhar* in a frantic studio. Bagchi says she managed to find enough room within the classic to sound like herself. But the ultimate validation for Bagchi came when Uthup approved. "I played her the song and she was very encouraging," says Bagchi, in a Zoom conversation from Mumbai.

While two songs in *Dhurandhar* — *Rambha* ho and *Shararat* (with Jasmine Sandlas), generated enough buzz, they also reaffirmed Bollywood's faith in Bagchi, who is increasingly being trusted with a variety of musical landscapes. Be it Amit Trivedi's chartbuster item song *Uyi amma* (*Azaad*,

2025), *Najariya ki maari* — the delicate classical thumri — in *Heeramandi* (2024) and the sultry *Aaj ki Raat* (*Street 2*), which won her a Filmfare Award or the breezy *Jab tak* in *Cocktail 2* (2026), Bagchi has shown a wide sonic range, slowly building a repertoire without clear categorisation.

Born and raised in north Bengal's Balurghat, Bagchi grew up in an academic household. Her father, a political science professor, later moved to Kolkata for work, determined that his daughter had access to better education and musical training. While Bagchi was learning classical music under vocalist Shubhra Guha, she did not like anything

about it. It took her two years to start enjoying it. Bagchi is glad she persisted. "I wouldn't have had the skill that I do now to navigate the film industry," she says. "My father learned classical music as a child, but like many middle-class families, he never saw music as a secure profession. Coming from a small town with no industry connections, it simply didn't seem like a viable career for me as well," says Bagchi, who did her engineering and worked in the tech industry before she realised that she was not cut out for the corporate life. She also began to audition for local composers and landed a multi-singer song by composer Neel Dutt. It took a

while before she got her next and the uncertainty was daunting. Her next, however, was *Egiye de* (2015), this time a duet with Arizeet Singh. In 2017, Bagchi moved to Mumbai, joining numerous others in pursuit of a Bollywood breakthrough. "I thought, what's the worst that could happen? I'd fail. I could return and do what I was doing," says Bagchi.

The move to Mumbai was a leap into the unknown. She began by sharing an apartment in Andheri with three people and initially survived by singing jingles. "The first slap on the face was that my entire month's expense in Kolkata was just the rent in Mumbai. But ads — for Cadbury, Maggi,

Royal Enfield among others — paid the bills," says Bagchi, who, despite being an introvert, didn't relent. What surprised Bagchi most about Mumbai was its generosity. In an industry often seen as fiercely competitive, she found people willing to pass along opportunities. That is how she met Sachdev and recorded a non-film song titled *Kahaniyaan*, followed by a thumri in *Uri: The Surgical Strike* (2019).

With a film inundated with more of the same songs, Bagchi says that businessmen are investing money and want their best payback. "They don't want self-expression on their money. They are not concerned that good art has to be produced for people to listen to it. A lot of mediocre and less than mediocre things have worked, and then the good composers are also forced to create that mediocre song because it has worked in the past," says Bagchi, who adds that the industry does not lack good composers or good songs. The question is if the labels even want to release them. "It is all about saleability," says Bagchi, whose rise has also come up at a time when AI is the buzzword in the world of music: to clone voices, even to create compositions. Bagchi, however, is largely unfazed by the AI debate. She dismisses AI as "stupid", arguing that while it may mimic a voice, it cannot recreate the emotion. "AI is more annoying than unnerving... It is unnecessarily being shoved down our throats. In my contracts, I have forbidden music companies from any kind of AI version or recreation," says Bagchi, who is gearing up for her upcoming India tour.

CHEF AT HOME

Heena Khandelwal

HOW OFTEN do you see men at ease, knowing where everything is in their house, what is running out and what needs to be consumed at the earliest? AliAkbar Baldiwala is, as his partner Damini once described him, “a domestic goddess.”

The two spend Mondays, their weekly offs, preparing the menu for the week, which is shared on WhatsApp as well as handwritten on a white board in their expansive kitchen, a rarity in Mumbai. Theirs is a 1 BHK, on the third floor of an old four-storey building in Mahim.

The 31-year-old head chef at Slink & Bardot, the Worli restaurant known for its “cuisine without borders”, stands over a pot of dal but it has nothing to do with tasting menus or covers. He is making Bohri dal-chawal palidu dish, earning it the moniker, DCP. He first had the dish at a mosque in Devlali in Nagpur, where he grew up.

“I was a religious boy who would go to mosques regularly. This meal meant com-

Baldiwala turned Slink & Bardot’s French identity into a global one with India-inspired flavours

munity dining. That is where I found the passion for service, for hospitality,” he says, before tipping *tur* dal into a pot with salt and a little turmeric before boiling it. Some households cook the dal down to 70-80 per cent, layering it with rice like biryani and putting it on dum to make dal pulao. At home, he keeps it simpler.

The broth that comes off the dal becomes palidu — tempered with *ghee*, *jeera*, *methi* seeds, curry leaves and *besan*, which acts like a roux, thickening the stock into a silky sauce. *Doodhi* (bottle gourd) and drumstick carry the flavour; tomato adds acidity; onion is the base. “There are no strong spices,” he says. “Just simple broth. What I really like about DCP is its simplicity.” Alongside it, he makes baingan bharta that behaves more like a cold salad — smoked eggplant, folded through with *dahi* and spring onion, finished with garlic, salt and pepper.

Food, for Baldiwala, has always been associated with place. His childhood

An Appetite for Home

Chef AliAkbar Baldiwala’s lessons in hospitality came from the shared palidu served in mosques



SANKHADEEP BANERJEE

ALL IN THE BROTH
AliAkbar Baldiwala at his Mahim home; DCP with baingan bharta salad and fryums

home was an old British-era theatre building. His father had converted the ground floor into a Chinese-restaurant — Ali Baba’s Den. The family lived on the first.

He was a shy child who felt trapped in a schooling system built for rote study. It made sense when he got diagnosed with ADHD as an adult. When a friend mentioned hotel management, he enrolled. He had been cooking since Class VII, initially out of necessity after his mother left home when he was 13. “My father would give me instructions on the phone for meal prep. He would come home and do the final *tadka*,” he recalls.

Post college, he worked with the Taj

group of hotels, before moving to the award-winning Masque and its catering wing, Sage and Saffron. The initial years were tough. He had two slip discs by 24. What followed was a series of resets: a sabbatical in Dubai to reconnect with his father who he hadn’t met for six years; return to India just as COVID hit. Two formative months at a permaculture guest house in Kamsket, a village in Maharashtra, where he rediscovered his appetite for cooking; some time off in Devlali, spent cooking for himself for the first time in his adult life. A now-shut food truck slinging *banh mi* and *katsu sando* out of Oshiwara (Mumbai). A pandemic-stalled restaurant

job in south Goa, where he met his partner Damini. And finally, Slink & Bardot. He inherited it as a ‘French’ restaurant but made it his own — one that boasts ‘global flavours with Indian inspiration’.

Baldiwala’s relationship with religion has moved as much as his kitchens, but the community and service culture of the mosque remains close to his heart.

To that, he wants to give a fuller stage. He wants to bring Bohri food into an *à la carte* restaurant. He did it at a pop-up at a now-shuttered Worli café. For now, it is more passion than an existing plan — much like the palidu on the stove: unhurried and instinctive.



DAL CHAWAL PALIDU RECIPE

INGREDIENTS

For the Dal Stock:

200 g toor dal, 5 g turmeric powder, 5 g salt, 1.2 litres water

For the palidu: 1.2 litres dal stock, 100 g besan, 200 g doodhi; 1 drumstick; 1 onion; 1 tomato; 30 g ginger-garlic-green chilli paste; 2 sprigs curry leaves; 7 g turmeric powder; 3 g red chilli powder; 2 g fenugreek seeds; 7 g cumin seeds; 4-5 kokum pieces, soaked; 100 ml ghee or oil, divided; Salt, to taste

For rice: 400 g basmati rice

METHOD

Prepare the dal stock

● Combine the toor dal, turmeric, salt and water in a heavy-bottomed pot. Cook until the dal is tender, it should be cooked through, not mushy. Strain and reserve the cooked dal and stock separately.

Make the palidu

● In a large pot, simmer the dal stock with the doodhi, drumstick and tomato until the vegetables are tender but retain their shape.

● Heat 60 ml ghee or oil in another heavy-

bottomed pot. Add the cumin, fenugreek and curry leaves. Once fragrant, add the onion and sauté. Add the ginger-garlic-green chilli paste and cook until the oil separates. Add the turmeric and red chilli powder, followed by the besan. Cook on low heat, stirring continuously, until the besan turns aromatic.

● Gradually whisk in the hot dal stock, one ladle at a time, ensuring no lumps form. Add the cooked vegetables and bring to a gentle boil. The palidu should be smooth and pourable, thicker than a broth but lighter than a curry. Now add the soaked kokum and simmer for 15-20 minutes. Finish with a *tadka*.

Prepare the chawal

● Cook the basmati rice using the absorption or steaming method.

TO SERVE

Layer the cooked toor dal over the rice and garnish with spring onion greens. Serve the hot palidu alongside the dal-topped rice. Garnish with coriander and serve with roasted/fried papad.



Neil Patil

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I walked out of Christopher Nolan’s *Odyssey* last week and did something I have never done after a movie before. I opened Google Maps. Not to check directions home as I always would, but rather to look up Voidokilia Beach. Then Favignana. Then Essaouira. Then a black sand promontory in southern Iceland I had never heard of called Hjørleifshöfði. Within twenty minutes of leaving the theatre, I had six tabs open and was pricing flights to places I hadn’t known existed two hours earlier.

That, I think, is the most remarkable thing Nolan has done with this film. Not the IMAX. Not the 91-day shoot. Not Matt Damon on a Viking longship. He’s made a \$250 million movie about a 3,000-year-old poem, and the thing it leaves you wanting to do most urgently is travel.

The Rule That Changed Everything

Here’s what sets *The Odyssey* apart from every other Hollywood epic. Nolan imposed a single rule on himself: no green screens, no digital environments, wherever it could possibly be avoided. If the story needed a beach, they found a beach. If it needed a volcano, they found a volcano. If it needed the underworld, they flew a thousand people to Iceland.

That meant the production travelled to six countries over six months. Morocco, Greece, Italy, Scotland, Iceland, and Malta, hunting down coastlines, castles, caves, and glaciers that could stand in for Homer’s ancient world without a single frame of CGI trickery. Nolan wanted audiences to feel like they were on the boat with Odysseus. And because everything on screen is real, real water, real stone, real light, you do.

The result is that every frame of *The Odyssey* is, accidentally or not, a travel advertisement. And every location is a place you can actually visit. Let me walk you through the map.

Morocco: Where Troy Burns

The film opens with the fall of Troy,

The Greatest Travel Film Ever Made Isn’t a Travel Film

and Nolan built his Troy at Ait Benhadou, a UNESCO World Heritage Site near Ouarzazate in Morocco. This 11th-century fortified village of red-earth towers has stood in for the ancient world so many times it probably has an agent. *Gladiator*, *Game of Thrones*, *Lawrence of Arabia*, *Prince of Persia*, they have all filmed here. Nolan added 60 temporary structures, including the pillared Temple of Athena and the city gates, covering 2.5 acres, and brought in 2,000 extras to recreate Troy’s destruction.

Then comes the Trojan Horse sequence, which Nolan had carried in his head for over two decades. He was briefly attached to Wolfgang Petersen’s *Troy* in the early 2000s before stepping away. He finally realised his version on the beaches of Essaouira, Morocco’s “Windy City” on the Atlantic coast. In Arabic, Essaouira means “little picture.” In IMAX, there’s nothing little about it. The same beach where Nolan buries his Trojan Horse is where Odysseus and his men set out for home, and the shot of the ships leaving the shore with the Moroccan coastline stretching behind them is one of the most beautiful departures I have seen on screen.

Essaouira is about three hours from Marrakech by road. It’s laidback, bohemian, famous for windsurfing and a medina that hasn’t been overrun yet. Ait Benhadou is roughly two hours southeast of Marrakech. Both are easy additions to any Morocco itinerary.

Greece: Where the Myth Lives

For the Cyclops sequence, Odysseus and his crew stumbling into Polyphemus’ cave, Nolan chose Nestor’s Cave in Messina, on the southwestern tip of the Peloponnese. The cave sits above Voidokilia Beach, a near-perfect horseshoe of golden sand and turquoise water that looks so symmetrical it seems engineered. It isn’t. It’s just Greece being Greece.

The production also filmed at Methoni Castle, a medieval Venetian fortress that juts into the sea, and at Acrocorinth, the ancient fortified acropolis above Corinth. These are not obscure ruins. They are monumental structures that have been standing for centuries, open to visitors, and somehow still not on most Indian travellers’ radar.

The nearest airport is Kalamata. Fly into Athens and drive the scenic three hours south, or catch a seasonal flight from Europe. May, June, and September are ideal, the light is extraordinary, and the crowds haven’t arrived.



Sicily: Where Odysseus Lives

This is the one that got me. Nolan chose Favignana, a small island off Sicily’s northwest coast, part of the Aegadian archipelago, as Ithaca, Odysseus’ home. Homer himself is believed to have based parts of the poem on this island, calling it “goat island” where Odysseus’ crew landed and barbecued goats.

On Favignana, Nolan used the ruined Castello di Santa Caterina atop Monte Santa Caterina as Odysseus’ palace, where Penelope and Telemachus hold out against the suitors. Nolan has said that when they climbed to the castle and saw the view, it simply felt like Odysseus’ home, even though it was, by his own admission, a deeply impractical location to film.

From mid-April to mid-May, the production moved to the Aeolian Islands, Lipari, Vulcano, and Basiluzzo, for the sequences set on Aeolia, the island of the wind god. Volcanic seascapes, smoking craters, and water so blue it looks artificial. Except it isn’t, because Nolan doesn’t do artificial.

Fly into Palermo or Trapani, catch a ferry to Favignana. For the Aeolians, the ferry runs from Milazzo, about two hours by train from Catania. These are popular Mediterranean summer destinations, but

outside July and August, they’re wonderfully uncrowded.

Iceland: Where the Dead Live

For the underworld, Book 11 of the *Odyssey*, where Odysseus consults the dead, Nolan chose Iceland. Specifically, the black sand plains and coastal rock formations around Hjørleifshöfði, a dramatic promontory on Iceland’s south coast. The filming took 12 days, involved a thousand people including 450 local extras, and was shot in June’s perpetual daylight, which Nolan used to create an eerie, timeless quality.

“I knew early I wanted the landscape of Iceland to portray Hades,” Nolan has said. “This journey north, further and further into the cold, couldn’t be further away from Odysseus’ home in Ithaca.”

He’s right. Watching the sequence, you feel the temperature drop. The black sand, the mist, the volcanic rock, it’s the visual opposite of everything warm and golden that came before. And it’s all real. No filters, no colour grading tricks. Iceland just looks like the underworld.

Scotland: The Quiet Surprise

The least expected location on the list. Nolan filmed on the Moray Firth coast in Aberdeenshire, using the ruins of Findlater Castle and nearby Culbin Forest for northern cliff-and-shore sequences.

Scotland’s grey light and rugged coastline gave the film a quality that Mediterranean locations alone couldn’t, a sense of cold, of danger, of being far from home.

What Nolan Proved

Here’s why I think this matters beyond the movie.

There’s a growing school of thought in Hollywood that you can build anything digitally. That locations don’t matter because pixels can replicate anything a camera can capture. And technically, that’s true. The technology exists. You could build Voidokilia Beach in a computer and most audiences wouldn’t know the difference.

But Nolan chose not to. He spent six months and \$250 million proving that real places have a quality that pixels don’t. A weight, a texture, an unpredictability that the human eye registers even when the conscious mind doesn’t. When Odysseus’ ship rolls on real Mediterranean waves with real wind filling real sails, you feel it in your body. When the black sand of Iceland stretches to the horizon with real mist rolling across it, something in you responds that no green screen can trigger.

That’s also the argument for travel itself. You can watch a 4K video of Essaouira on YouTube. You can scroll through a hundred photos of Voidokilia Beach on Instagram. But until you stand there, until the wind hits you, until the sand is under your feet, until the light changes in real time, you haven’t experienced it. Nolan knows this. It’s why he sent a thousand people to Iceland instead of building Iceland in a warehouse in a studio.

Real places are irreplaceable. That’s true in filmmaking. It’s true in travel. And *The Odyssey* is the most expensive, most spectacular proof of that idea anyone has ever produced.

Your Own Odyssey

The beautiful thing about Nolan’s location map is that it’s buildable as a trip. Morocco, Greece, and Sicily are all within a few hours of each other by air. You could do Marrakech to Essaouira to Ait Benhadou, fly to Kalamata for the Peloponnese coast, ferry to Sicily for Favignana and the Aeolians, and, if you are feeling ambitious, add Iceland as a standalone leg. Two weeks, six countries, and a journey that traces the oldest story ever told across the most beautiful locations on the Mediterranean.

I am already thinking about it. If you

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have watched the film, I suspect you are too... See you next week...

Know the Unknown

Ever since we launched flight bookings on Veena World, I have been falling down rabbit holes about the places planes take you. And this week, given the article, I couldn’t resist digging into Iceland.

Nolan chose Iceland for the underworld because it felt like another world. Here’s the thing: geologically, it is.

Keflavik International Airport, where every flight to Iceland lands, sits on the Reykjanes Peninsula. The Reykjanes Peninsula sits on the Mid-Atlantic Ridge. The Mid-Atlantic Ridge is the boundary where the North American and Eurasian tectonic plates are slowly pulling apart, at roughly 2.5 centimetres a year. Iceland is the only place on earth where this ridge, which otherwise runs along the floor of the Atlantic Ocean, rises above sea level. Which means when your plane touches down at Keflavik, you are landing on the seam between two continents.

It gets better. Twenty minutes from the airport, there is a small footbridge called the Bridge Between Continents. It spans a fissure in a lava field where the two plates are visibly splitting apart. You can walk from the North American plate to the Eurasian plate in about fifteen steps. One foot in America, one foot in Europe.

Nolan sent Odysseus to Iceland to visit the land of the dead. But the real story beneath his feet was even stranger: a country that is literally being pulled in two directions at once, creating new earth as it goes. Did you know this about Iceland?

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